

Babylon

How to Live When America Stops Being Christian

James Bell

LIVEWELL BY JAMES BELL

Build houses and live in them. Plant gardens and eat their produce... But seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile, and pray to the Lord on its behalf, for in its welfare you will find your welfare.

— Jeremiah 29:5, 7

Chapter 1: The Part of the Letter We Never Read

You've seen the verse. You just haven't seen where it lives.

"For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope." It's on the coffee mug and the graduation card. Somebody probably read it over you at a commencement. It might be the most quoted verse in the American church, and we've turned it into a private promise — that my dreams are about to land, that God is lining up good things with my name on them, on a schedule I'll live to see.

We pulled that off with a little quiet surgery. We cut the verse loose from the sentences around it, the ones nobody reads. And those sentences were written to people whose whole world had just burned to the ground.

So go back and read them. In 597 BC the armies of Babylon came for Jerusalem. The boy king Jehoiachin gave up after three months, and the winners did what winners did back then. They marched the best of the nation a thousand miles east — the king, the metalworkers, the soldiers, the families that mattered, ten thousand of them by the book of Kings — and left a puppet named Zedekiah behind to keep the peace. Ten years later the puppet got brave, bet on Egypt, and Babylon came back to finish the job. They starved the city until people ate things I won't write down. They burned the temple, the one place on earth God was supposed to live. They made the king watch them kill his sons, and then they put his eyes out, so that was the last thing he ever

saw.

Understand who these people were. They'd been told their whole lives that God would never let this happen. The temple was the guarantee. Zion couldn't fall. Now they're sitting in the ash of every promise they thought they understood, in a country that isn't theirs, surrounded by people who pray to other gods and have no reason to be kind.

That's who got the letter. The first wave, already hauled off in 597, grieving and lost and desperate to go home. That's who Jeremiah sat down and wrote to.

The plans verse is the eleventh line of that letter. We treat it as the headline. In the letter it's closer to a footnote, a bit of reassurance bolted onto the end of a much harder word. And the harder word is the one we've spent twenty-five centuries refusing to read. Because the first thing the letter does is take away the only hope the exiles wanted. There were prophets among them, men like Hananiah, telling the people exactly what their grief was begging to hear — that the nightmare was short, that inside two years God would break the yoke of Babylon and bring everyone home and set the furniture back where it stood. Jeremiah, speaking for the same God, called that a lie. He handed them a number instead. A number so cruel nobody selling comfort has ever wanted to say it out loud.

Seventy years. A lifetime. Most of you will die here. Your grandchildren will see Jerusalem. You won't. Settle in. This isn't a weekend and it isn't a detour. It's the rest of your life, and your children's lives, and you'd better learn how to live it.

And then, having taken away the fantasy of rescue, the letter does the shocking thing. It doesn't tell the exiles to fight. It doesn't tell them to disappear. It tells them to live. Here's what

God actually said, with none of the sanding we've done to it: "Build houses and live in them; plant gardens and eat their produce. Take wives and have sons and daughters; take wives for your sons, and give your daughters in marriage, that they may bear sons and daughters; multiply there, and do not decrease." And then the line that should stop the heart of anyone who's watched their country slide out from under them: "But seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile, and pray to the LORD on its behalf, for in its welfare you will find your welfare."

Build. Plant. Marry. Multiply. Seek. Pray. And behind the last two, holding them up, a command so total it doesn't need its own verse because it runs under all the rest: do not bow. Do not worship what they worship. Be the most present, most generous people in Babylon, and belong, all the way, to Someone else.

Read them together and count them, because the count matters. Six commands handed to a beaten people, and every one of them refuses the two things grief reaches for first. They aren't told to keep their bags packed and wait it out in protest. They aren't told to melt into Babylon and forget who they are. They're told to do the third and stranger thing: put down roots in the soil of the empire that ruined them, seek its good, and bow to none of its gods. That's the letter. That's the whole letter. And it's written, I'm going to spend this book arguing, to us.

I didn't always see it that way. For a long time I read Jeremiah 29 the way everybody reads it, as a nice private promise with an awkward history attached, and I preached it that way too, God help me, at more than one graduation. What changed came slow and came hard. It was the growing sense that the letter isn't describing my feelings. It's describing my address. It's written to a people who've lost a home they thought was permanent, who

are grieving a world that felt like the water they swam in, who are tempted by exactly two bad answers and are handed a third. That is not a metaphor for the American church. That's a description of it, close enough to be uncomfortable, and the discomfort is where wisdom starts.

Let me say it plainly, because the whole book depends on getting it right, and most of the American church still can't make itself say it out loud. For sixteen hundred years, and in this country for the better part of four centuries, Christianity had an arrangement we've come to call Christendom. The faith was the assumed water everyone swam in. Culturally established. Socially respectable. Woven so far into the civic furniture that you didn't have to believe much of anything to get carried along by it. That arrangement is over. It's not coming back in our lifetime or our children's. And what died with it was never Christianity. It was Christianity's scaffolding — the borrowed power, the easy respect, the vague civic warmth. The church has been weeping at the wrong funeral. We stood over the body of cultural Christianity as if it were the body of the church, and mistook the loss of our privileges for the loss of our God. We're exiles now, a moral and spiritual minority in a country that no longer shares our memory. And the sooner we quit waiting for the water to come rushing back, the sooner we can do the one thing the exiles were actually told to do, which is live, and live well, here.

We've been weeping at the wrong funeral. What died was not Christianity but Christendom, the scaffolding and not the building. We mistook the one for the other because we were told, for so long, that they were the same.

I can say this with a freedom I didn't earn and won't pretend to,

because I never swam in the water in the first place. I didn't grow up Christian. I came to Christ out of atheism, as a grown man, in the full daylight of a secular age, as exactly the kind of skeptic the hardest chapters of this book are written to reach. I've never once needed the culture to assume the faith on my behalf, because the culture I lived in assumed the opposite, and Jesus turned out to be enough anyway. That's not a small thing to say to a church in a panic. But I won't overplay the hand, because I've watched something happen in my own chest that I didn't expect. The longer I've pastored inside Christendom's ruins, the more I've caught myself missing a world I never actually lived in. Aching for a deference I was never owed. Wanting the room on my side the way it was for the generation before me. So I'm not writing this from above the grief. I'm writing it from inside a grief I have less right to than most people reading it, which is its own kind of rebuke, and I feel it.

Let me be honest about what a book like this can and can't do. A diagnosis, once you have it, is strangely useless. It tells you what happened. The water drained, the arrangement collapsed, the country moved on and isn't coming back to apologize. It does not tell you how to get out of bed on a Tuesday and be a Christian in the world that's left. And we've had plenty of diagnosis. The books, the conferences, the laments, the graphs about decline and the hand-wringing about the rising tide of the religiously unaffiliated. Much of it is true. Almost none of it helps, because a man who knows only that he's in exile knows only that he's lost. The letter is the cure for that particular paralysis, because the letter doesn't stop at you are in exile. It keeps going, out of the indicative and into the imperative. Into verbs. Into the unglamorous, load-bearing business of how an exile actually builds a life. This book is those verbs. It spends most of its length not proving we're in Babylon, which takes only a few

chapters, but learning, slow and concrete, how a faithful people lives there.

And the verbs turn on a single word, which is why the platform I write from carries the name it does. Seek the welfare of the city, God says, and in its welfare you'll find your welfare. The word translated welfare, both times, is the Hebrew shalom. And shalom is not the thin thing we've cut it down to. It's not quiet. It's not the absence of conflict. It's not a private calm you buy with a meditation app. It's wholeness. Flourishing. The way things are meant to be when they're finally right, a world stitched back together at every seam. Shalom is the city where the hungry are fed and the stranger is safe and the work is honest and the weak aren't crushed and the streets are at peace after dark. It's the shape of the world God intended before it broke, and the shape he's promised to put back. And God tells the exiles to seek that — not for Jerusalem, which is gone, but for Babylon, the empire that burned his temple and blinded their king. He tells them to work for the flourishing of the place that ruined them.

Then he does something that ought to take the breath away. He ties their own flourishing to it, so tight the two can't be pulled apart. In its welfare, he says, you'll find your welfare. In its shalom, your shalom. You won't find your wholeness by hoarding it behind a wall while the city outside rots. You won't find it by conquering the city, or fleeing it, or walling it out. You'll find it the only place it's ever been found, by spending it on the good of a city that isn't your home and never will be. This runs against every instinct a frightened minority has. The instinct says protect what's yours, circle the wagons, secure the remnant, and shalom will follow. God says the opposite. Pour yourselves out for the good of Babylon, and your own good is hidden inside Babylon's, and there's no other door to it. To live well, in the

sense that verse means, is to seek the life of a city that doesn't know you. That's why the platform is called what it is. Not live comfortably. Not live safely. Live well, in the full weight of shalom, which turns out to be inseparable from the welfare of everyone around you.

That sentence is the whole argument of this book in miniature, and it cuts against the two answers the church keeps reaching for — the same two answers the exiles were tempted by and Jeremiah forbade. There's the answer that wants to fight its way home, take the country back by force, grab the levers of culture and law and the state and crank the old Christendom back into place. And there's the answer that wants to stop being different at all, to file down every offensive edge of the faith until it dissolves into the surrounding culture and the ache of being a stranger finally goes away. One wants to conquer Babylon. The other wants to move in and change its name to home. I'm going to make the strongest case I can for both before I refuse either, because the pull of them is enormous, I feel both in myself, and a church that only sneers at the people caught in them hasn't understood the grief underneath.

Take the first answer, the one that wants the country back. It isn't held only by cynics and opportunists, whatever the caricature says. Underneath the worst of it there's very often a real love. A love of a country and an inheritance that genuinely gave people good things — schools that taught the children something true, neighborhoods where a door could be left open at night, a shared moral vocabulary that made a common life possible. And there's real grief at watching it dissolve, and real fear for the grandchildren who'll grow up in the ruins with none of it. Those loves are not nothing. A pastor who can't feel their weight has no business speaking to the people who carry them. But name the

thing at the root, because the root is rotten even where the grief is honest. The take-it-back answer believes the kingdom of God can be advanced by the sword of Caesar. And the moment it believes that, it's lost the ability to tell the two cities apart. It mistakes the nation for the kingdom. It baptizes a tribe. It produces a Christianity finally indistinguishable from a voting bloc with a worship band. You can win every election ever held with that faith and lose the one thing the church was ever sent into the world to keep.

Now take the second answer, the one that wants to stop being strange. It deserves better than a sneer too, because it almost always shows up as compassion and sometimes sincerely is. It's a desire to remove needless offense, to quit defending things that were never worth defending, to love the very people the church has too often wounded and driven off, to be done with a cruelty that was always a betrayal of the gospel it claimed to protect. Those instincts aren't all wrong. Some of what the accommodating church wants to shed genuinely deserved shedding. But name the root here too, with the same honesty. The give-it-up answer believes the church survives by agreeing with the world. And a church that agrees with the world about everything has nothing left to say to it and no reason on earth to exist. It'll be applauded all the way to its own empty buildings, because the world has never once needed a slightly more spiritual version of what it already believes. A faith that exists only to bless the going consensus dies the moment the consensus stops needing its blessing. And the consensus always stops needing it.

Look at what the two answers have in common, because it's the most important thing on these pages, and it's the thing neither can see about itself. Both are driven, underneath the bluster on

the one side and the compassion on the other, by the same fear. Strip them down and neither actually believes the faith can survive without the culture's backing. The one who reaches for power can't imagine a faithful church that isn't also a powerful one. The one who reaches for approval can't imagine a faithful church the culture despises. Different reaches. Identical terror. Both looked at the drained water and concluded, in their bones, that the church can't live without it. And both are wrong. The back half of this book is the proof, because there was a church before there was ever any water — a church born powerless and despised in the heart of a pagan empire, and it didn't merely survive there. It came alive there. It always has. The exiles were never offered either of the two answers. They were handed a third and harder thing, and this book is about that third thing: stay, and build, and bless, and stay entirely distinct, in a city they'd never control and were told to love anyway.

I won't pretend I stand outside any of this, because I don't, and the man who's felt only one of these pulls hasn't been honest with himself. There's a version of me that wants the old deference back, that misses being able to assume the room, that would gladly crank the water on again if someone showed me the valve. There's a version of me that wants the clever world's approval, that would love to be the kind of Christian the people who matter find reasonable and unembarrassing at a dinner party. And there's a third version, on the tired days, that wants only to pull my wife and my five sons behind a wall and let the whole burning city fend for itself. All three of those wants are the flesh dressed up as faithfulness. All three are the cultural Christian in me grieving his lost water. And the man who met Christ in the open sea, with no water under him and no culture holding him up, knows better than all three, because he knows the church was born with none of the things the three answers are frantic to get

back, and it converted an empire anyway, from the bottom of a prison, with nothing but its life.

Let me map the road, so you know where this goes. There are three movements. The first is diagnosis, and it's short, because it has to be, because diagnosis is the part the church has already overdosed on. We'll make the water visible — the sixteen hundred years of Christendom that ran from a Roman emperor's battlefield conversion to a few decades ago in America — so you can finally see the thing you've been swimming in. We'll watch the scaffolding come down in the actual numbers, and in the deeper change underneath them, the quiet move of the throne from God to the self that the sociologist Robert Bellah saw coming as early as 1985. We'll let the philosopher Charles Taylor name our condition for what it is, a secular age, not a world emptied of belief but a world where belief has become one contested option among many. And we'll look hard at the two, or really the three, bad answers, and see that they're secretly the same answer, and refuse them.

The second and longest movement is the letter itself, taken command by command, verb by verb, because the letter isn't a mood. It's a set of instructions, and instructions are meant to be obeyed, not admired. We'll sit with the seventy years until the number stops being cruel and starts being merciful, until we can tell the true prophet, who hands you a shovel, from the false one, who promises your old country by the weekend. Then we'll build houses and learn what it costs to put your weight down in a place, with the writer Wendell Berry as our witness against a nation of people who can't stay anywhere. We'll learn to live in the houses we build, to work in Babylon as people who know there's no such thing as secular labor, and to rest in Babylon as people who refuse to let the empire measure them by their

output. We'll plant gardens, which is to say we'll learn the long obedience Eugene Peterson wrote about, the willingness to plant slow things whose fruit we'll never taste. We'll eat the produce, because the God who sent his people into exile didn't send them into a joyless one. We'll take wives and raise children, and find that the home is the first and most durable outpost of the faith in any foreign land, the place where the next generation of exiles is either formed or forfeited, one kitchen table at a time. We'll seek the welfare of the city, and pray for it, and hold the hard line under all of it, which is that we do not bow.

The third movement is the great cloud of witnesses, the proof that this has been done before and can be done again. We'll stand with the church before the empire, the powerless and hunted minority that grew at something near forty percent a decade for three centuries, and ask with the sociologist Rodney Stark the only question that matters, which is why. The answer wasn't strategy and it wasn't cultural power, because they had none. They lived in a way the empire couldn't explain. They stayed to nurse the sick through plagues everyone else fled. They gathered up the infants the empire threw away. They sat slave and master at one table and called them brothers. We'll sit beside Augustine as he watches Rome fall in 410 and writes the book that should be the constitution of every Christian living after Christendom, the book that pries the City of God apart from the city of man with both hands and shows a panicked church that the burning empire was never the indestructible kingdom in the first place. And we'll end where the whole thing has been heading, with the recognition that the future of the American church doesn't belong to stronger tribes but to deeper disciples, and that these are not two flavors of one project but two roads running opposite directions, and that we are early, very early, in something long.

That last word is the one to carry out of this chapter, because everything going wrong in the church right now goes wrong because we're in a hurry, and the people of God were never meant to be in a hurry. You and I are not going to see the end of this. The recovery of a deep, faithful, post-Christendom church is not a project we'll complete or a problem we'll solve inside a program cycle or a campaign or a single lifetime. We're the early exiles. The early exiles planted gardens whose fruit fed people they'd never meet, and copied Scripture by candlelight through centuries whose dawn they didn't live to see. If we can't make our peace with that, we'll keep grabbing for the fast and ruinous answers, because the fast answers are finally just the answers of people who can't bear to wait. The man who learns to live well in exile is not a man who never felt the pull to go home. He's a man who heard the prophet say seventy years, and grieved it, and then picked up a shovel and planted a garden in the Babylonian dirt anyway, because that was what faithfulness looked like in the world as it actually was and not the world he wished he lived in. That's the whole vocation. And it's available to a church with no power at all, which is the only kind of church that has ever changed anything.

So let me hand you the letter, the way it was actually written — the hard word, the strange commands, and the buried promise that your welfare is hidden inside the welfare of a city you didn't choose. But we can't start with the commands, because the exiles couldn't start there either. We have to start where they started, with the grief, and with the honest work of admitting what's actually happened to the world that used to feel like home. And the first and hardest part of that work is the part the two young fish couldn't manage in the old story, the part about the water. You were swimming in something so long you stopped being able to see it. So long it stopped feeling like a culture at all and

simply felt like reality. Like air. Like the way things are. You can't learn to live after Christendom until you can see the Christendom you're living after. So before we build a single house, we have to make the water visible, and admit it's already drained away into the sand.

Chapter 2: The Water We Forgot Was There

The hardest part of being an exile is the moment you figure out that you are one. And it's hard because for a long time you don't feel exiled at all. You feel like something has gone wrong with the world. You feel like the country betrayed you. Like something you can't name crept in and stole the home you were standing in. Like the ground shifted while you slept. The grief shows up before the understanding does, and grief looks around for someone to blame. The schools. The courts. The other party. The young. It takes a long time, and a lot of honesty, to get to the truer and stranger diagnosis. Which is not that your home was stolen. It's that it was never quite your home the way you thought. You were swimming in water you had mistaken for air. The water drained. And now you're on the sand, gasping, certain the world is ending, when what actually ended is one arrangement of the world you had confused with the world itself.

There's an old story about fish that keeps getting told because it's true about a lot more than fish. Two young fish are swimming along, and an older fish passes them going the other way and nods and says, morning, boys, how's the water. The two young fish swim on a while, and eventually one looks over at the other and says, what is water. That's the whole problem with water, and it's the whole problem with what I'm about to describe. The fish can't see the water. It isn't one feature of the world the fish could point to and hold at arm's length. It's the medium. It's the given that everything else happens inside, the invisible condition of every move the fish will ever make, and because it's

everywhere it's nowhere in particular. Unnoticed. Unnamed. Assumed. American Christians spent so many generations swimming in a culture that was basically on their side that they stopped feeling it as a culture at all. It stopped feeling like an arrangement and started feeling like reality. It felt like the way things simply are.

So let me try to make the water visible. You can't learn to live after Christendom until you can see the Christendom you've been living inside. And to see it, you have to go back a lot further than the country you're grieving. All the way back to a bridge over a river outside Rome, and a man who saw something in the sky, or said he did, the morning before a battle.

For its first three hundred years the church had no political standing of any kind. None. It was an illegal assembly, a suspect and often hunted minority that met in borrowed houses and buried its dead in tunnels under the city. When a fire or a plague came, it got blamed for the anger of gods it refused to worship. No buildings of its own. No seat in any senate. No protection from any magistrate. It had martyrs. And then, on the twenty-eighth of October in the year 312, a Roman general named Constantine met his rival Maxentius at the Milvian Bridge on the northern approach to Rome, and he won, and he credited the victory to the God of the Christians, whose sign he claimed to have seen blazing above the sun. The next year, in 313, he issued from Milan an edict of toleration that ended the persecution and gave the faith a legal right to exist. Twelve years later, in 325, he summoned the bishops of the whole known church to a town called Nicaea, near his eastern capital, to settle what Christians would confess about the Son. And an emperor who had recently run a pagan state presided, in effect, over the writing of the creed. Then, inside a single human lifetime of that bridge, on the

twenty-seventh of February in the year 380, an emperor named Theodosius issued an edict from Thessalonica making the faith of Nicaea the official religion of the Roman state, outlawed the old pagan sacrifices, and the thing was done. The faith Rome had fed to lions had become the faith Rome enforced.

That's the hinge of Western history, and I want you to feel how fast it turned. Fewer than seventy years separate the edict that made it legal to be a Christian from the edict that made it official to be one. One old man, born under persecution, could have watched the whole reversal happen with his own eyes. And once it turned, it stayed turned, in one form or another, for sixteen hundred years. Through the collapse of the western empire and the long labor of the monasteries. Through the crowning of Charlemagne on Christmas Day in the year 800, when a pope set an imperial crown on a Frankish king and the marriage of throne and altar was sealed for the medieval world. Through the whole vast machinery of Christendom, in which to be European was to be baptized, and the calendar and the law and the university and the very shape of a life were assumed to be Christian all the way down. Through the fracture of the Reformation, which broke the unity but never questioned the arrangement, so that Geneva and Rome and Canterbury each kept the marriage of faith and civic order in its own way. And then across the sea, into the founding of a nation that promised, at last, to do the thing differently.

And America did do it differently, in the narrow legal sense, and we should be glad of it. I won't have you hear me sneer at it. There was no state church. No bishop on the public payroll, no crown enforcing a confession, no establishment of religion, and the First Amendment forbade Congress from ever making one. That disestablishment was a real good, and it was, in part, a Christian good. It was born of Baptists and dissenters who had

themselves been jailed and taxed by established churches and wanted no arm of the state ever again pressing a creed on a conscience. So don't mistake what I'm saying. The legal wall between church and state was not the enemy of the faith. In a lot of ways, it was its friend.

But what we built in the space that wall protected was subtler than a state church. In some ways stronger. And far harder to see, which is exactly why it fooled us. We built a cultural establishment without a legal one. The faith was woven so thoroughly into the civic furniture that no law was ever needed to enforce it, because the culture enforced it for free. The public schools opened the day in prayer and closed the week for a sabbath no statute required. The stores locked their doors on Sunday morning because everyone understood where a decent person was supposed to be. The politicians quoted the King James whether they'd ever read it or not, and ended their speeches asking God to bless the country, and meant, roughly, the God the audience meant, and nobody found it strange. The calendar itself bent around the Christian year, so the nation paused, together, at Christmas and near Easter, and a child grew up assuming the whole country breathed to a rhythm the church had set. A pastor was a respected man in town, not a suspicious one. Seated near the front at the civic dinner. Asked to open the meeting and bless the meal. And a person could be completely faithless, could believe nothing at all, could darken a church door only for weddings and funerals, and still be carried his whole life by a current that ran, unmistakably, in a Christian direction.

That current was the water. And the crucial thing about it, the thing that opens up everything that follows, is that the water held everyone up. The devout and the nominal and the outright unbeliever, all of them floated on the same buoyancy, and all of

them floated for free. You didn't have to believe much of anything to be lifted by it. That was the whole point. To be a broadly decent American and to be a vaguely Christian person had drifted so close to the same thing that a man could live his whole life and die without ever once having to tell them apart.

Now hear what the water did to us, because this is the wound, and it's a wound we can only examine now that the water has finally drained off it. The water taught us something it never once said out loud. It taught us that to be a Christian was to be central. To be normal. To be respectable. To be the home team, the majority, the ones who set the terms and expected the terms to hold. Over generations it formed in us a whole set of expectations that we quietly mistook for the faith itself. That the institutions would defer to us. That the culture would assume us, that our holidays would be everyone's holidays and our morality would be the default morality and our book would be the book even the unbelievers half-knew. That to be a believer meant, above all, to be an insider. Not a stranger. Never a stranger.

And I want to say, as plainly as I know how, that none of that is anywhere in the New Testament. Go and look. The documents that gave us our faith were written by and to a powerless minority scattered across a hostile empire. People with no cultural standing whatsoever, who met in secret and were slandered by their neighbors and had every institution of their world lined up against them. Peter writes to them as elect exiles of the dispersion. Paul writes from prison. The whole thing assumes a church on the underside of power. A church that persuades because it cannot compel. A church whose only argument is its own strange life. There isn't one line in it that promises the followers of a crucified Lord that they'll be the majority, or that the magistrate will bless them, or that the

culture will keep their calendar. Not one.

But all of it felt, to us, like Christianity. Every bit of the arrangement felt like the faith, because we had never once known the faith in any other condition. A fish raised in water can't imagine that water is optional. We'd swum in Christendom so long that we could no longer feel where the arrangement ended and the gospel began. And so we did the fatal thing, the thing this whole book is written to help us undo. We took the privileges of the arrangement and we quietly folded them into the gospel itself. We stitched the respectability and the centrality and the cultural deference into the very fabric of what we thought we believed, until the two couldn't be pulled apart, until they were one seamless garment in our hands. So when the privileges started to be stripped away, it didn't feel like losing a set of privileges. It felt like losing the gospel. It felt like the faith itself was being torn off our backs, because we had sewn the two together so tightly and so long ago that we'd genuinely forgotten they were ever two things.

We took the privileges of an arrangement and folded them into the gospel until we couldn't tell them apart. So when the culture pulled the privileges back, it felt for all the world like the culture was killing God.

I did this. I want to name it before I go on, because it's too easy to diagnose a whole church from a safe height, and I'm not standing at a safe height. I catch the folding in my own chest. I catch myself missing the deference I never earned. Resenting the loss of a centrality Christ never promised me. Feeling the withdrawal of the culture's assumption like it's a personal wound and not just the ordinary condition of every disciple who ever lived before Constantine, and every disciple who lives in most of

the world today. And the strange part, the part I've had to sit with, is that I didn't even grow up in the water. I came to Christ out of atheism, as a grown man, in the full daylight of an age that assumed the opposite of everything the water once assumed. I have less excuse than most for the nostalgia I still find in myself. And I find it anyway. Which tells me the water doesn't only form the people who swam in it. It forms the whole church that inherited it, so deeply that even a convert who never floated in it can grieve its draining. That's how total the arrangement was. That's how invisible.

You can watch the water drain in the numbers, and the numbers are not subtle. In the early 1970s, roughly one American in twenty told a survey taker he had no religion at all. One in twenty. A rounding error, a curiosity, a category so small it barely registered on the page. By the 2020s that figure was approaching one in three, and the people who check the box marked none had become the fastest growing religious group in the country. Larger than any denomination. Larger than a whole wing of the church. That's not a dip in a cycle. That's not the kind of thing that swings back when the mood improves. That's a whole category of human being who barely existed in your grandfather's America becoming one of the largest blocs in your children's. Whatever had been holding the old arrangement up stopped holding somewhere around the turn of this century. The fall since has been steep. There's no serious sign of it reversing. And a lot of the foolishness loose in the church right now comes from people who can't make themselves believe the water is not about to come rushing back through the door.

But a number like that hides the deeper change, and the deeper change isn't how many people left. It's what replaced the thing they left. The people who walked away from the church did not,

for the most part, walk into nothing. They walked into a different faith. One with no name over its door and no building on the corner. A faith so pervasive it doesn't look like a faith at all, which is the surest sign it's become the new water. The sociologist Robert Bellah saw it coming as early as 1985, in a book called *Habits of the Heart*, and he saw it in one person. A woman he interviewed and called, to protect her, Sheila. She described her religion to him in a few sentences that ought to be carved over the door of this whole era. She believed in God, she said. She was not a religious fanatic. She couldn't remember the last time she'd been to church. Her faith had carried her a long way. And it was her own faith, she said, her own little voice, and she gave it a name. She named it after herself. Sheilaism.

She had named her religion after herself, and Bellah understood at once that she was not a rebel. She was a prophet. She was the future, arriving early and speaking in an ordinary voice at an ordinary kitchen table. What she'd done, without malice and almost without noticing, was move the throne. The self had quietly become the highest authority, the final court of appeal, the one voice that could not be overruled. Everything else, the church included, had been demoted to a resource. Something you might consult on your way to deciding for yourself. The church was no longer the place you went to find the truth. It was one more shelf in the market of things that might or might not work for you, to be sampled and kept or tossed according to a verdict you alone would render. The therapeutic had replaced the confessional. The old question, is it true, the question that stands over you and demands your submission whether you like the answer or not, had been swapped for a smaller and more flattering one. Does it work for me. And a faith that makes demands, a faith that tells you to take up a cross and die, doesn't survive that question for long, because the whole nature of a

demand is that it doesn't bend to whether you find it convenient.

Charles Taylor gave this whole new condition its truest name. He called ours a secular age, and he spent the better part of a thousand pages making sure we understood what he did not mean by it. He did not mean a world emptied of belief, a world where the churches are all shut and no one prays. That is not the secular age. Plenty of people still believe. What Taylor meant is harder to escape. He meant a world where belief has become contestable. Where the faith that was once the unspoken floor under everyone's feet has become one option among many, and a disputed one at that. In the age of the water, faith was the default, the assumed given, the thing you'd have to work to disbelieve. In a secular age, faith is a position you take. And you take it knowing full well that the thoughtful people across the table have looked at the exact same evidence and landed somewhere else, and are not fools for it, and are not going to be argued back by the mere fact that you find your own position obvious. That's a wholly different kind of believing. It's believing without the buoyancy. It's faith in the open sea.

Lesslie Newbigin understood the shape of this before most of the church had any words for it, and he understood it because he'd crossed the world and come back. He spent close to forty years as a missionary in India, carrying the gospel to people who had never heard it. And when he finally came home to Britain he found something that unsettled him more than anything he'd met abroad. He found a country that had become a harder mission field than the one he'd left, and a church that didn't even know it had become a mission field at all. The West, he saw, was no longer pre-Christian. It was post-Christian, which is a different and lonelier kind of soil, because it's soil that has heard the seed and grown a crop and then let it wither. Soil that remembers. A

post-Christian culture holds the church in its memory the way a man holds a marriage he walked out of. Not nothing. Not neutral. But not the open expectancy of someone who has never heard the name. Newbigin's whole late work was a summons to the church to wake up and see the country it was actually standing in. To stop acting like the chaplain of a Christian civilization and start acting like a missionary in a strange land. Because the strange land was already here, and it was called home.

So we get, at last, to the diagnosis, stated plainly enough to build a book on. What is dying in America is not the Christian faith. It's cultural Christianity. The broad and shallow belief the water held up for free. The kind of faith that cost nothing precisely because the culture paid for it. The nominal churchgoing and the vague civic religion and the comfortable assumption that decent people were more or less Christian and Christian people were more or less decent. That faith was never converted. It was carried. It had no roots of its own because it never needed any, because the water did the work that roots are for. And you can't honestly mourn the loss of a faith that was only ever the buoyancy of the water. It was going to evaporate the moment the water did. It always was. It was the church's shadow thrown large across the wall of a culture that has now switched off the light. And a shadow is not a body. When the light goes out the shadow doesn't die, because it was never alive.

The real church is still standing in the drained room. That's the thing the panic can't see. The church with roots, the church that costs something, the church that was never the majority and never needed to be, the church that existed for three centuries with no water at all and converted an empire from underneath it — that church is exactly where it always was. Standing in the emptied room in the plain morning light. It's smaller than the

shadow made it look. Of course it is. The shadow was always larger than the body that cast it. But it is, for the first time in a very long time, unmistakably itself. No longer swollen by the crowds the water floated in. No longer padded by the nominal and the notional. No longer able to mistake the size of its cultural footprint for the depth of its actual life. And a church that can no longer count on the culture is a church about to find out what it actually believes, which is at once the most frightening thing that can happen to a people and the most clarifying. And, I've come to think, the most merciful.

We are not watching the death of the church. Let that be the verdict this chapter leaves in your hands. We are watching the end of the church's long holiday from being a minority. We are watching the water go back into the sand it came from. And we are learning, some of us slowly and some of us kicking, that we were never actually held up by it. That underneath the water the whole time there was rock. That the rock was there before the water rose and will be there long after it's gone. The only question left, and it's the question that will sort the faithful from the frightened in the years ahead, is what we'll do with the discovery. Whether we'll spend our one strength trying to flood the room again, cranking and pumping and grieving at the wrong graveside. Or whether we'll do the harder and holier thing, and turn, and look at the water we have left, and start at last to understand how quickly it went.

Because that's the part almost no one is ready for. It's not just that the water drained. It's how astonishingly fast it drained. Faster than any arrangement sixteen centuries in the making had any right to collapse. A leak that became a flood inside a single generation while the people standing in the room were still arguing about whether the floor was wet. That speed is its own

kind of revelation, and it's the next thing we have to face. So let me show you the day the scaffolding came down, and how few years it took, and why the very swiftness of the fall is telling us something about what was holding the thing up all along.

Chapter 3: The Day the Scaffolding Came Down

Ask ten Christians when it happened and you'll get ten different years. And each man names the year by what he personally lost. One will say 1962, when the Supreme Court took organized prayer out of the public schools in *Engel v. Vitale*, and a certain kind of believer felt, for the first time in his life, the cold draft of his own country telling him no. Another will say 1963, when the Court came back the next year and ended mandated Bible reading. Someone older points further back, to a thing he can't quite date, the slow disappearance of the world his grandmother used to describe. Someone younger points to an election. Or to one Sunday when he looked around the sanctuary he grew up in and understood that the young families were simply gone and were not coming back. Everyone has a year. Almost nobody has the same one.

They are all wrong. And they are all right. And the reason they can't agree is that they are all looking for a day. There was no day. What happened to the American church was not an execution. It was a slow leak. A draining so gradual that for decades you could stand in the room and feel the water going down around your ankles and tell yourself it was only a bad season. A wet spot on the floor. The other party, or the courts, or the culture having a rough decade. The leak had been running a long time before anyone called it a flood. And by the time we noticed, somewhere around the turn of this century, the water was already most of the way gone. A whole generation stood in a drained room wondering who had pulled the plug, refusing, with

a stubbornness that would be admirable if it weren't so costly, to believe the water was not about to come rushing back.

I want you to look at the leak. The whole argument of this book depends on getting the diagnosis right, and getting the diagnosis right depends on saying plainly what drained and what did not. So I'll do the unglamorous thing first. I'll show you the numbers. Then I'll tell you why the numbers, true as they are, hide the change that actually matters, and why almost everyone who quotes them is mourning the wrong death.

The Rounding Error and the Third

You can watch the water drain in the surveys, and the surveys aren't subtle. In the early 1970s, when the sociologists at the University of Chicago started asking a national sample of Americans, year after year, what their religion was, the share who answered none, no religion at all, was about one in twenty. Five percent. It was a rounding error. A curiosity. A category so small that a man could go his whole life in most of this country without knowingly meeting one. The village atheist. The odd cousin. The professor everyone whispered about. The box marked none was the box almost nobody checked, and the people who did check it were understood by everyone, themselves included, to be exceptions to a rule that held for the whole society. The rule was that Americans were religious. Decent people believed something. The exceptions proved it.

By the 2020s that same box, asked the same way, was checked by nearly one American in three. The rounding error had become one of the largest religious groups in the country. Larger than any single Protestant denomination. Larger than the Catholic share by some measures. Growing while nearly everything else shrank. The people the sociologists took to calling the nones, spelled like the negation and not like the sisters, had gone in a

single human lifetime from the margin of the survey to the center of it. A person born when the figure was five percent, living an ordinary span, watched it climb to almost thirty. That is not a dip in a cycle. That is not the kind of thing that happens and then unhappens. That is a whole category of human being, a way of standing toward God and church and the memory of both, that barely existed in your grandfather's America becoming one of the defining blocs of your children's.

And it didn't stop at the box. Every measure the sociologists know how to take moved the same direction at about the same speed. Church membership, which Gallup had tracked at around seventy percent of Americans through the whole middle of the twentieth century, steady as a heartbeat for sixty years, fell below fifty percent for the first time in the recorded history of the question right around 2020. Weekly attendance dropped. The share who told a survey-taker they belonged to no house of worship at all climbed year over year. The mainline Protestant denominations, the establishment inside the establishment, the churches of presidents and country clubs, lost members by the millions across a few decades. Some of them shed more than half their people. Whatever had been holding the old arrangement up, whatever invisible thing had kept those numbers so high for so long that everyone assumed they were permanent, stopped holding somewhere around the year 2000. The fall since has been steady, and there is no serious demographer anywhere who thinks it's about to reverse.

I could go on with the numbers. The temptation of a chapter like this is to keep going, to pile survey on survey until the sheer weight of the data does the emotional work for you. I'm going to resist it. The numbers, for all their force, are the least interesting true thing here. They tell you how many people left. They don't

tell you what they left for, and they don't tell you what died, and it is entirely possible to get every number right and still be weeping at the wrong funeral. So set the surveys down. The question is not how many walked out. The question is what walked in behind them, into the space the leaving cleared. And to answer that, we have to go back to 1985 and meet a woman named Sheila.

Sheila, and the Little Voice

In 1985 the sociologist Robert Bellah published, with four colleagues, a book called *Habits of the Heart*, and it did something decades of survey data could not do. It put a face on the change. Bellah and his team weren't counting heads. They were sitting in living rooms across America, listening to ordinary people talk about their lives, their work, their marriages, their sense of what made a life good. And underneath all of it they heard a country that had lost the shared moral languages it used to speak and had fallen back, almost without noticing, on the only language it had left. The language of the self. Americans, Bellah found, could still talk fluently about their feelings, their needs, their growth, their fulfillment. They had gone nearly mute about duty, about obligation, about anything a person is bound to whether it serves him or not. The moral vocabulary had thinned to a single word. The word was I.

And then, in the middle of the book, Bellah introduced the woman who would outlive every statistic in it. A young nurse he called Sheila Larson, a name changed to protect her, though she has since become more famous under the mask than she ever could have been beneath it. Sheila described her faith to Bellah's interviewer in a few sentences that ought to be carved over the door of this whole era. She believed in God. She was not a religious fanatic. She couldn't remember the last time she'd been

to church. Her faith had carried her a long way. And then she named it. It was her own faith, she said. It was Sheilaism. Just her own little voice.

She had named her religion after herself. Not after Christ. Not after a church, a tradition, a creed, a book. After Sheila. Because the final authority in her faith, the court from which there was no appeal, was Sheila. And Bellah, too good a scholar to sneer, understood at once that he was not looking at a rebel. He was looking at a prophet. Sheila was not the exception to where America was headed. She was the future, arriving a little early, saying out loud and without embarrassment the thing tens of millions of her countrymen already half-believed and would soon believe entirely. That religion is a private matter of personal preference. That the self is the arbiter of the sacred. That you consult the traditions the way you consult a menu, taking the dishes that suit you and sending the rest back. That the little voice inside is the closest thing to God a modern person can be expected to obey.

Sit in how strange that is. Then sit in how normal it now sounds. The distance between those two feelings is the exact measure of how far the water has drained. To a Christian of any earlier century, Sheilaism would have been not one religion among many but the definition of no religion at all. The self hoisted onto the throne that belongs to God. The oldest sin in the book wearing the mildest possible smile. To a Christian of the present century it sounds like your neighbor. It sounds like your cousin. If we're honest, it sounds like the unconverted floor of a good deal of what still passes for faith inside the church, because the little voice got into the sanctuary too. A great many people who sit in pews on Sunday are practicing a quiet Sheilaism the rest of the week. Believing what they find agreeable. Declining what

they don't. Treating the church as a resource for a faith they've already decided the shape of on their own.

Bellah gave us the woman. He did not fully name the machine that made her. For that we reach for a phrase a later sociologist, Christian Smith, would coin to describe what he found when he interviewed a generation of American teenagers about their beliefs and discovered that most of them, churched and unchurched alike, had converged on the same unspoken creed. He called it moralistic therapeutic deism, and the mouthful is worth the trouble, because each word names a load-bearing beam of the thing that replaced the faith. Moralistic, because its whole content is that you should be nice and fair and good. Therapeutic, because the point of God is to make you feel better about yourself and to be there when you need help. Deism, because the God of this creed is real but distant, a manager who set the world running and stays politely out of the way unless you call the front desk with a problem. It's Sheilism with a doctrine. And it is, Smith found, the actual functioning religion of most Americans under forty. Including a startling number who could still recite the creeds of the churches they attended without believing a word of them in the sense the churches meant.

That is what walked in behind the ones who walked out. Not, at first, a hostile atheism. Not a militant unbelief that hated the church and wanted it destroyed. Something milder, and in the end more corrosive. A therapeutic religion of the self that kept the vocabulary of God and quietly moved the throne. So that the question a person brought to any claim, any command, any doctrine, any church, stopped being the old question and became a new one.

The Therapeutic Replaces the Confessional

The old question was: is it true. The new question is: does it

work for me.

I want to slow down here, because this is the hinge of the whole change, and it's easy to say fast and hard to feel. For most of the history of the church, a man came to the faith the way you come to a fact about the world. You came asking whether it was so. Did God become man. Did he die. Did he rise. Is the tomb empty. Is there a judgment coming. The faith made claims, hard claims, about what had actually happened and what was actually true, and you stood before those claims the way you stand before any claim about reality. Obligated to reckon with them whether or not they were convenient. Whether or not they made you feel good. Whether or not they fit the life you'd already decided to live. The church was the place you went to find out what was true and to be told, on occasion, that the truth condemned you and that you needed to change. The confessional, in every tradition that had one and in every heart that didn't, was the room where a man laid his life down against a standard outside himself and found himself wanting and asked for mercy. The whole transaction assumed an authority the self did not control.

The therapeutic dissolves all of that, gently, without a fight. It doesn't argue that the claims are false. It just changes the question you're allowed to ask about them. It moves the standard from outside the self to inside it, so that the measure of any belief is no longer whether it's true but whether it helps. Whether it heals. Whether it fits. Whether it makes you feel seen and safe and whole. And a faith that makes demands cannot survive that question for long, because the entire point of a demand is that it does not bend to whether it works for you. A command that only binds you when you find it agreeable is not a command. It's a suggestion you've already decided to take. The moment the therapeutic question becomes the only question a culture knows

how to ask, the confessional is finished. Not because anyone tore it down. Because no one can any longer imagine why they'd enter it. You do not confess to a God you've hired as your therapist. You do not repent before a standard you set yourself. You do not kneel to a little voice.

Philip Rieff, the sociologist who saw this coming even before Bellah, called it the triumph of the therapeutic, and he understood it was not a new religion so much as the solvent that dissolves all the old ones. Every previous culture, Rieff argued, had organized itself around a set of demands, a sacred order that told people what they were forbidden and what they were for, and had produced its characteristic person by forming him against those demands. The therapeutic culture is the first in history organized around the abolition of demands. Around the freeing of the self from every standard it did not choose. And it produces a characteristic person too, the one Rieff called psychological man, who lives for well-being and asks of everything only whether it contributes to his sense of himself. That person cannot be a Christian in any sense the word has ever borne. Not because he's rejected the faith, but because he's quietly dissolved the ground the faith stands on. The ground where something outside you has the right to tell you what to do.

We built this. I want to say that plainly, because it's tempting to describe the therapeutic as something the secular world did to the church from outside, and it is not. The church helped build it. We baptized it. We took the therapeutic and dressed it in Christian clothes and preached it from our own pulpits. The sermon series on your best life. The gospel repackaged as the solution to your felt needs. The worship engineered to produce a feeling. The whole vast machine of a Christianity that sold itself to the therapeutic age by promising to be therapeutic. To work.

To help. To heal. To make you the person you already wanted to be. We asked the culture's question in our own sanctuaries. We taught two generations to come to God asking whether it worked for them. And now we're astonished that when it stopped working for them, when the felt need was met more efficiently by a screen or a supplement or a self-help book, they left, and took their little voice with them, and didn't look back. We did this. I have done this. I have preached the God who meets your needs to people who needed, more than anything, to be told that they were not the point.

What Actually Died

So here we are, standing in the drained room with the numbers in one hand and Sheila's little voice in the other. The church has looked at all of it, the empty box and the relocated throne and the therapeutic solvent, and reached the conclusion that seems obvious and is, I'm convinced, catastrophically wrong. The church has concluded that the faith is dying.

It is not. Something is dying. Something real, something that felt for a long time exactly like the faith, something whose death is producing genuine grief I will not mock, because I feel it too. But what is dying is not Christianity. What is dying is cultural Christianity. The two are not the same thing. And the failure to tell them apart is the single most expensive mistake the American church is making right now.

Christendom is the arrangement. It's the long stretch of history, running from a Roman emperor's conversion to a few decades ago in this country, in which Christianity was assumed, established, respectable, and held up, for free, by the power of the surrounding culture. It's the water. Christianity is the thing itself. A crucified and risen Lord, a gospel, a people, a way of life that was already three centuries old and had already turned

an empire upside down before any emperor ever made it official. Cultural Christianity is what happens when the second thing lives long enough inside the first that people forget the difference. The broad and shallow belief the water held up for nothing. The nominal churchgoing and the vague civic religion and the assumption that decent people were more or less Christian, that being American and being Christian were close enough to the same thing you never had to tell them apart. That faith, the subsidized kind, the carried kind, is evaporating. And it was always going to, because it had no roots of its own. It was never converted. It was carried. You cannot mourn the loss of a faith that was only ever the buoyancy of the water.

The cultural Christian was never converted. He was carried. What we're watching is not the death of the church but the evaporation of its shadow on the wall of a culture that has finally turned out the light.

The picture I keep coming back to is the scaffolding and the building. When a great structure goes up, or gets repaired, the crews throw scaffolding around it, a whole exterior skeleton of pipe and plank, and for a season the scaffolding is so total, so wrapped around every surface, that from the street you can't see the building underneath anymore. You see the scaffolding. You come to think of the scaffolding as the shape of the thing. Then one day the work is done, or the arrangement ends, and the crews take the scaffolding down, and there's always a moment, if you've forgotten what was under there, when it looks for all the world like the building is being demolished. The clatter of falling pipe. The exposed and naked walls. The sudden absence of the familiar exterior. A man who mistook the scaffolding for the building would stand in the street and weep, certain he was watching a demolition, when in fact he was watching a building

emerge, for the first time in years, as itself.

That is exactly what's happening, and exactly why we're grieving. Christendom was the scaffolding. For sixteen hundred years it wrapped the faith so completely, the established church and the Christian calendar and the schools that opened in prayer and the stores that closed on Sunday and the politicians who quoted the King James whether they'd read it or not, that we stopped being able to see the building underneath. We came to think the scaffolding was the shape of Christianity. We came to believe that to be a Christian was to be central, normal, respectable, the majority that set the terms. None of that is anywhere in the New Testament, which was written by and to a hunted minority under a hostile empire. But all of it felt like the faith, because we'd never known the faith in any other condition. And now the scaffolding is coming down, with all the clatter and all the exposed walls, and we're standing in the street weeping at a demolition that is not a demolition. The building is fine. The building was always fine. We were told for so long that the scaffolding was the building that we can no longer tell the difference. So we're weeping at the wrong funeral.

I have stood in that street. I want to be honest that the diagnosis is easier to write than to feel, because even a man like me, who came to Christ out of atheism as a grown adult and never once swam in the water, who has less excuse than almost anyone for the nostalgia, even I catch it in my own chest. The ache for a country that would assume the faith on my behalf. The wish that the room were on my side. The pull of the scaffolding is enormous even for those of us who never needed it, because it's comfortable, because it's easy, because a faith the culture holds up for free costs so much less than a faith you have to carry yourself. The grief at its loss is real grief. I am not asking you

not to grieve. I'm asking you to grieve the right thing. To weep at the correct funeral. To understand that the body in the casket is cultural Christianity and not Christ, and that Christ, as it happens, has a long history of being pronounced dead by people standing at the wrong tomb.

The Wrong Funeral

Consider what the death of cultural Christianity actually clears away, because the church has been so busy mourning it that no one has stopped to notice a good deal of what's dying was worth losing. Cultural Christianity gave us a country full of people who called themselves Christian and had never met Christ. Who wore the name like a coat they'd inherited and never once examined. Who assumed that being born in a Christian nation made them Christian the way being born in a garage would make you a car. It gave us churches full of the unconverted, kept full by social pressure and civic habit, where the gospel could go unpreached for a generation because everyone already assumed they were fine. It gave us a faith so cheap, so undemanding, so thoroughly subsidized by the surrounding culture that it couldn't tell the difference between a disciple and a respectable citizen, and didn't need to, because the water held them both up equally and asked nothing of either. That is what's draining away. And a church with the courage to look clearly at what it's losing will find, mixed into the genuine grief, a strange and unexpected relief. Because the thing that's dying was never the church. It was the thing that made the church impossible to find.

The real church, the one with roots, the one that costs something, the one that was never the majority and never needed to be, is still standing in the drained room. It's smaller than the shadow the water made it look, and that smallness is a shock, and the shock is part of the grief, because for a long time we counted the

shadow and called it the church and comforted ourselves with numbers that were mostly water. But it is also, for the first time in a very long time, unmistakably itself. A church that has stopped being able to count on the culture is a church about to find out what it actually believes, which is the most clarifying thing that can happen to a people. And the most frightening. And the most necessary. The drought does not create shallow faith. It exposes it. And it exposes, at the same time and in the same drought, the faith that was never shallow. The roots that went down long before the sky turned to brass. The disciples who were disciples when it cost nothing and will still be disciples now that it costs everything, standing in the open room, holding onto the Lord who was always the only thing holding them up.

Lesslie Newbigin saw this before most of us, and I'll let him have something close to the last word in this chapter, because he earned it in a way I have not. He spent nearly forty years as a missionary in India, carrying the gospel to people who'd never heard it, and when he finally came home to Britain he found something that broke his heart and cleared his vision at once. He found a country that had become a harder mission field than the one he'd left, and a church that didn't even know it had become one. The West, he understood, is not pre-Christian. It's post-Christian. It has the church in its memory the way a man has a marriage he walked out of, and that is not nothing, and it is not the same as never having married at all, and it takes a different and lonelier kind of missionary than the one who comes to people who've never heard the name. Newbigin came back to a drained room and, instead of weeping at the funeral, asked the only question worth asking. How could the gospel become credible again in a culture that had heard it and moved on. That's our question now. That's the question the rest of this book is trying to answer.

But we can't answer it yet, and here's why. We've named what drained and what did not. We've said, as plainly as I know how, that the scaffolding is coming down and the building is fine, that cultural Christianity is dying and Christianity is not, that we've been weeping at the wrong funeral. That's a true diagnosis and a necessary one. It's also not enough. Because it treats the change as if it were only a change in the numbers, only a shift in who checks which box, only the draining of a visible water we could see if we looked. And the deepest part of the change is not visible at all. The deepest part is not that fewer people believe. It's that belief itself has changed its nature. The very air we all breathe now, the frame through which every one of us sees the world, believer and unbeliever alike, has been rebuilt so thoroughly that we can no longer see it, any more than the fish can see the water it was born in. The therapeutic did not just empty the pews. It reground the lenses behind everyone's eyes, ours included, so that even our faith comes to us bent through a shape we did not choose and cannot detect.

To understand that, to see the frame we're all sealed inside and can't climb out of, we have to leave the numbers behind entirely and go to the one thinker who spent eight hundred pages describing it. We have to understand what it means to live, as every last one of us now does, in a secular age. And the first thing to understand about that age is that it is not a room emptied of God. It's a room fitted with lenses, ground so finely and worn so long that we've forgotten they're there. Until we can name them, we'll keep mistaking the shape of the glass for the shape of the world.

Chapter 4: A Secular Age

There's a question almost nobody who ever lived could have asked. You've asked it. So have I. So has your most devout neighbor, at two in the morning when the house is quiet and the arguing stops. It isn't whether God is good. It isn't even whether God is there. The question is whether you'd believe any of it if you'd been born somewhere else, to someone else, in some other room. That question is the weather of the whole age. And the man who named it best took eight hundred pages to describe a single shift, one so total and so invisible that most of the people living inside it don't know it happened. His name is Charles Taylor. In 2007 he published a book called *A Secular Age*. The argument of that enormous book fits in one sentence, and it will take the rest of this chapter to feel it.

Five hundred years ago it was nearly impossible not to believe in God. Now it's one option among many, and often not the easiest one.

That's the change. Not that people stopped believing, though plenty have. It runs deeper than the head count, underneath the believers and the unbelievers both. Taylor is careful, almost fussy, about what he is not saying. He's not saying we live in a world emptied of faith. He spends real energy going after the lazy story, the one that says religion was a fog and science burned it off, that the human race got smarter and outgrew its gods the way a boy outgrows the dark. That's a fairy tale the secular age tells about itself. Taylor takes it apart, because the truth is stranger and harder. What changed was not the amount of belief in the world. What changed were the conditions of belief.

What changed was what it feels like to believe anything at all.

Put two men side by side, one in 1500 and one now, and watch the gap. The man in 1500 does not believe in God the way you believe a proposition, after you've weighed it against the alternatives. He doesn't believe in God the way he believes a certain field will yield a good crop, or that the king is a fool. He believes in God the way he believes in the ground under his feet. There's no thinkable alternative. Atheism isn't a position a serious person holds. It's a kind of madness. The whole world he lives in is shot through with meaning and spirit and moral order, top to bottom, heaven to ditch. God isn't a hypothesis for that man. God is the floor. To stop believing wouldn't be to change his mind. It would be to lose it, to step outside the shared world, and there's nowhere outside to step. His belief isn't chosen. It's the water. And we already know what water does to the fish who can't see it.

Now the man now. He believes, let's say. He's devout. He prays, he goes to church, he gives, he means it. And even for him the belief has changed its texture. He holds his faith in a world where the person across the dinner table doesn't, and isn't crazy, and is in fact kind and smart and has looked at more or less the same evidence and landed on the other side. His own kids might walk away from what he believes and turn into decent, thriving, unremarkable adults, and everyone he knows will call that ordinary. So he believes knowing the belief is contestable. Knowing it's a position and not a floor. Knowing thoughtful people have taken the other chair and are perfectly comfortable there. And whether he admits it or not, that knowledge gets into his believing. It changes what faith feels like from the inside. He believes in the open sea. The man in 1500 believed in the shallows. The difference isn't the strength of the conviction. It's

the world the conviction sits inside.

Taylor calls the thing that made this the coming of the immanent frame, and the phrase is worth slowing down on, because it names the box we're all living in whether we picked it or not. The immanent frame is a way of taking the world as a closed system. A self-contained order of nature that runs by its own laws and needs nothing above it or beyond it to be complete. Cause and effect. Matter and mechanism. A universe you could in principle explain all the way down without once mentioning God. That doesn't mean the frame forces you into unbelief. Taylor is firm that it doesn't. You can live inside it and still believe the frame is open at the top, still hold that the closed order of nature is itself held in the hand of God. But you can also live inside it and believe the frame is shut, that nature is all there is and all there ever was. The unnerving part is that both readings now feel available. The frame is the default. Whether you crack a window and let the transcendent back in is, for the first time in human history, up to you. And a faith you have to hold open against a frame that wants to close is a different animal than a faith the whole world holds open for you.

I want to be honest about how deep this goes, because it doesn't stop at the unbeliever. The church makes a fatal mistake when it treats the immanent frame as a problem out there, some secular fog on other people. The frame is the air all of us breathe. It's gotten into the church, into the devout, into me. James K. A. Smith, who did the work of reading Taylor for the rest of us and giving us the short version, says it with a bluntness that stings. Even our believing, he says, has gone buffered. We believe in God now the way you believe a fact, a piece of information filed in the head, inside a world we otherwise feel as flat and closed and disenchanted. We don't dwell in God the way the saints did,

moving through a world lit from the inside by his presence at every point. We say we believe in a God who fills all things, and then hour by hour we live as if the material world were a closed machine and God a conclusion we affirm on Sundays. The frame is not the unbeliever's prison. It's the shared house. The believer has a room in it too, and the walls press on the faithful as hard as on anyone.

This is where Taylor hands us the most useful pair of words in the whole book. I've watched them explain people to themselves like almost nothing else can. He says the modern person is a buffered self, where our ancestors were porous selves, and the whole psychological weather of the age is the difference between the two.

The porous self is the older self, the self of nearly everyone who lived before the modern world. To be porous is to be open, permeable, unsealed at the edges. It's to live in a world where meanings and spirits and powers can reach you from outside, where a curse can land on you and a blessing can enter you and the line between the self and the world is thin and easy to cross. The porous self is vulnerable in a way we can barely picture, exposed to forces it didn't invent and can't fully control. That's frightening. But it is never alone. Never sealed off. Never trapped inside its own skull. Because the same opening that lets the demons in lets God in, and the world it lives in is charged, full, alive with presence. In that world the sacred is not a private opinion. It's a public and dangerous fact.

The buffered self is us. To be buffered is to be sealed, bounded, protected. To have a firm border between what's inside the mind and what's outside it. Meaning lives in here, in my head, in my choices, in my interior life, and the world out there is just stuff. Neutral. Mechanical. Disenchanted. It can't reach in and touch

me without my permission. The buffered self is the great achievement of the modern age, and it's a real gain. It's safer. The curse can't land, because we don't believe in curses, and the border holds. It's master of the meanings inside its own walls. But read the fine print on that safety. The same wall that keeps the demons out keeps everything else out too. The buffered self, having sealed itself against a hostile enchanted world, finds it has also sealed itself into a world gone silent. A universe of matter and mechanism with no voice in it but its own. The porous self was exposed and never alone. The buffered self is safe and desperately, structurally lonely, and it doesn't know why, because the loneliness is built into the walls it mistook for freedom.

Read your own restlessness in that. The low hum of anxiety under the age. The sense so many people carry that something is missing and they can't name it. A loneliness no amount of connection seems to touch. Taylor gives it a diagnosis the therapists mostly miss. We built the buffer to keep the frightening enchanted world at bay. We succeeded. And now we live inside the buffer, and it turns out to be a cell. We're safe from the spirits and cut off from God in the same wall. Master of our own interior and prisoner of it in the same act. And the church, which ought to be the one place a buffered person could come and have the walls opened, has too often just offered a buffered version of the faith. God as one more managed meaning inside the sealed self. A private conviction that leaves the frame closed and the wall standing and the loneliness right where it was.

Now the turn this whole chapter has been building toward. The hardest thing in it. The thing that ought to keep a pastor up at night. If the immanent frame is the air we breathe, and the buffered self is the shape we've all been pressed into, then the faith we hold has been bent by both, and we can't see it, because

you can't see the frame you're looking through. We don't read the faith straight. We read it through lenses. The lenses were ground for us by an age we didn't choose, and we've worn them so long we've stopped feeling them as lenses at all. We think we're seeing the gospel plain. We're seeing it bent. And the bend is invisible precisely because it's total.

Take the lenses one at a time, because naming them is the first step to seeing them, and seeing them is the only way to take them off.

There's the individualist lens, and it may be the thickest of all. So thick most American Christians can't picture the faith without it. We read a book written to a people, addressed to a covenant community, soaked in the plural, and we hear a message to me, about my personal relationship with God, my private salvation, my individual walk. Robert Bellah saw it coming and gave it a face. In 1985, in *Habits of the Heart*, he interviewed a woman he called Sheila, who described her faith in a sentence that ought to be carved over the door of this whole era. She believed in God. She wasn't a fanatic. She couldn't remember the last time she'd been to church. And it was her own faith, she said. Sheilaism. Just her own little voice. Bellah understood she wasn't a rebel. She was a prophet. She'd only drawn out to its end the lens the whole culture had already ground, the one that makes the sovereign individual the final authority and the private inner voice the last court of appeal. The self had quietly become the throne. The church had been demoted from the place you go to find the truth to one more resource you might consult on your way to deciding it yourself. And the terrifying part isn't that the world thinks this way. It's that the church does. We've read Sheilaism back into the Bible until we can't hear how strange our individualism would have sounded to Paul, who did not have a

private faith and wouldn't have understood the concept, because he had a people.

There's the consumer lens, and it rides in on the back of the first. Once the self is the throne, everything else becomes a product laid out before the throne for its selection, and the faith takes its spot on the shelf next to the rest. A consumer never asks, is it true. A consumer asks, does it work for me. Does it meet my needs. Does it fit. Run through the consumer lens, the faith becomes a set of services the customer evaluates. A church chosen the way you choose a gym. A doctrine kept if it comforts and dropped if it demands. Taylor traces how the therapeutic slowly replaced the confessional, how the whole vocabulary of the inner life shifted from sin and grace to needs and fulfillment. And the church, desperate to keep the customer, too often just changed its signage to match. We started selling the faith the way you sell anything to a buffered self, as a means to its own flourishing, a technique for a better life. And in doing that we handed the sovereignty to the very customer we were sent to convert. You cannot preach the cross to a king. The cross is the one product that tells the buyer he has to die.

There's the national lens, and this one is nearly invisible to Americans, because it feels like patriotism, and patriotism feels like virtue. It's the lens that quietly welds the story of God to the story of the country. That reads the church's hope through the frame of the nation's destiny. That hears thy kingdom come and thinks, without quite noticing the swap, God bless America. There's a whole chapter later on the wreckage this makes, so I won't lay it all out here. I only want to name it as a lens. An inherited way of reading that most who wear it never chose and can't see. A way of taking a faith that was born stateless under a hostile empire and can't be owned by any flag, and quietly

wrapping it in one flag until the two become one object in the hand and won't come apart. The whole burden of this book is that they have to come apart. The exile begins the day you feel them come loose.

And there's the political lens, which is the national lens turned toward the machinery of power. It reads the faith as a program to be pushed through law and state and culture, so that being a faithful Christian comes to mean holding the correct positions and winning the correct fights. The gospel gets slowly bent into a platform, the church into the chaplaincy of a coalition. Left and right both do it, and each is sure only the other has. The lens is not a set of policies. It's the assumption underneath, the one that says the faith is finally about which side wins. That assumption sits so deep in the American church that to question it sounds like apathy, when in fact it's the assumption the powerless early church did not hold, could not have held, and grew explosively without.

What these four lenses share is the buried theme of the whole chapter. Not one of them is in the New Testament. The individualism, the consumerism, the nationalism, the shrinking of faith down to politics, all of it was ground for us by the immanent frame and the buffered self and the long habits of Christendom. Absorbed with the water. Breathed in with the air. Then folded so quietly into the faith itself that we came to mistake the lens for the light. We did this. I did this. I've read the plural letters of a covenant people as private mail addressed to me. I've shopped churches like a customer and called it discernment. I've felt the story of God and the story of my country fuse in my chest and called the warmth worship. None of that was faithfulness. Every bit of it was the frame, doing its silent work on a man who thought he was just reading his Bible.

We didn't lose the faith. We bent it, through lenses an age handed us and we never thought to take off, and then we called the bent thing the gospel and defended it to the death.

And this, at last, is why Taylor matters so much for a church in exile, and why I've given him a whole chapter instead of a paragraph. The end of Christendom is not only the draining of the water we felt in the first chapters. It's the removal of the lenses. Or rather, the exposure of them. The sudden ability to see the frame, because the culture has stopped holding it perfectly still. When the faith was assumed, when everyone in the room wore the same lenses, you couldn't see them, any more than you can see your own glasses. But the room doesn't share them anymore. The person across the table has taken the other chair, and the frame that felt like reality is exposed as one frame among possible frames, and the lenses that felt like sight are exposed as lenses. That's disorienting. It feels like loss. And it's the beginning of the only clarity we've got, because a church that can finally see its lenses is a church that can finally take some of them off.

I said Taylor is careful not to tell the fog-and-science story, and I want to come back to that, because it guards us against a despair the age keeps pressing on us. The frame did not close because the human race got too smart for God. Belief did not retreat before proof. Taylor shows, patiently, over hundreds of pages, that no such proof ever arrived. The closing of the frame was not a discovery. It was a construction. A slow rearrangement of what feels obvious. A shift in the plausible, not a verdict of the reason. Which means it can shift again. The frame that closed can open. The plausibility that drained away is not a fact of nature but the mood of an age, and moods pass. The deep human hunger for the

transcendent that the buffer was built to seal out is still there, aching inside the wall, unnamed and unmet, in the loneliest generation the West has ever made. The buffered self is not satisfied. It's starving. And a starving world is not a closed door to the gospel. It's an open wound the gospel was made for.

But naming the frame is not the same as escaping it, and I won't pretend the church can think its way out of an age that formed it. You don't argue a person out of the buffered self. The buffer isn't an argument. It's a formation, ground into the body by ten thousand repetitions of a disenchanted life. A church that has spent generations wearing the lenses of the age will not set them down because someone told it to. It has to be re-formed, slowly, by a different set of practices and a different set of loves, and that long labor is what the back half of this book is finally for. But before we can build the thing that forms a porous soul in a buffered age, we have to reckon with what the church actually does when it first feels the water drain and the lenses slip and the frame close in. Because a frightened people, told the world they assumed is gone, does not usually respond by taking off its glasses and learning to see. It reaches, in a panic, for one of a small number of escapes, and each of them is a way of refusing the exile instead of living it. It tries to force the water back. It tries to dissolve into the age so the ache will stop. Or it walls itself off and waits for the barbarians to lose interest. Three answers. Each of them wears the face of faithfulness. Each of them is the flesh grieving its lost home. Those three are what we turn to now.

Chapter 5: Take It Back, Give It Up, or Wall It Off

Tell people their world has ended and watch what they reach for. It's almost always one of a few answers, and the answers are old. They were old in Babylon. There were prophets in the exile whose names we half remember, Hananiah the loudest, telling the captives exactly what their grief wanted to hear. And there were quieter men, men whose names we don't have, who'd already stopped writing home to Jerusalem. They'd started letting the old language go. They wanted one thing, and it was for the ache of being different to stop. Jeremiah's letter spends about as much strength forbidding the wrong answers as it does commanding the right one. That should tell us something. The wrong answers aren't exotic. They're the reflexes of a grieving people. They come up in the heart before the mind has said a word, and they wear the clothes of faithfulness, and they're still with us. They're in me.

I've felt all three. I need to say that up front, before I lay a hand on any of them, because a man who's only ever felt one of the temptations he's about to name hasn't been honest with himself, and you'll smell it on him. There's a version of me that wants the old country back. That misses being able to assume the room. That would happily crank the water back on if somebody handed me the valve. There's a version of me that wants the clever world's approval, that would love to be the kind of Christian the people who matter find reasonable and unembarrassing. And there's a version of me, on the tired days, when the news is bad and my kids are watching something I can't see the bottom of,

that wants only to pull my family behind a wall and let the whole burning city go. Three wants. All three are the flesh dressed up as faithfulness. All three are the cultural Christian in me, grieving his lost water. I'm not standing above this chapter. I'm standing inside it, naming idols I've served myself.

Because that's what they are. Not strategies. Idols. Three ways to keep the thing we actually worship, which was never God but the arrangement that made God convenient. Let me take them one at a time. And let me do the hard part first, which is to make each one as strong as it can be made before I turn it down. A temptation you haven't steelmanned is a temptation you don't understand. A man who only sneers at the other two answers hasn't grasped the people who hold them, which means he hasn't grasped himself.

The first answer: take it back

The first answer is to fight your way home. If Christendom is falling, this answer says, then the job of the faithful is to hold it up. By force if that's what it takes. Grab the levers of culture and law and the state, and crank the old arrangement back into place. This is the impulse behind the harder forms of what we now call Christian nationalism. The fusion of cross and flag. The conviction that the way to save the faith is to make the nation Christian again by making it obey. It has a history. It goes back to the fourth century, to a Roman emperor who saw a sign in the sky before a battle at the Milvian Bridge in 312, and won, and issued an edict of toleration the next year. Within a single lifetime, under Theodosius in 380, the faith Rome had fed to lions became the official religion of Rome. That was the day the church got the lever. And the take-it-back answer is, underneath everything, the longing to hold that lever again. It's the fourth century's ghost, and it isn't going quietly.

I want to steelman it, and I want to do it seriously, because it isn't held only by cynics and grifters, whatever the people who despise it want to believe. Underneath the worst of it, very often, there's a real love. Love of a country and a heritage and a way of life that genuinely gave people good things. That fed the hungry and buried the dead and married the young and taught the children to read out of a book that told them the truth. There's real grief at watching that dissolve. There's real fear, and it's not a foolish fear, for the children who'll grow up in the ruins, catechized by a culture that's lost the plot, formed by screens their parents can't follow them into. Those loves aren't nothing. A grandfather who wants his grandchildren to inherit what he inherited is not a monster, and a church that can only mock him hasn't earned the right to correct him. There's a real theological instinct buried in there too. An instinct that the lordship of Christ is public and not just private. That Jesus is Lord of nations and not only of hearts. That a faith which asks nothing of the common life has quietly agreed to be a hobby. The nationalist is right that the world belongs to God. He's right that a privatized Christianity, content to be one leisure option among many, has already surrendered something it had no business surrendering. The instinct that the faith carries public weight is a true instinct. Hold onto that. I'm going to grant it, and then show you what the answer does with it.

Because it takes a true instinct and hands it to Caesar. Say the thing at the root plainly, because the root is rotten even where the grief is real and the instinct is sound. The take-it-back answer believes the kingdom of God can be advanced by the sword of the state. The moment it believes that, it's lost the ability to tell the two cities apart. Augustine saw those two cities. He spent thirteen years, from 413 to 426, teaching the church to keep them separate. The earthly city built by love of self, reaching all the

way to contempt of God. The heavenly city built by love of God, reaching all the way to contempt of self. The take-it-back answer collapses them. It mistakes the nation for the kingdom, baptizes a tribe, and produces a Christianity finally indistinguishable from a voting bloc with a worship band. And you can win with that. You can win an election, win a court, win a whole political season. And you can lose the only thing the church was ever sent to keep.

Look at what Jesus actually did with the offer of the lever, because he was offered it. Plainly. Twice. In the desert the devil showed him all the kingdoms of the world in a moment of time and said, "To you I will give all this authority and their glory, for it has been delivered to me, and I give it to whom I will. If you, then, will worship me, it will all be yours." That's the take-it-back offer in its purest form. Real authority. Real power over the actual kingdoms of the actual world, offered for the price of one act of worship. And Jesus said, "It is written, 'You shall worship the Lord your God, and him only shall you serve.'" He didn't say the kingdoms didn't matter. He said the price was the one price he wouldn't pay. And at the very end, in the garden, when Peter drew a sword and took a man's ear off trying to hold the arrangement together by force, Jesus said, "Put your sword back into its place. For all who take the sword will perish by the sword. Do you think that I cannot appeal to my Father, and he will at once send me more than twelve legions of angels?" He had the lever. A bigger lever than any nationalist has ever dreamed of. And he set it down and let them take him, because the kingdom he came to bring does not come the way the kingdoms of the world come. He knew that the moment it did, it would stop being his kingdom and start being theirs.

The take-it-back answer wants a Christ with a sword.

But the only sword Jesus ever touched, he told Peter to put away. The only crown he ever wore, they made out of thorns. A church that reaches for Caesar's power has already refused its King's cross.

There's a specific poison in this answer that the other two don't carry, and I have to be honest about it, because it's the most dangerous of the three in a certain kind of season. When the church fuses itself to political power, it doesn't only fail to advance the kingdom. It slanders it. It turns the name of Christ into a party badge. It teaches a whole watching generation that to become a Christian is to pick a side in a war they want no part of. The skeptic I most want to reach, the one this whole book is written toward, is not repelled first by the resurrection or the virgin birth. He's repelled by a cross wrapped in a flag. By a Jesus he's only ever seen used as a club. And he's concluded, not unreasonably from the evidence in front of him, that Christianity is a power play with a religious accent. The take-it-back answer builds that wall between him and the gospel, brick by brick, in the name of defending the gospel. It's the flesh doing the devil's demolition and calling it construction.

The second answer: give it up

The second answer is the opposite reach. It comes from the other kind of grief. Not the grief of the man who lost his country, but the grief of the man who's ashamed of it. If the culture has moved on, this answer says, then the job of the faithful is to catch up. Quietly file down every edge of the faith the age finds offensive. Keep the architecture and the music and the warm feeling, and let the hard substance go. This is the impulse behind the slow accommodation of the progressive church. The steady trade of the difficult sayings of Jesus for the settled opinions of the educated class. Where the first answer wants to conquer

Babylon, this one wants to move into Babylon and change its name to home.

I want to steelman this one too. I find it easier to steelman than the first, which should make me suspicious of myself, because I'm formed by the same educated class whose approval this answer craves, and the temptations that flatter us are the ones we defend most gently. So let me be careful. The give-it-up answer almost always presents itself as compassion, and sometimes it sincerely is. A desire to remove needless offense. To stop defending things that were never worth defending. To love the people the church has wounded and to stop wounding them. Those instincts aren't all wrong. Some of what the accommodationist wants to let go of, the church genuinely should have let go of long ago. The cruelties we baptized. The cultural prejudices we mistook for doctrine. The times we made the gospel carry the weight of our comfort and called our comfort holiness. There's a real repentance hidden inside this answer. A real recognition that the church has too often stood with the powerful against the wounded. That recognition is not the enemy of the gospel. It's closer to the gospel than the smugness that dismisses it. Paul himself said he became all things to all people, that by all means he might save some. There's a true instinct here. The offense of the cross should be the only offense. We should clear away every needless stumbling block, so the one necessary stumbling block, the crucified God, stands alone in the road. Grant that. It's true. And then watch what the answer does with it.

Because it doesn't stop at clearing away the needless offense. It clears away the necessary one too. Name the root here, as plainly as the first. The give-it-up answer believes the church survives by agreeing with the world. And a church that agrees with the

world about everything has nothing left to say to it and no reason to exist. Paul became all things to all people that he might save some. He did not become all things to all people that he might be liked by some. The whole sentence bends toward salvation. Toward the moment of witness. Toward the offense of the cross finally landing. Accommodation keeps the flexibility and drops the point. It becomes all things to all people so it might be applauded by all people. And it will be applauded, all the way to its own empty buildings, because the world has never needed a slightly more spiritual version of what it already believes.

The numbers are merciless here, and it does no one any favors to hide them. The churches that have most fully embraced the give-it-up answer, that have most thoroughly conformed themselves to the going consensus, are not growing. They're the ones dying fastest. Emptying out generation over generation. Closing and merging and selling their buildings to developers. This isn't a taunt. It's a diagnosis, and it's a diagnosis the accommodationist should be able to accept on his own terms, because his whole premise is that relevance is survival. If relevance were survival, these would be the fullest churches in the country. They're the emptiest. A faith that exists only to bless the going consensus dies the moment the consensus no longer needs its blessing. And the consensus never needed it in the first place. The world can generate its own affirmation. It has an entire economy dedicated to affirming it. What it can't generate, and what it's quietly starving for, is a word from outside itself. The church that agreed to say nothing the world wasn't already saying has nothing the world wasn't already dying of.

Jesus was blunt about this in a way we've sanded down. "You are the salt of the earth," he said, "but if salt has lost its taste, how shall its saltiness be restored? It is no longer good for anything

except to be thrown out and trampled under people's feet." Salt that's become indistinguishable from the dish is not being gracious. It's being useless. Worse than useless, because it's forgotten the one thing it was for. The give-it-up answer is salt working very hard to lose its taste, out of a sincere and mistaken conviction that saltiness is what's keeping people away from the table. When saltiness is the only thing it ever had to offer them.

The third answer: wall it off

The third answer is the quietest and the most pious-sounding, and for that reason it fools serious Christians most easily. The ones who've already seen through the other two. If the culture is lost, this answer says, then the job of the faithful is to retreat. Pull back behind the walls. Build a parallel everything and wait out the long darkness in a fortified enclave. Protect the children and the doctrine from a world gone wrong. It's the bunker. And I want to steelman this one hardest of all, because it has the most real wisdom mixed into it, more than the other two combined. The reader who's followed me this far is the reader most likely to be quietly building a bunker of his own and calling it discipleship.

So steelman it, and steelman it generously. The withdrawal answer takes formation seriously, and it's right to. It knows, where the accommodationist has forgotten, that the culture is not neutral. That it's catechizing us and our children all day long through a thousand small liturgies, the scroll and the screen and the store. And that a faith which doesn't actively resist that formation will simply be dissolved by it. It's right that we're creatures of habit before we're creatures of argument. That we're formed by what we do over and over far more than by what we say we believe. That a church which only preaches at people on Sunday while the world disciples them the other six days has

already lost a contest it doesn't know it's in. It's right that thick community isn't optional. That the faith has always been carried by communities dense enough to hold a different way of life. You can't form a saint in isolation any more than you can raise a child in an empty room. And it can point to the whole history of the church for proof. When the Roman order fell apart, it wasn't the people who tried to prop up the dying empire who saved the moral and spiritual life of the West. It was the monasteries. The deep little communities Benedict and men like him built, the ones that copied the Scriptures by hand through the long dark and carried the faith across centuries no one could see the end of. The philosopher Alasdair MacIntyre ended a famous book in 1981 by saying we're waiting for another, doubtless very different, Benedict. He was right. The withdrawal answer heard him. And some version of strategic withdrawal is genuinely part of faithfulness, as every monastery in history would tell you. Grant all of it. It's the strongest of the three cases, and most of it is simply true.

And then watch it become its own betrayal at the exact point where it's pushed past wisdom into fear. Because the monastery MacIntyre pointed to was never a bunker. The Benedictine communities did not wall themselves off from the world to survive the world. They kept the door open. The Rule of Benedict, written around the year 530, commands that every guest who arrives be received as Christ himself, that the poor and the pilgrim be welcomed with particular care. Those monasteries became, across the dark centuries, the hospitals and the schools and the libraries and the guest houses of a shattered civilization. The places the surrounding world came to for healing and learning and bread. They were fortresses of formation with the gates open, and the openness was the point. The bunker keeps the formation and shuts the gate. And in shutting the gate it

abandons the one command that stands at the dead center of Jeremiah's whole letter, the command this entire book is an attempt to obey. The withdrawal answer seeks the welfare of the church and lets the city fend for itself. It builds the wall and calls it discipleship. It forgets that the exiles were sent into Babylon on purpose, for Babylon's sake, and were never given permission to wall themselves off from the city they were commanded to bless.

Name this root too, because it's the subtlest of the three and the easiest to miss under the piety. The withdrawal answer believes the faith is fragile. That it must be protected from contact. That exposure to a hostile world is a threat the church can't survive. And that belief is a slander against the God who sent his people into the world in the first place. Jesus prayed for his disciples on the last night of his life, and he did not pray what the bunker wants him to have prayed. "I do not ask that you take them out of the world," he said to his Father, "but that you keep them from the evil one. They are not of the world, just as I am not of the world." And then: "As you sent me into the world, so I have sent them into the world." Not of the world, and sent into it, in the same breath, held together by the same prayer. The bunker keeps the first half and throws away the second. It hears "not of the world" and builds a wall. It never hears "sent into the world" at all. A church that's not of the world but also not sent into it is not the church Jesus prayed for. It's something else. Something safer and smaller and finally disobedient. A lamp that's decided the safest thing to do with its light is put it under a basket where the wind can't reach it. "Nor do people light a lamp and put it under a basket," Jesus said, "but on a stand, and it gives light to all in the house." The bunker is a basket. A holy basket. A well-meaning basket, built out of real love for the children inside it. But a basket over a lamp is a lamp that's forgotten what it's for.

The one fear underneath all three

Now look at what the three answers share, because it's the most important thing in this chapter and it's the thing none of them can see about themselves. Set them side by side. The first reaches for power. The second reaches for approval. The third reaches for the wall. They look like opposites. The nationalist and the accommodationist despise each other, and both of them find the withdrawer naive, and the withdrawer thinks both of them have already lost their souls to the culture in opposite directions. They're the three warring factions of the American church, and each is certain the other two are the whole problem. And underneath the war, driving every one of them, hidden beneath the bluster and the compassion and the piety, is a single fear. One fear wearing three costumes. The fear is this: that the faith can't survive without the culture's backing.

The nationalist can't imagine a faithful church that isn't also a powerful one, so he reaches for power. The accommodationist can't imagine a faithful church the culture despises, so he reaches for approval. The withdrawer can't imagine a faithful church exposed to a hostile world, so he reaches for the wall. Three different reaches. One identical terror. All three have looked at the drained water, the lost arrangement, the country that moved on, and all three have concluded the same thing. That the church can't live without it. The nationalist wants to flood the room again. The accommodationist wants to dissolve into whatever fluid the room is filled with now. The withdrawer wants to seal off a chamber where a little of the old water might be kept. But all three agree, in the one place they'd never admit to agreeing, that a church without the water is a church that dies. And that's the lie. That's the single lie underneath all three answers. And it's a lie the church has the means to expose, because it's already

been disproven once, decisively, in the only laboratory that matters. History.

The first three hundred years are the disproof. The church that grew fastest in the whole span of its existence was the church that had none of the three things the three answers reach for. It had no power. It was illegal, slandered, periodically hunted, its members meeting in homes and burying their dead in tunnels, with no lever anywhere in reach. It had no approval. It was the object of the culture's contempt, accused of atheism for refusing the gods, of cannibalism for the Supper, of incest for calling each other brother and sister, held in exactly the low regard the accommodationist is desperate to escape. And it had no wall. It did not withdraw. It poured itself into the plague-struck cities the pagans were fleeing, nursed the sick who were not its own, gathered the infants left exposed on the hillsides to die, and sat slave and master at one table in a world that couldn't imagine it. No power, no approval, no wall. And the sociologist Rodney Stark ran the arithmetic and found it growing at something near forty percent a decade, sustained for three centuries, until a persecuted minority of a few thousand had become half an empire. It didn't merely survive without the three things the three answers crave. It came alive without them. It has always come alive without them. The three answers are all, every one of them, solutions to a problem the early church proves does not exist.

Fight the city, flee the city, or wall yourself off from the city. The three answers look like enemies, and they're secretly the same, because all three are afraid the faith can't survive without the power it just lost. The first three centuries are the proof that it can. That it does. That it always has.

So the three answers are not three positions to be weighed and balanced, a little power and a little accommodation and a little withdrawal blended into a moderate whole. They're three forms of a single unbelief. Three ways of not trusting that Jesus meant it when he said the gates of hell would not prevail against his church. Three ways of quietly assuming that he needs our help, our power or our relevance or our fortifications, to keep the promise he made. And he made that promise, we should remember exactly who he made it to, in a pagan district in the shadow of a rock face carved full of the shrines of other gods, to a dozen frightened men with no buildings and no budget and no cultural standing of any kind. He did not attach the promise to their dominance, because they had none. He did not attach it to their respectability, because they had none of that either. He did not attach it to any wall. He attached it to himself, and to the strange deathless thing he was starting. And that thing has now outlived every single empire that ever presided over its funeral. It will outlive this one. It does not need us to save it. It needs us to trust it. Which is the one thing all three answers refuse to do.

I said at the start that I've felt all three, and I have, and I won't end by pretending I've been cured of them, because that would be its own kind of lie, and this book has too much of the lie to correct already. On the days the news is bad I still feel the old country pulling. Still catch myself wanting the lever. Still notice the part of me that would trade the offense of the cross for a seat at the reasonable table. Still feel the wall going up around my own house when I look at my sons and the world they're inheriting. The wants don't leave. What changes, if anything changes, is what you do with them. Whether you let them run the church, or whether you name them as the flesh they are and set them down, the way Jesus set down the sword and the kingdoms and the twelve legions. And pick up instead the harder, older

thing the three answers were all invented to avoid.

Because there was a fourth answer. The exiles in Babylon were not offered the three. They were handed something harder than all of them. Something that took the true instinct buried in each and refused the fear that had twisted it. A way to hold the public weight of the faith without the sword. To love the world without dissolving into it. To be formed as a distinct people without sealing the gate. God did not tell them to conquer Babylon. He did not tell them to become Babylon. He did not tell them to hide from Babylon. He told them a fourth thing, in a letter, in words so plain and so strange the church has spent twenty-five centuries reading past them. And it's that letter, the actual letter, the one Jeremiah sat down and wrote and sent a thousand miles east to a grieving people who wanted anything but what it said, that we have to open now, and read the way it was written, before we can learn to live.

Chapter 6: The Letter to the Exiles

The first half of this book was diagnosis, and diagnosis is the easy part. It asks nothing of you. It just tells you what happened. The water drained out, the scaffolding came down, the country moved on, and now we are exiles in a land that doesn't remember us. All of that is true. And none of it tells you how to get out of bed on a Tuesday and be a Christian in the world that's actually still here. A man who knows only that he's in exile knows only that he's lost. What he needs is not a better description of what he lost. He needs a letter.

There was a letter. A prophet named Jeremiah wrote it from the wreckage of Jerusalem to people who had just watched their whole world end. Two royal envoys carried it a thousand miles east, into the court of the king who had destroyed them. We know their names. Elasah the son of Shaphan and Gemariah the son of Hilkiah, sent by Zedekiah, the puppet Babylon had left on the throne to keep things quiet. The letter went in the diplomatic pouch, tucked in among the tribute and the paperwork of a beaten vassal, and it reached the first wave of exiles already in Babylon. Deported in 597 before Christ. The king, the craftsmen, the soldiers, the leading families. Sitting in a foreign empire, waiting to go home. It is the most important piece of mail in the history of God's people. It is the reason for the rest of this book. And most of us have read one verse of it.

I want to give you the whole thing. Not the verse on the mug. The letter.

Start with what it was answering, because a letter is a reply, and

this one was written into a specific, unbearable situation. The people in Babylon were not settling in. They were grieving. And their grief had a shape. The shape was one fixed, burning conviction: we're going home, and soon. This wasn't wishful thinking they'd cooked up on their own. It was being preached to them, in the name of the Lord, by men who held the office of prophet and spoke with total confidence. Jeremiah names them in the letter. Ahab and Zedekiah, and a man named Shemaiah, promising the captives a quick and glorious return, telling them the exile was a short humiliation God was about to reverse. And behind all of them, back in Jerusalem, stood the most famous one. His name was Hananiah. To understand the letter you have to first stand in the temple and watch the two prophets face each other, because everything the letter forbids and everything it commands is a reply to what Hananiah said.

The scene sits in the chapter right before the letter, and it is one of the quietly devastating passages in all the prophets. Jeremiah had spent months walking around Jerusalem with a wooden yoke on his neck. An ox yoke. Straps and bars of wood. A piece of theater God told him to perform, a walking sermon that said one thing. Submit. Put your neck under Babylon and live. And Hananiah, in the temple, in front of the priests and all the people, stood up and preached the opposite. Thus says the Lord of hosts, the God of Israel: I have broken the yoke of the king of Babylon. Within two years I will bring back to this place all the vessels of the Lord's house, and I will bring back to this place the exiled king and all the exiles. Two years. The temple treasures back. The king home. The whole nightmare undone inside twenty-four months, guaranteed in the name of the Lord of hosts, glowing with hope and faith and patriotism. Everything a grieving nation was aching to hear.

Then Hananiah did something for effect. He took the wooden yoke off Jeremiah's neck and broke it. Snapped it in front of everyone, his own bit of theater to match Jeremiah's, and he said it again. Thus says the Lord: even so will I break the yoke of Nebuchadnezzar from the neck of all the nations within two years.

Watch what Jeremiah does, because it is not what a fanatic does, and it is the first thing the letter teaches. He does not shout Hananiah down. He does not call him a liar to his face in that moment. Standing there with his yoke in pieces on the temple floor, he says one of the most poignant sentences a true prophet ever spoke to a false one. Amen. May the Lord do so. May the Lord make the words that you have prophesied come true. And he means it. Nothing would make Jeremiah happier than for Hananiah to be right. For the yoke to break, for the vessels and the king and the people to come streaming home in two years. Jeremiah is not the man who enjoys the hard word. He is the man crushed by having to say it. Then, having agreed with everything Hananiah's hope wanted, he says the thing that separates the true prophet from the false one in every age. The prophets before us prophesied war and famine and plague. The one who prophesies peace will be known as a true prophet only when his word comes true. The burden of proof sits on the man selling comfort. And later, God gives Jeremiah the word to finish it. You have broken wooden bars, he tells Hananiah, but you have made in their place bars of iron. The comfort you're peddling doesn't lighten the yoke. It doubles it. And you have made this people trust in a lie. Hananiah the prophet died that same year, in the seventh month, exactly as Jeremiah said he would.

That is the confrontation the letter answers. And now you can hear the letter for what it is. Jeremiah's reply to Hananiah,

carried to the very people Hananiah was lying to, and built to take away, gently and for good, the one hope they were clinging to.

The false prophet is always the one who tells you it will be short. He does not lighten the yoke. He swaps it from wood to iron and calls that mercy.

So the letter opens. These are the words of the letter that Jeremiah the prophet sent from Jerusalem to the surviving elders of the exiles, and to the priests, the prophets, and all the people, whom Nebuchadnezzar had taken into exile from Jerusalem to Babylon. Notice the first thing it says about who sent the exiles there, because it is the hinge of everything that follows and it is easy to miss. Thus says the Lord of hosts, the God of Israel, to all the exiles whom I have sent into exile from Jerusalem to Babylon. Whom I have sent. Not whom Nebuchadnezzar dragged. Not whom Babylon stole. Whom I sent. In one clause God claims the whole catastrophe. The empire that burned the temple was, without ceasing to be guilty, the tool of a God who was doing something on purpose. The exiles were not the losers of history who had slipped out from under their God's protection. They were deported by the hand of the God who was still, even here, especially here, their God. That is the ground the whole letter stands on. You are not lost. You are sent.

And then, having claimed the sending, the letter tells them what to do inside it. The commands are so ordinary and so shocking that the shock slips right past a reader who's only ever heard them at weddings. Build houses and live in them. Plant gardens and eat their produce. Take wives and have sons and daughters, take wives for your sons and give your daughters in marriage, that they may bear sons and daughters, multiply there, and do not

decrease. Six commands, plain as bread, handed to a people who wanted a seventh. The one they were praying for. The command to pack. And the command to pack never comes. Build. Plant. Marry. Multiply. Every one of those verbs is a stake driven into Babylonian ground. You don't build a house you plan to leave by spring. You don't plant a garden, and least of all an orchard, in dirt you expect to walk away from. You don't marry your daughter into an exile you think is almost over. Each command is a small permanence, and permanence was the one thing the grieving heart couldn't bear, because permanence meant Hananiah was wrong and the seventy years were real.

I have to be honest about how much this offends the natural piety of a suffering people, because I feel the offense myself and I suspect you will too. The devout instinct of the exile is to hold Babylon at arm's length. Sit loosely on the land. Keep the bags by the door and the heart fixed on home. Surely a faithful person doesn't sink roots into the empire that murdered his nation. Surely the holy posture is the provisional one, the refusal to be at home in a place under judgment. And God says no. He tells them to do the thing that feels like surrender. Commit. Put your weight down. Stop living on the balls of your feet, ready to run the second the door opens. Accept that this Babylon, this pagan and hostile and idol-crammed city, is where your one life is going to be lived. The letter takes the fantasy of the quick return and hands you a shovel instead. Not a ticket home. A shovel.

But the commands to build and plant and marry are the setup. They clear the ground. They make the exile stop waiting and start living. And then, at the center of the letter, comes the sentence the whole thing was built to deliver. The command that should stop the heart of anyone who has ever felt his country slipping out from under him. But seek the welfare of the city

where I have sent you into exile, and pray to the Lord on its behalf, for in its welfare you will find your welfare.

Seek the welfare of Babylon. Pray for the prosperity of the empire that burned the temple, broke the walls, killed the king's sons in front of him and then put out his eyes, so the slaughter of his children would be the last thing he ever saw. Seek the good of that. Want it to thrive. Pray, by name, for the flourishing of the city that did that to you. There is no command in the Old Testament more scandalous, and we have read it on so many mugs that we have sanded the scandal clean off. It has to be recovered before the letter can do its work. This is not the kind of thing anyone says to a conquered people. It is the exact opposite of what every conquered people in history has ever wanted to hear, which is that their conqueror will burn. And the God of Israel says: bless it.

The word matters, and everything turns on hearing it at full strength. The word translated welfare, both times, is the Hebrew shalom. We've shrunk shalom down to a thin, private thing. Quiet. The absence of conflict. An inner calm. It is nothing so small. Shalom is wholeness, the way a thing is when it works the way it was made to work, the full flourishing of a common life. A city has shalom when the hungry are fed and the worker is paid what he's owed and the stranger is safe and the sick are tended and the weak are not ground under by the strong and the neighbors know one another's names. To seek the shalom of Babylon is to seek all of that, for the actual city, for the good of the actual people packed into it, most of whom worshiped gods that were not God. God commands the exiles to become agents of the wholeness of the empire that enslaved them. Not to find a quiet corner where they can practice their private religion undisturbed. To seek the flourishing of the whole pagan city, and

to do it as a people who belonged entirely to someone else.

This is the third thing, and it is why the letter is the map for the whole book. It forbids the two answers the exiles wanted and the two answers we still want. There was a faction in Babylon that wanted to fight, that listened to Hananiah and Ahab and Shemaiah, that believed the yoke would break and the whole arrangement would be cranked back into place. That faction is still with us, wearing the flag, sure the right movement or the right election is about to reverse the exile and take the country back. God does not tell the exiles to fight. He tells them not to. And there was a quieter faction that wanted to disappear. Stop being Jewish. Let the strangeness dissolve into Babylon until the ache of being different went away. That faction is still with us too, filing down every hard edge of the faith until it can't be told apart from the settled opinion of the age. God does not tell the exiles to assimilate either. He commands the third thing neither faction could imagine. Stay, and be entirely distinct, and pour yourself out for the good of a city you will never control and were never allowed to conquer. Not take Babylon. Not become Babylon. Seek the welfare of Babylon, on behalf of a God it does not know, while bowing to none of its gods.

I laid out the three failures earlier in this book, so I won't run the whole case again, but I want to name what the letter exposes about all of them at once, because it's the thing none of them can see about itself. Every one of them is trying to escape the exile. The fighter escapes it by force, refusing to accept that it's real. The assimilator escapes it by surrender, refusing to stay the kind of person exile makes strange. And the third temptation, the one the letter forbids most sharply, is to escape it by withdrawal. Wall yourself off from the city and wait out the dark behind the barricade. Seek the welfare of the church and let Babylon fend

for itself. The letter forbids that one by the plainest possible means. It does not tell the exiles to build a wall. It tells them to seek the welfare of the city, and you cannot seek the welfare of a city you've walled out. All three escapes are refusals of the sending. All three say, in the end, that God was wrong to put us here, and we'll get ourselves out, by conquest or by camouflage or by retreat. And the letter says: I sent you here. Stay. Seek its shalom.

Then comes the promise that turns the whole command from a demand into a gift, the promise that keeps the seeking from being grim charity. For in its welfare you will find your welfare. In its shalom you will find your shalom. God ties the flourishing of the exiles to the flourishing of the city so tightly the two can't be pried apart. This is not a bribe, and it is not selfishness with a halo. It is a statement about how God has actually built the world. The people who spend themselves for the good of the place they've been planted will find their own good waiting there, hidden inside the good of the city. And the attempt to secure your own welfare while the city rots is not only disobedient, it's futile, because your welfare was never a separate thing. Seek the city's good, and you find your own. Hoard your own behind a wall, and you lose both. That one sentence is the whole argument of this book packed down to a seed, and it's why the ministry that carries this book carries the name it does. In its welfare you will find your welfare. Your shalom is spent, not saved. You find it only where you give it away.

And only now, after all of that, does the famous verse arrive. It has to be read in its place, or it means the opposite of what it says. For I know the plans I have for you, declares the Lord, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope. Read it where it actually sits, and feel how much bigger it

is than the private good-luck charm we cut it down to. It is not a promise your dreams are about to come true by spring. It is a word spoken to a people God has just told will spend their whole lives in Babylon, and it says: I know. I know it's long. I know most of you will die here. I have not forgotten you, and my plans for you are plans of shalom and not of harm, and there is a future, and there is a hope, at the far end of a captivity longer than your own life. The word translated welfare in that eleventh verse is the same shalom from the seventh. The same word. God did that on purpose, so we could never finally separate the good he plans to give us from the good he commands us to seek for the city. The plans verse is not a footnote we promoted to a headline. It is the reassurance stitched onto the far harder word. And the harder word is the one we have spent twenty-five centuries refusing to read.

Because the letter does not end at the promise. It circles back, on purpose, to Hananiah, to the false prophets still working the crowd in Babylon, and it warns the exiles not to let those prophets and those diviners deceive them, not to listen to the dreams that they dream, for it is a lie that they are prophesying in the Lord's name. The whole letter is bracketed by the fight with false comfort. It opens as the answer to Hananiah's two years, and it closes by naming the men still preaching Hananiah's lie in Babylon itself. In between, it hands the exiles the truth those liars couldn't stand to say. The truth is not that Babylon will fall next year. The truth is that God is with them in Babylon, that he has plans for them in Babylon, that their whole calling is to be lived out in Babylon, and that the length of it is not two years.

I feel the weight of that, and I won't pretend I stand above it, because I want the short exile as badly as anyone. I want the water back. I catch the Hananiah in my own chest, the voice that

says surely this is temporary, surely the culture will swing back, surely I'll live to see the church restored to the center of the country I grew up assuming. That voice is not faith. It is grief looking for a comfortable lie, and I know it because it lives in me. The letter does me the hard mercy of refusing it. It takes the two-year hope out of my hands and gives me, in its place, the harder and better thing. A God who sends his people into exile on purpose, who stays with them through all of it, who commands them to build and plant and marry and seek and bless and pray, and who binds their flourishing to the flourishing of a city that is not their home and never will be.

So this is the letter, whole, the way it was actually written. It claims the exile as God's own sending. It commands a beaten people to put down roots and live. It forbids the fight and forbids the surrender and forbids the retreat, and commands the third and stranger thing, to seek the welfare of the city on behalf of a God the city does not know. It ties the exile's good to the city's good so the two can never come apart. And it brackets the whole command with a warning against the prophets who promise a short exile, because the deepest lie an exile can believe is that he'll soon be going home.

Which leaves the one thing the letter says that we have not been able to face. The number Hananiah couldn't stand to name and Jeremiah wouldn't soften. Two years, Hananiah promised. Two years, and the vessels and the king and the people, all home. Jeremiah answered him with a different number, buried in the letter, spoken over a people who wanted anything but this. It is the number the whole next chapter has to reckon with, because everything about how an exile lives depends on how long he believes the exile will last. When seventy years are completed for Babylon, God said, I will visit you. Seventy years. A lifetime.

And what a man does with the one life he's been given inside that number is the difference between an exile who wastes it waiting and an exile who learns, at last, to live.

Chapter 7: Seventy Years

The cruelest word in the letter is a number. And it is the one number the exiles least wanted to hear. "When seventy years are completed for Babylon, I will visit you, and I will fulfill to you my promise and bring you back to this place." Seventy years. Not seventy days. Not the two short years the popular preachers were promising over in the temple courts. Seventy years, which in that world was about the far edge of a human life. It's the number the psalmist himself would use for the whole allotted span. "The years of our life are seventy, or even by reason of strength eighty." God does not hand the exiles a delay. He hands them a lifetime. He tells a grieving, homesick, disoriented people that the thing that just swallowed everything they loved is not a storm you wait out under an overturned boat. It is the weather of the rest of their days. And their children's days. Only their grandchildren will walk the road home.

Sit in that math a minute before you reach for anything comforting. The comfort is real, but you only earn it on the far side of the math. A man of forty hearing that letter would be a hundred and ten before the promise came due. Which is to say he'd never see it. A young mother nursing her baby on the banks of the Chebar canal would die in Babylon. And that baby would die in Babylon too, gray and old, and maybe her child, if the years were kind, would load a cart and turn it west toward a Jerusalem she'd only heard about in her grandmother's stories. Seventy years is not a comma in Israel's history. It's three generations. It is the whole working life of everyone who first unrolled that scroll, spent to the last hour on soil they didn't

choose, under a sky they didn't want, serving an empire that had burned the house of their God to the ground.

We don't like this number. And we've inherited every trick the exiles used to get around it. Set it next to what the people were dying to hear, and you can feel the pull of the lie in your own chest. There was a prophet glad to sell them the fantasy. His name was Hananiah. In the chapter right before the letter he stood up in the house of the Lord, in front of the priests and all the people, and prophesied in the name of the same God that within two years the yoke of Babylon would be broken, the plundered temple vessels returned, the king and the captives brought home. It was everything a broken nation wanted. It had the whole outward look of faith. Spoken with confidence. Bright with hope and patriotism and the promise of getting it all back. And it was a lie.

Jeremiah's answer is one of the most moving moments in all the prophets. He said, in effect, amen. May the Lord do it. "May the Lord make the words that you have prophesied come true." Nothing would make me happier than for you to be right. And then, having given the longing its full dignity, he said it wouldn't happen. He said Hananiah had made the people trust in a lie, and that the wooden yoke he'd snapped so theatrically in the courtyard would be answered by a yoke of iron. Hananiah died that same year, in the seventh month, exactly as Jeremiah said. And the people were left with the prophet who wouldn't comfort them with a falsehood. The one who put a shovel in their hands where they'd reached for a ticket home.

The false prophet of exile is always the one who tells you it'll be short. That's his whole method, in every century, wearing whatever's in fashion at the time. He is still with us. He still speaks in the name of the Lord. He still tells the grieving church

exactly what its grief wants to hear. He tells us the exile is a temporary thing, a bad patch, a swing of the pendulum that's already swinging back. He tells us the right election is about to snap the yoke. Or the right revival. The right movement. The right coalition. He tells us we're forever on the edge of taking it all back, that the water is about to come rushing back into the room and everything will be like it was. His appeal isn't that he's cynical. His appeal is that he's merciful in the cheapest way there is. He lets you off the long hook. He lets you stay angry, and hopeful, and waiting, instead of settling into the slow, unglamorous, load-bearing work of being faithful in a world that is not going to change back on your schedule.

And the true prophet, then and now, is the lonelier man. He's the one willing to say the harder number. That the cultural home the church held for centuries is not coming back in our lifetime, or our children's. And the sooner we make our peace with the seventy years, the sooner we can stop scanning the western horizon for a rescue and start planting a future in the dirt under our feet.

This is what the number exposes about the whole take-it-back project. Underneath the anger and the activism and the very real urgency, the demand to restore Christendom by force is, at the root, a refusal to accept the seventy years. It's the insistence on seeing the harvest in our own lifetime. It's the demand to be the generation that wins, to personally stand in the victory, to bring the whole thing in under a span short enough that I get to be there for the parade. And that demand, however righteous it feels, has never once in the long history of God's people produced anything but false prophets and broken people. You cannot do multigenerational faithfulness while requiring a one-generation payoff. The two things are made out of opposite

materials. The seventy years is God's gentle and devastating refusal of our hurry. It tells us the work is longer than we are. It tells us we'll pour our whole lives into something we won't see finished, and that this is not the work failing. It is the shape of the work, among a people whose God has always thought in generations and never in news cycles.

I feel the rebuke of that in a place I don't enjoy having exposed. And I'm not going to pretend I'm standing outside it, lecturing you from higher ground. I'm a man of my age. I was formed by its hurry, catechized by its metrics before I ever read a page of Scripture. I want to see the fruit of my work in my own lifetime, and if I'm honest, ideally this quarter. I have measured faithfulness by visible results the way the world measures everything. Counting the people in the room, the numbers on the screen, the reach, and calling the counting stewardship. The seventy years stands over all of that and says, quietly and without heat, that is not how my kingdom keeps time. We did this. I did this. We took the tempo of an impatient civilization and baptized it. We called our impatience zeal. And then we wondered why the church we built felt so frantic and so shallow and so perpetually one disappointment away from despair.

Now I have to guard this hard against a misreading, because these two get confused constantly. The prophet of the seventy years is not the prophet of decline. He is not telling the people it's over. He's telling them it's long. Those are completely different words, and everything hangs on the difference. Decline says the light is going out. Length says the road is farther than you thought. God keeps his people through the seventy years, all the way through, present in Babylon as fully as he was ever present in Jerusalem. And the exile turns out to be not the grave of Israel's faith but the forge of it.

This is the great irony the whole rest of the Old Testament rests on. In the place of their defeat, cut off from the temple and its sacrifices, the people who could not go up to Zion learned to gather in smaller rooms around the reading of the word. And the synagogue was born. Cut off from the priesthood, they became a people of the book, and the Scriptures were gathered and guarded and copied as never before. A faith that had leaned for centuries on a building and a city and a piece of ground got hammered, on the anvil of exile, into something portable and durable. Something that could survive anywhere, in any empire, under any hostile sky, because it had learned the hard way that its God was not confined to a single address. The seventy years did not thin Israel out. It made Israel deep. It produced the one thing that could never have been produced in the comfort of the land. A people whose witness would outlast the empire that enslaved them, and every empire after.

But notice which way the hope faces. This is the hinge of the whole thing, and it's where the church goes wrong even when it has correctly refused despair. Because there are two things that both feel like hope, and only one of them is. The hope of the seventy years is not nostalgia. Nostalgia faces backward. It aches toward the lost country, the old arrangement, the Jerusalem that was, the room where the water still held everyone up. Nostalgia spends the exile grieving a past that isn't coming back, and it dresses the grieving up as faithfulness, and it is one of the most respectable ways there is to waste a life. Biblical hope faces the other direction entirely. It faces forward, toward the thing God is doing next, toward the city he is building, toward a return that is not a reversal but an advance. The exile eaten up by nostalgia will spend the seventy years looking over his shoulder and taste nothing of the years he actually has. The exile with biblical hope will spend them building, because he knows the God who sent

him here is the same God going on ahead of him, and the promise lives in the future and not the past.

Lot's wife is the whole warning in one sentence. She was told to run forward and not look back at the burning of the old order. She looked back. And she became a pillar of salt standing on the road, a monument to the death that comes of facing the wrong way. The church that spends the exile grieving Christendom is looking back at the fire. The church that will live is the one that keeps walking.

Charles Taylor, whose big book on the secular age has been sitting under this whole argument, taught us we cannot simply reason our way back into an older world by wanting it. The conditions of belief have changed, he says, and there's no unringing that bell. There's no route back to the age when faith was the assumed and effortless floor under everyone's feet. That sounds at first like the deepest possible discouragement, and every nostalgic instinct in me wants to argue with him. But hear what it actually does. It closes off the exit we keep clawing at. And in closing it, it turns us around to face the only direction hope was ever supposed to face, which is ahead. Taylor is not telling us the light is going out. He's telling us the way back is walled, so we'll finally quit throwing ourselves against the wall and turn toward the country we're actually being led into.

Lesslie Newbigin understood the same thing from inside the ache of it. He came home from forty years as a missionary in India to find that his own Britain had become a harder mission field than the one he'd left. And he did not spend his old age trying to resurrect the Christian England of his boyhood. He asked, instead, how the gospel could be made fresh and credible to a people who had heard it and moved past it. That's a forward question. It's a question about what God is doing next among a

post-Christian people, not a backward question about how to reassemble what had fallen. That turn, from the lost past to the given future, is the whole difference between an exile who withers and an exile who plants.

And the faithful, when they've gotten this right, have always known how to plant what they will not harvest. There's no posture more foreign to a modern person, and none more necessary to recover, so let me give it a face and not leave it an abstraction. Go look at the monasteries in the long centuries after Rome fell, in the cold and the dark of what we used to call, with some arrogance, the dark ages. Picture the monk in the scriptorium at Lindisfarne or Iona or Monte Cassino, bent over a page in the failing light of a northern winter, copying the Scriptures by hand, letter by letter, line by line. The ink freezing. The fingers cramping. The eyes going decades before their time. He is copying a book he did not write, in a world falling apart around him, for readers who have not yet been born and whom he will never meet. He doesn't copy because he can see the harvest. He can't see it. The civilization his patience will one day seed is centuries past his own death, and he knows it. He copies because the word is true, and because the work is his to do, and because the seeing is God's business and not his.

Alasdair MacIntyre, ending his hard and troubling book in 1981, looked at those communities and drew from them the lesson the church has been chewing on ever since. What preserved the moral and spiritual life of Europe through the collapse of the old order, he said, was not the men who tried to prop up the dying empire. It was the men who quietly built new communities where a way of life could be sustained through the long darkness. "We are waiting," he wrote, "not for a Godot, but for another — doubtless very different — St. Benedict." He meant

we'd better stop trying to hold the empire up and start doing the patient, unglamorous, generational work of building things that will outlast us.

Or lift your eyes from the scriptorium to the cathedrals, because they teach the same lesson in stone. The men who laid the foundations of Chartres, of Cologne, of the great cathedral at Milan that took nearly six hundred years to finish, the masons who quarried and dressed and set the first courses of stone, knew a mathematical certainty about their work. They would be dead, and their sons would be dead, long before the spire rose, long before the last vault was closed, long before the finished building would shelter a single worshipper. They would never once pray inside the thing their hands had started. And they built it anyway. Cut every stone true anyway. Gave their working lives to a glory reserved for faces they would never see, content to be one faithful link in a chain whose completion belonged to God and to the unborn. That is gardening on the scale of centuries. That is exactly the posture the seventy years asks for. The willingness to plant orchards whose shade will fall on strangers, to work for a harvest that isn't yours to gather, to build the cathedral you won't worship in and copy the book you won't see read.

Eugene Peterson gave this the name that stuck to it, and it belongs here more than anywhere. He borrowed a phrase, by a strange route through Nietzsche of all people, and called the whole shape of discipleship a long obedience in the same direction. He wrote it against what he named an instant society. A culture of immediacy that has trained us to expect everything now and to quit anything that doesn't pay off fast. And he argued that following Christ is constitutionally the opposite of that. Not a burst. Not a campaign. Not a launch with a metric that has to move by the end of the quarter. A slow walk in one direction,

sustained across a whole life. Most of it uphill. Most of it unphotographed. Most of it in weather.

The instant society has now thoroughly colonized the church, and we barely notice, because it's the water we swim in. We want revival by next year. We want a recovered culture by the next election. We want our own sanctification on a visible, reportable schedule. So we plant nothing slow, because nothing slow shows up in the numbers, and we abandon the ground the second it fails to produce. And then we stand around bewildered that the faith we're handing our children feels so thin and so anxious and so easily blown over. A garden cannot be hurried and cannot be faked and cannot be measured at the speed we measure everything else. A people that has forgotten how to do anything slowly has forgotten how to do the one thing the exile most requires.

The demand to win in our own lifetime is the root of every fast and ruinous answer the church keeps reaching for. It is not zeal. It is the refusal of the seventy years.

Let me take the objection seriously, because it's a serious one and it deserves better than a wave of the hand. And I've felt its force. Someone will say, this counsel of patience is exactly how the church loses. This is quietism dressed up as wisdom. This is how you comfort people into surrender while the culture is remade around them and their grandchildren are catechized by other gods. If we plant slowly and wait on generations, the objection runs, we'll be plowed under before the seed ever sprouts, and the long obedience will turn out to be a long capitulation, and the ones telling us to be patient will be the ones who lacked the nerve to fight. I hear it. There's a real fear underneath it, and the fear is not foolish.

But look hard at what the seventy years actually asks, because it isn't what the objection thinks. It does not ask for passivity. It asks for endurance, which is the opposite. The monk copying in the dark was not surrendering. He was resisting, at a depth and on a timescale the barbarian could not reach, and the empire fell and his little sentence of faithful ink did not. Daniel served in the court of Babylon for a lifetime, and he was not quiet and was not passive. He was faithful in plain sight for seventy years and outlasted the kings who threatened him. The seventy years is not the counsel of the coward. It's the counsel that refuses the coward's shortcut, which is the demand for a fast win, because the fast win is the very thing that keeps producing false prophets and burnt-out believers and a church that spends its strength on a rescue that isn't coming and has nothing left for the life it actually has. Patience of this kind is not the absence of struggle. It is struggle that has made its peace with not seeing the end. Which is the only struggle that has ever actually held.

And this is finally where the famous verse belongs. The one on the coffee mug and the graduation card and the framed print in the foyer, put back at last into the sentence it was cut out of. "For I know the plans I have for you, declares the Lord, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope." We took that line and made it the most personal promise in the Bible. A private guarantee that my particular dreams are on their way, that my future is bright, that God is arranging good things for me specifically and soon. We did that, every one of us who has ever leaned on it that way, by a little quiet surgery. We cut the verse loose from the four verses in front of it and the terrible number they hold.

Read it now in its actual place, strapped to the seventy-year sentence, and feel how much stronger and how much stranger it

gets. God is not saying your wishes will come true by spring. He is saying something to a people he has just told will spend their entire lives in exile. He is saying, I know. I know it's long. I know most of you won't see the end of it. I know I've asked you to build houses you'll die in and plant gardens whose fruit will feed your grandchildren and not you. And I have not forgotten you. My plans for you are plans of shalom and not of harm. There is a future, and there is a hope, on the far side of a darkness longer than your own life, for a people willing to settle in and trust me through the whole of it. That is not a good-luck charm. It is the promise of a God who does not evacuate his people out of the long dark but goes down into it with them, and keeps them, all the way through, and brings them, in the end, home.

The word in that promise, the same Hebrew word that runs through the whole letter, is shalom. And it will not be shrunk to the thin thing we usually make of it. It is not mere quiet. Not the absence of trouble. Not a private inner calm. It is wholeness. The way things are meant to be when they are finally right. A whole city at peace. And God attaches that word, that enormous word, not to a quick deliverance but to a long faithfulness. The plans of shalom are the plans of a God playing a longer game than the false prophet can stand to name. Weaving a good out of the very exile the people wanted only to escape. Working across three generations toward a wholeness no two-year rescue could ever have produced. To believe that verse in its real setting is not to believe God will make your life comfortable soon. It is to believe that God is good over a span of time longer than your ability to see it. And that faithfulness inside that span, even faithfulness that dies with the promise still unfulfilled in your hands, is not wasted. Because the God who keeps time in generations forgets none of it.

So the question the letter puts to us, before it ever tells us to build or plant or marry or seek or pray, is whether we can bear the seventy years at all. That's the prior question, and everything else waits on the answer. Can we give our lives to a recovery we won't live to see, and call that faithfulness instead of failure. Can we be a link in a chain and be content not to be the clasp. The exiles who could bear the number became Daniel in the king's court and Esther in the palace and a people whose portable, durable faith outlasted Babylon and Persia and Greece and Rome and is being read this morning in ten thousand rooms while the empires that despised it are dust in museums. The exiles who could not bear it spent their one life waiting for a homecoming that came, when it finally came, too late for them. And they missed the whole strange gift of the years they actually had, grieving forward toward a Jerusalem their eyes would never see and blind to the Babylon their feet were standing in. The number is seventy. That part is not up to us. The only thing up to us is what we will do with the one life we've been given inside it.

I said I would not lecture you from higher ground, and I meant it. So let me end where the rebuke lands on me. I do not naturally have the patience this chapter is about. I want the harvest, and I want to be there for it, and I have to be re-formed, season after season, into a man who can plant what he will not taste and count it joy. But I've come to believe this re-formation is not a diminishment of hope. It's the purification of it. The hope that could only survive if I got to see the payoff was never really hope in God at all. It was hope in my own timeline wearing God's clothes. The hope that can plant an orchard, press the seed into the Babylonian dirt, and walk away knowing another set of hands will do the gathering, that hope is aimed at God himself and not at my need to witness the result. And it is the only hope that will still be standing when the sun comes up on the drought.

We are early in something long. We are the first exiles, unrolling a letter that names a number we do not like. And the whole of our faithfulness turns on whether we can hear that number, and grieve it, and then reach anyway for the tools the letter puts in our hands.

Because the letter does not stop at the number. It never does. Having taken away the fantasy of the quick rescue, having told the people the exile will fill their whole lives, the letter turns, in the very next breath, to verbs. It refuses to leave us paralyzed, knowing only that the road is long. It moves straight into the imperative, into the unglamorous and load-bearing business of how an exile actually builds a life on ground he did not choose. And the first of those verbs is the most ordinary and the most audacious of all, so ordinary that its sheer defiance can slip right past you. To a people straining west toward the first sign of home, sitting loose on the land because surely, surely this is temporary, God says the one thing they cannot bear to hear and the one thing that will save them. Build houses. Build the kind of thing a man builds only when he has decided, in his bones, that he is staying. Put down foundations. Put down your weight. And live.

Chapter 8: Build Houses

When God finally tells the exiles what to do, the first command is so ordinary you can miss how much nerve it takes. Build houses and live in them. Not pitch tents. Not throw up something you can strike and fold and load on a cart the day the call comes to march home. Houses. Foundations. Load-bearing walls. A roof pitched to shed the rain of many winters. The kind of thing a man builds only when he's decided, in his bones, that he's staying. And to a people leaning west toward the horizon for the first sign of rescue, sitting loose on the land because surely this is temporary, surely we won't be here long, God says the one thing their grief could not stand to hear. Stay. You live here now. Build something you can't carry when you go, because you're not going. Not for a long time. And the sooner your hands admit it, the sooner your soul can follow.

We hurry past this one because it sounds easy, the throat-clearing before the letter says something spiritual. It's the opposite. It's the hardest word in the whole letter. Harder than the seventy years, because you can grieve a number from a distance, but a house is a decision you make with your hands, in a particular place, this week. The number tells you how long. The house tells you where. And it tells you now, and it won't let you keep your options open. You can absorb a number and set it on a shelf. A house gets built or it doesn't, and either way your body has answered the prophet before your heart caught up.

Think about what a built house actually is. Before it's a shelter, it's a confession. A house says I am staying. It says I am exposed, I have decided this particular patch of a pagan empire is

worth the labor and the lumber and the risk of permanence. You can't un-build a house in a hurry. You can't slip out of a foundation the way you slip out of a tent. To lay a foundation in Babylonian ground is to put down a marker your enemies can see and your children can inherit. A public bet, one you can't take back, that you'll be here when the mortar cures, and here when the roof needs mending, and here, most likely, when they lower you into the same ground you built on. The tent-dweller keeps faith with the road. The house-builder keeps faith with the place. And God, to a people who wanted nothing on earth so much as the road home, commanded the house.

Permanence, it turns out, is the thing every other command depends on. See that plainly before we go on, because if you miss it you'll misread everything after it. You can't seek the welfare of a city you're about to abandon. You can't love a neighbor you've walled out or written off as a temporary nuisance. You can't plant a garden in ground you plan to leave by spring. You can't raise children into a place, or pray with any real weight for a place, that you're holding at arm's length, weight on your back foot, bags by the door, ready to bolt the second it opens. Every command after this one grows out of this one. Build houses is not the first item on a list of six equal things. It is the soil the other five are planted in. It is the command to put your weight down.

Let me be exact about what that means, because it's a posture of the soul before it's a matter of real estate, and people confuse the two. It doesn't mean you'll never move again. It doesn't mean God has chained you to a zip code. It means the end of living provisionally. The death of the reservation, that quiet withholding by which a man can be physically present in a place for years and never actually arrive there. Never fully commit.

Always one eye on the exit, one portion of the heart held back for the better place that's surely coming next. The exile who lives that way has technically relocated to Babylon and has never once lived there. His body is in the empire and his life is in a country that no longer exists. God, with four plain words, forbids it. Build houses and live in them. Be here. All the way here. On purpose.

There are exactly two ways to refuse this command. The modern American church has perfected both, and I have practiced both, so let me describe them from the inside instead of from above.

The first refusal is the suitcase. The suitcase Christian keeps his bags packed by the door, and he has a verse for it, and the verse is even true. This world is not my home, I am only passing through. Paul really did say our citizenship is in heaven, and the writer of Hebrews really did say these all died in faith, having acknowledged that they were strangers and exiles on the earth, and I believe every word of it and I'll defend it against anyone who wants to make Christians too comfortable in the country they live in. But the suitcase Christian takes a true thing and puts it to a false use. He means it as piety and uses it as an excuse. Why should I pour myself into the schools of a city under judgment. Why invest in the civic life, the long slow repair of a place I'm leaving anyway. Why sink roots into ground I don't expect to be standing on much longer. The passing-through verse becomes a permission slip to skip the whole second half of Jeremiah's letter. To be present in a place without ever being committed to it. To hold the whole city at the arm's length of a man in a hotel who doesn't learn the names of the staff because he checks out Sunday. It looks spiritual. It's really a refusal to love what God has plainly told us to love. And it's the more dangerous of the two failures, precisely because it can quote

Scripture while it disobeys it.

The second refusal is the bunker. The bunker Christian also knows he doesn't belong here, and on the surface that looks like faithfulness, and some of it is. But his answer to not belonging isn't to travel light. It's to fortify. He builds a parallel everything. A walled world with its own schools and its own commerce and its own culture and its own carefully filtered air. He pulls his family and his money and his attention behind the walls and waits for the barbarians to lose interest or die off or somehow go away. There's more wisdom mixed into this one than the church usually credits, and I'll defend the part that's right when we come to formation, because the bunker at least takes seriously that the culture is catechizing us and that we need communities thick enough to resist it. But pushed to its end, the bunker is its own betrayal. It abandons the central command of the letter as surely as the suitcase does, only from the other side. The suitcase won't invest in Babylon. The bunker won't touch it. One holds the city at the arm's length of a tourist, the other at the arm's length of a fortress wall, and neither one builds a house and lives in it as a neighbor among neighbors, exposed, present, committed to the actual ground and the actual people. God forbids them both with the same four words. Build houses and live in them.

The suitcase Christian won't invest in Babylon. The bunker Christian won't touch it. God commanded neither the tourist nor the fortress, but the neighbor, exposed and staying, who builds a house he can't carry away on ground he doesn't own.

Nobody in our time has seen the cost of refusing this more clearly, or named it better, than Wendell Berry, who has spent a long working life on a single hillside farm in Henry County,

Kentucky, arguing against the whole momentum of the American economy for the radical and unfashionable act of staying put. Berry says there are two kinds of people, and the names have stayed with me for years because they're so exact. There are boomers and there are stickers. The boomer, he says, borrowing the word from his teacher Wallace Stegner, is the one always moving on. He treats every place as a resource to use and a launching pad to somewhere better. He goes where the opportunity is, extracts what the place offers, and leaves the moment it stops serving him, loyal to his own advancement and to no particular patch of ground under heaven. The sticker is the one who stays. Who settles. Who commits to a place and its people for the long haul, who isn't driven by the fear of missing the next thing, who learns a place slowly, across seasons and decades, well enough finally to love it, and tend it, and be responsible for it, and be buried in it.

And Berry's hard insight, the one both the suitcase and the bunker are built to dodge, is a sentence I think the whole American church needs written over its door. You cannot love a place in general. You can only love a place in particular. Love is not a warm benevolent glow you beam out over a region from a passing car. Love is the slow attention of someone who is not leaving, who has learned this creek and this fence line and this failing family down the road, who knows which field floods and which neighbor drinks and which widow will need her walk shoveled before she asks. You cannot love your neighbor in the abstract. There is no such creature as the neighbor in the abstract. There is only this neighbor, on this street, whose name you bothered to learn precisely because you aren't going anywhere and neither, most likely, is he. The abstraction is easy and costs nothing and does nothing. The particular is hard and costs everything and is the only love there is.

The exiles were commanded, in effect, to become stickers in Babylon. Not stickers in Judah, which would have been easy, which was only nostalgia. Stickers in the pagan city that had blinded their king and burned their temple. They were told to love the particular place they'd been planted in. Not as a cause to champion from a distance, but as a place to inhabit up close, with the patient, committed, un-glamorous love that only staying makes possible. The love a body can learn only after it has decided to remain. You don't get to that love by touring Babylon or by fortifying against it. You get to it exactly one way, the way the command prescribes. You build a house, and you live in it, and you stay long enough for the abstraction called Babylon to dissolve into the particular faces of the people on your street. And then, only then, you can start to love them the way God commanded.

Follow this all the way down and it's a question of incarnation, and the church should have understood it better than anyone alive, because it's the pattern written into the center of everything we believe. Our God did not save the world from a safe distance. He did not love humanity from the far side of the sky, in general, as an abstraction, as a species he felt warmly toward. The Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and every clause of that sentence is a scandal of particularity. He took on flesh, which is to say a body, which is to say a location, in a particular place, Bethlehem and then Nazareth, to a particular mother named Mary and a particular carpenter named Joseph, in a particular occupied province of a particular empire, at a particular datable moment when Augustus was in Rome and Herod was in Jerusalem. He walked particular dusty roads between particular named villages and got tired at a particular well in Samaria at about the sixth hour and asked a particular woman for a drink. He did not love the world by hovering above it. He loved it by

moving into it. One body, one town, one carpenter's shop, one three-year ministry within walking distance of where he was born. That staggering particularity is not incidental to how God saves. It is the method. It is the pattern of everything he does.

And the church, forgetting this, has too often chased a Christ who does not exist. An abstract, placeless, frictionless, everywhere-and-therefore-nowhere Christ, a spirit of general goodwill with no dust on his feet. We've wanted a faith of the abstraction, the region, the demographic, the movement, the platform that reaches millions we'll never meet and can't name. But the Christ of the Gospels keeps insisting, maddeningly, on the local. The particular. The embodied. The town. The table. The twelve. The neighbor you can actually touch, whose name you actually know, whose funeral you will actually attend. To build a house and live in it is to follow the incarnate God down into a real place and stay there long enough for your faith to take on flesh the way his did. To become not an idea you hold in your head but a life you live in a body, among particular people who can watch you live it and be persuaded, or not, by the watching. The incarnation is God refusing to love in the abstract. The command to build houses is God refusing to let us love in the abstract either.

Now I have to say the thing this cuts against, because it cuts against the deepest reflex of the people I'm writing to, and I feel it in myself, so I won't pretend to stand outside it. We are the most restless people in the history of the world. America was built by movement and for movement, settled by people who pulled up stakes and crossed an ocean, then pushed by people who pulled up stakes again and crossed a continent, formed at the marrow to believe the answer to almost any problem is a fresh start somewhere else. The better job, the bigger house, the

newer city, always just over the next ridge, and the free and admirable man is the one unencumbered enough to go get them. We move, on average, more than eleven times in a life. We've built an entire economy that assumes it, rewards it, and would grind to a halt without it. An economy that treats a rooted, settled, un-relocatable worker as a liability and a mobile, detachable, optimizing one as an asset. And the word we use for all this restlessness is a warm word. We call it opportunity. We call it freedom. We teach our children that staying is failure and leaving is arrival.

And the church, God forgive us, has largely gone along, and produced its own version of the boomer, and given him a pew. We now have Christians who change churches as casually and as often as they change neighborhoods. Shopping the congregations of a city for the better music, the better children's program, the better preaching, the better parking, the better fit. Loyal to their own preferences and to no particular body of believers, treating even the body of Christ as one more place to boom rather than stick. The pastor of any church that's stood for a while knows this family. They arrive in a wave of enthusiasm. They serve for a season. They're fed and they're known. Then a friend gets excited about the newer church across town with the better band, and they're gone. No wound. No conversation. No covenant broken, because no covenant was ever made. Off to the next thing the way a boomer is always off to the next thing, and the ground they were briefly planted in closes over the hole and does not remember them. We church-hop the way we job-hop and house-hop, and we've baptized the whole restless enterprise and called it finding where God is leading. It is very often nothing but the American disease with a worship set. The sovereign consumer self, exercising its sovereignty over the one place it was never meant to shop.

The command to build a house stands against every bit of that, gently and without apology. It says there's a kind of faithfulness you can only learn by staying, a depth that only grows where roots are left undisturbed across years, a knowledge of God and neighbor and self that is simply not available to the man who is always about to leave. It says the rootless, mobile, endlessly optimizing life our culture calls freedom is, for the soul, a kind of homelessness we've mistaken for liberty. The boomer is free the way a tumbleweed is free. He goes wherever the wind of opportunity blows him. He is attached to nothing and responsible for nothing and known by no one, and he calls the whole hollow arrangement freedom because he has never tasted the other thing. The deep and costly and rooted joy of the man who stays, who is planted, who has given his one life to a particular place and a particular people and been given, in return, a home. There is a liberty on the far side of commitment that the tumbleweed will never know, and the command to build a house is the door to it.

Let me be careful and fair, because you can turn a command into a cruelty by pressing it past its meaning, and I am not preaching a law against ever packing a truck again. People must sometimes move, and the letter knows it, and I know it. Jobs end and aren't replaced. Callings genuinely change and God genuinely leads. A dying parent in another state needs a child close. A marriage begins and one person's roots have to give way to make one home out of two. A church becomes something a family in good conscience cannot stay in, and leaving is not consumerism but faithfulness. There are a hundred good and even holy reasons a household loads a truck, and the command to build houses is not a chain around anyone's ankle forbidding it. It is not, first, a policy about real estate at all. It is a posture of the heart, and the posture is this. Wherever God has actually planted you, right now, in this actual place, be fully here. Do not live perpetually on

the way to somewhere else. Do not keep your real life in reserve for the better place that's always just ahead. The exile who is always about to leave never really lives anywhere, no matter how many decades he stacks up in one town, because his heart has never once put its weight down. And the exile who builds a house has decided, whether he stays two years or forty, to live here, really here, with these neighbors, on this street, in this church, for as long as God keeps him. To love the place as if he'll die in it. Because he might. And because that is the only way anyone has ever loved a place at all.

I feel the whole weight of this in my own life, and I won't preach it from a safe distance, because I haven't lived it perfectly, and the gap between the command and my obedience is where I actually live. I pastor a church in Fenton, Michigan. A particular town with a particular water tower and particular potholes and particular families whose stories I've been let into over years. And I can tell you that everything of any weight I have ever done as a pastor came from staying. From being the one still here when the season turned. From having sat at enough hospital beds and graveside services with the same people that they finally trusted me with the things you only tell someone who isn't leaving. None of that was available to me in my first year, when I was still a stranger, still an abstraction to them and they to me. It came only through the slow accumulation of not going anywhere, which is the pastoral form of Berry's staying, the sticker's love aimed at a congregation. And I can also tell you the pull to boom is real even for a settled pastor. The private fantasy of the bigger church in the more interesting city where the ministry would finally be what I imagine it should be. That fantasy is exactly the thing Jeremiah's first command puts to death. It says the ministry God has for you is not in the imagined elsewhere. It is in the house you're standing in, among the people

whose names you already know, and it will only ever be as deep as your willingness to stay put and let it get deep.

So build the house. Lay the foundation you can't slip out of, in the particular ground of the particular Babylon where God has actually set you down, among the particular neighbors he has actually given you. Stop living out of a suitcase. Stop hiding in a bunker. Stop shopping the city for a better fit. Put your weight down, all of it, on the ground under your feet. That is the first command, and it is the ground the rest of the letter is planted in, and until a people has obeyed it there is nothing else to say to them, because every other instruction assumes a people who have decided to stay.

But a foundation is not a home, and here the letter does something we're almost certain to miss, because we skim right over the second half of the first command. It does not say only build houses. It says build houses and live in them. And the living in them is a harder and stranger command than the building, because we are people who have gotten very good at constructing lives we do not actually inhabit. We know how to acquire and improve and manage a house, and we're slowly forgetting how to dwell in one. How to eat and sleep and rest and be known and simply be human under a roof that is ours. You can build the house and never move in. It's possible, and it's common, to put your weight down on the ground and still hold your life at arm's length, to be a resident who is never quite at home. So having commanded us to stay, the letter turns at once to what it means to actually live in the place we've committed to. And that question runs straight into the two great arenas where a human life is either inhabited or squandered, the six days of our work and the seventh day of our rest. Build the house. Now learn, which is harder, to live in it.

Chapter 9: Live in Them

The command has a second half. And the second half is the one we skip. Build houses and live in them. We heard build, and we went to work, because building is the thing we know how to do. We are a people of the loading dock and the spreadsheet and the launch. Tell us to construct something and it lands like a word in our own language. But the sentence doesn't stop at build. It keeps going, into a quieter and harder verb. And live in them. That verb turns out to be the tougher of the two. Building is doing. Living is dwelling. And we have gotten very good at the first while slowly forgetting how to do the second at all.

Let me say up front that I'm writing this chapter against myself. The man least qualified to lecture anyone about dwelling is the man who can't stop building, and that man is me. I know how to put up a life. I know how to add the project and the platform and the next thing, how to fill a calendar until it groans, how to grade a week by what came out of it. What I don't know, what I'm learning late and learning badly, is how to actually live in the thing I built. To move into my own life instead of running it from the outside like a landlord who never moves in. So read what follows as one exile talking to another about a command we've both half-obeyed. We built the house. We never quite moved in.

Because a house is not a worksite. It is not an investment. It is not a project to be optimized, and it is not a monument to how hard you work. It is a place a human being is supposed to live. Eat. Sleep. Rest. Be known. Be bored. Be interrupted. Be a creature among creatures instead of a machine among machines. The exile who builds the house and never lives in it, who treats

even his own shelter as one more thing to manage, has obeyed exactly half the command. And the half he skipped is the half about being human. God didn't send his people into Babylon to build a monument to their own diligence. He sent them there to live. The building is for the sake of the dwelling, never the other way around. A people who get that backwards have missed the whole point while congratulating themselves on their obedience to it.

The one life, and no seam in it

To live in the house means, first and most plainly, to work in Babylon. A house has to be paid for. The exiles weren't handed some holy compound funded by nostalgia and subsidized by heaven. They had to eat. They had to take their place in the ordinary economy of the city that had beaten them. Learn its trades. Keep its books. Build its buildings, farm its fields, serve the everyday needs of a pagan society, and get paid for it. And in doing that they ran straight into the truth the church keeps discovering and keeps managing to lose. For a person who belongs to God, there is no such thing as secular work.

Understand what that rules out, because it's more radical than it sounds. It rules out the seam. The exile does not have a sacred life on the Sabbath and a secular life at the workbench. A religious self on Saturday and a merely economic self the other six days. A real Christian existence that happens at worship and a neutral zone of getting and spending where God has no particular stake. He has one life, lived before one God. The workbench is as much the stage of his faithfulness as the synagogue, because the God who claims all of him claims his Monday as surely as his Sabbath. There is no corner of an exile's week where he's off the clock. No stretch of his labor that God has agreed to call profane. No forty hours he gets to write off as

dead time to endure for the sake of the few hours that count. The whole of it is his, because the whole of him is God's.

This is exactly where the Reformers landed a blow the medieval church never recovered from. And then, over the centuries, we softened the blow into a cliché. Vocation. We use the word now to mean a career, or a job we happen to like, and doing that we cut out everything that made it dangerous. Martin Luther looked at the arrangement that had quietly built up over a thousand years, the one that reserved the word calling for monks and priests and nuns, the people doing the supposedly spiritual work, while everyone else merely had an occupation. And he blew it up. He said the monk at his prayers was not one inch closer to God than the farmer at his plow. Then he gave the picture that has never lost its edge. The milkmaid at her pail. The cobbler at his bench. The magistrate on his seat. The maid sweeping the floor. Each of them, Luther said, serves God as truly and as fully as any monk in any monastery. Because God is not waiting for them in the religious corner of life. He is already there in the work of their hands, feeding the world through the milkmaid, clothing it through the cobbler, ordering the city through the magistrate, using their ordinary labor as the very way he provides for his creatures.

Luther put it sharper still. He said God milks the cows through the milkmaid. Not that the milkmaid does her work and then, separately, prays, and the praying is the holy part. That the milking itself is the mask of God. The hands God's care reaches a hungry world through. Your work, however ordinary, however invisible, however far it sits from anything that looks religious, is a place where God is at work through you for the good of your neighbor. And to do it well, to do it faithfully, to do it as an offering, is not a distraction from your calling or a compromise

with a broken economy. It is your calling. It is the thing itself.

Tim Keller spent a whole book working this out for people like us, and it matters enormously for the exile. Work is where most of us spend most of our waking lives. Which means work is where most of our actual discipleship either happens or quietly fails to. Keller said the gospel changes the why of our work, the how of it, and the for-whom of it. The why, because the Christian no longer works to justify his own existence, to prove his worth, to build a name that will outlast him. He works as one already loved, already named, already secure. Free to work without the frantic self-interest that turns every job into a scramble for significance. The how, because now the work is done with honesty and care even when no one is watching, since the audience that matters is always watching. And the for-whom, because the work is no longer aimed at the self and its advancement but at the real good it does for real people. The neighbor fed and clothed and healed and taught and housed by the work of your hands.

So the Christian in Babylon does not clock in just to fund the real Christian life that supposedly happens on evenings and weekends. He does not treat his forty hours as a toll he pays for the few hours that count. He offers the work itself. The spreadsheet and the loading dock and the classroom and the exam room and the sales call and the assembly line, done with integrity, offered to God, aimed at the good of his neighbor, as one of the main ways he seeks the welfare of the city. Your cubicle is one of the houses Jeremiah told you to build. The work you do in Babylon, if it serves the real good of the city and is done as unto God, is not a detour from your faith. It is your faith, with its sleeves rolled up.

Made to make

This goes back further than the Reformers. Further than the exile. All the way to the first pages of the story, and it won't make sense until you trace it there. On the very first pages, before there is any such thing as sin to be saved from, the God who has worked for six days and called it good sets the human being down in a garden and gives him a job. The Lord God took the man and put him in the garden of Eden to work it and keep it. Read that slowly, because everything hangs on where it falls in the story. This is before the fall. This is Eden, unbroken, the world exactly the way God wanted it. And there is work in it. The man is set down in paradise and handed something to do. Something to tend. Something to grow and order and keep.

So work is not a result of the curse. Work is part of what it means to bear the image of a working God. We are creatures made in the likeness of a Maker, so we are makers. Born to build and tend and order and grow, to take the raw stuff of the world and bring something good out of it the way God brought a world out of the deep. The curse did not invent work. Go back and read what the curse actually did. It made work hard. Cursed is the ground because of you; in pain you shall eat of it all the days of your life; thorns and thistles it shall bring forth for you; by the sweat of your face you shall eat bread. The curse laid futility and frustration and sweat and thorns across the good thing, so now the making comes with resistance and the tending comes with grief. But the thing itself, the dignity of the work, was there in the garden before a single thorn ever grew.

And it will be there at the end. The picture the Scriptures give of the redeemed world is not endless leisure. Not harps and clouds and eternal sitting around. It is a city. The new Jerusalem. And a city is a place of culture and craft and commerce and construction. A place of work restored to what it was always

meant to be, the sweat wiped away and the making left standing. The kings of the earth bring their glory into it. The nations bring their honor. Whatever all of that means, it does not mean human making stops. It means human making is finally cleaned of its futility and offered whole. So the exile who works, even in Babylon, even under the curse, even at a job no one will ever celebrate, is doing a deeply human and deeply God-imaging thing. He is joining, however dimly, the calling that began in Eden and does not end at the grave.

Which means the dignity of ordinary work has to be recovered. And recovered against a culture, and sometimes against a church, that quietly looks down on it. We have built a world that honors a tiny set of glamorous callings, the ones with a platform and a stage and a title and a following, and tells everyone else, in a thousand small ways, that their work is merely a job. A way to pay the bills until the real meaning shows up from somewhere else. The teacher and the electrician and the nurse and the mother and the man who fixes your transmission are made to feel like they're sitting in the waiting room of meaning. Like the important lives are being lived elsewhere, on screens, under lights. And the church has too often blessed this lie by saving its highest honor for the people it calls into ministry. As though the pastor's calling were a higher grade of calling and the plumber's a lower one, when Luther set them on level ground five hundred years ago and the Scriptures set them on level ground before that.

But most of what God calls people to will never be on any stage. It will be the faithful raising of children who won't thank you until they have children of their own, if then. The honest running of a small business that will never make the news. The patient teaching of a class that will forget your name. The repair of the things that break. The care of the bodies that fail. Ten thousand

acts of ordinary competence and quiet service that hold a city together and will never be applauded by anyone. The exile who has understood vocation can do that ordinary work with his head up, because he knows the God he serves is not impressed by stages. The milkmaid and the magistrate stand on level ground before the throne. And a hidden life of faithful ordinary work is not a small thing to God, even when it's invisible to everyone else.

Wendell Berry has spent a long writing life defending exactly this. The goodness of good work done well in a particular place for the sake of a real community. Work that is not extraction but membership, not a way of escaping a place but a way of belonging to it. Against the whole momentum of an economy that treats labor as a cost to cut and workers as units to move, he has argued that there is a holiness in work sized to a place and answerable to the people it serves. The man who does his work well because his neighbors will live with the result of it is doing something the abstract, mobile economy cannot even see. That's close to what the exile is called to. Not work as a ladder out of Babylon. Work as a way of loving Babylon, done among people who will have to live with how well or how badly you did it.

*Your work is not the toll you pay to fund your real life.
It is your real life, offered as worship, wherever your
hands happen to be.*

The idol and its shadow

And this is where the exile has to get watchful. A thing this good is a thing that can turn on you. Work is so good and so God-given that it makes a particularly seductive idol. The same culture that looks down on ordinary work worships work in its prestigious forms, and the two errors are not opposites. They're

twins. Both of them refuse to see work for what it actually is. A good gift that is not God. We make our jobs our identity. We answer the question of who we are with the question of what we do. A stranger at a party asks what do you do, and we hear who are you, and we reach for our title like it's our name. We pour ourselves into our careers as the source of our worth and our meaning, until the work that was supposed to be a way of loving our neighbor becomes a way of justifying our existence.

And then it eats us. No job can carry the weight of being a person's god. Ask it to tell you that you matter and it will demand more and more and more, and it will never say enough, because it was never built to say that word to you. The idol of work is the most respectable idol in America. The one we praise even as it devours us. The one we call ambition and drive and excellence while it hollows out our marriages and pushes our children away and leaves us, at sixty, successful and unknown, having built a life we were too busy to live in. We did this. I have done this. I have felt the pull of the work becoming the whole of me, the slow swap of what I produce for who I am. I have watched what it costs. And I'm telling you the truth about an idol I have knelt to.

The exile is called to work hard and work well and, at the very same time, to refuse to let the work become the thing he lives for. Those two feel like they can't both be obeyed. Like hard work and freedom from work have to trade off against each other. And the reason we can't hold them together is that we lost the practice that makes holding them together possible. The cure for the idolatry of work is not laziness. It is the very thing built into the command we're looking at, the command to live in the house and not only to build it. The command the exiles carried into Babylon in their bones. Because the cure for the idol of work is

rest. Not collapse. Not the exhausted stupor of a body that finally ran out. Rest, chosen, commanded, holy. The Sabbath.

The stopping that sets you free

To live in the house is to rest in it. The exiles carried into Babylon the strangest, most countercultural practice their God had ever given them. The practice of stopping. One day in seven, they ceased. They laid down the work, closed the shop, left the field, stopped the getting and the spending and the producing, and remembered that the world is held up by God and not by their labor. Remember the Sabbath day, to keep it holy. Six days you shall labor, and do all your work, but the seventh day is a Sabbath to the Lord your God. On it you shall not do any work. It was, and is, an astonishing command. And it gets more astonishing the harder your world presses on you. Because a defeated people in a foreign empire had every reason to work every hour they could. To claw back some security. To prove their worth to their conquerors. To never stop. And God told them to stop.

The Sabbath is the proof that work is not their god. It is the weekly declaration, written not in words but in a whole idle day, that they are not slaves. That their worth was settled before they produced anything and would stay after they could produce nothing. That the God who made the world in six days and rested on the seventh was not tired but was showing them how a life is supposed to breathe. Notice which reason the Scriptures give. In one telling, you rest because God rested. Rest is woven into the fabric of creation itself, a rhythm as basic as day and night. In another telling, in Deuteronomy, you rest because you were slaves in Egypt and the Lord brought you out, and so you shall keep the Sabbath, and your son and your daughter and your servant and the stranger inside your gates shall rest too. Sabbath

is the memory of freedom turned into a weekly habit. A slave cannot stop. A slave works at the master's pleasure until the master is done with him. So a people who stop, on purpose, gladly, one day in seven, are declaring with their whole bodies that they are not slaves. That they have a Master who commands them to rest, which is the one thing no earthly master ever commands.

And here is the diagnosis for the exile, and I feel it land on my own chest as I write it. A people that cannot stop has not been freed. It has only changed masters. The exile who builds and works and accumulates without ever resting has not actually moved into his life. He has only moved his striving from Jerusalem to Babylon. Carried his anxiety a thousand miles and set it back up in a new city, still sure the world will fall apart if he lets go of it for a day. Still believing, in the deep place under his theology, that it is his labor and not God's grace that holds everything together. The refusal to rest is not diligence. It is unbelief with a good reputation. It is the practical atheism of a man who says he trusts God and then acts, seven days a week, like the universe is sitting on his shoulders and would crash the second he set it down.

To keep the Sabbath, to actually stop, to let a whole day go by in which you make nothing and prove nothing and earn nothing and simply receive your life as a gift, is its own quiet rebellion against an empire that measures you by your output and would gladly eat every hour you have. Babylon does not want you to rest. The whole machinery of the modern economy is arranged to keep you producing and consuming without a break. To blur the days into each other until there is no seventh day at all, only an endless present of work and its worries. The phone buzzing on the nightstand. The email answered at the red light. The work

that follows you home and into your bed and into what used to be your day off. In that world, to close the laptop and keep a day holy is not quaint. It is subversion. A small weekly insurrection against the lie that you are what you produce. And it announces, to yourself and your children and anyone watching, that you belong to a kingdom that does not run on the empire's clock.

The church that will survive the long exile is going to have to recover this. Not as a rule but as a gift. Not as one more thing to fail at but as the mercy it was always meant to be. Because a people who have forgotten how to rest have forgotten how to be creatures, and a people who cannot be creatures cannot worship a Creator, since worship is exactly the act of a creature admitting it is not God. The Sabbath is the hinge where the whole week turns from striving to trust, and a life with no such hinge grinds itself down, however good its intentions. We were not built for the endless week. We were built for six and one. For labor and rest. For the making that images God and the stopping that trusts him. And an exile who keeps only the first half of that rhythm is not more devoted than his resting brother. He is only more tired, and more afraid, and more deeply enslaved to a Babylon he thinks he is defying.

Dwelling, not only maintaining

So live in the house. Not maintain it. Not manage it. Not treat it as one more asset in the portfolio of a well-run life. Live in it. And I confess I feel the weight of this command right where I am weakest, because I am far better at building than at living, far more comfortable producing than dwelling. And I suspect I'm not alone. A whole generation of us has gotten very good at building lives we do not actually live in. We build the career and the platform and the house and the calendar, and we live forever at the edge of our own lives. Hovering over them. Managing

them. Optimizing them. Anxious about them. Present in them the way a contractor is present at a site, checking the progress, never quite moving in. We are the most housed and least dwelling people in history. Surrounded by everything we built and at home in none of it.

There is a difference between a life you are maintaining and a life you are dwelling in, and the difference is everything. Maintaining is a posture of anxiety. It keeps one eye always on the thing that might go wrong, the ball that might drop, the plate that might shatter, and it feels even its own good as a set of obligations to keep from collapsing. Dwelling is a posture of trust. It receives the life as a gift, sits down inside it, lets the walls hold, and rests in the knowledge that the whole thing is held up by a hand that is not your own. The exile who merely maintains his life in Babylon is worn out by it, because he is carrying it, and it is heavy, and it was never meant to be carried by him. The exile who dwells in his life has set it down into the hands of God and moved in. He can work without frenzy and rest without guilt and be really present to the wife across the table and the child at his knee and the neighbor at his door, because he is not, in the deep place, holding everything together. He knows who is.

The command to live in the house is God's mercy to people like me. It is an instruction to stop building long enough to be human. To take up residence in the one life we've been given. To work as those who are already loved rather than those still earning their worth, and to rest as those who trust that the world will keep turning while they sleep. It is not a lesser command than build, tucked on as an afterthought. It is the point of the building. God did not tell the exiles to build houses so they could stand back and admire the construction. He told them to build

houses so they could live in them. A people who master the first verb and skip the second have missed the whole reason the first was given.

The exiles who learned this became something the empire could not account for. A people who worked among the Babylonians with visible excellence and integrity, and who then, one day in seven, simply stopped, and rested, and worshipped a God the empire could not see, and were not destroyed by the stopping but were held together by it. They were the ones who could give their labor to Babylon without giving Babylon their souls, because their souls had a Sabbath the empire could not touch. They worked the empire's fields and kept the empire's accounts and built the empire's buildings, and they were free the whole time. Free because they knew the work was not their god and the empire was not their master and their worth was not up for the daily verdict of their productivity.

And having settled into a home, and a calling, and a rhythm of work and rest, the exile is ready for the slowest command of all. The one that will ask him, even more than the house did, to believe he is really staying. A house you can throw up in a season, and a job you can start on Monday. But the next thing the letter commands cannot be hurried at all. Plant gardens, God says, and eat their produce. And a garden makes you wait. It asks you to put a seed in the ground and believe in a harvest you cannot yet see. To tend soil that shows nothing for a long time. To commit to a patch of Babylonian earth on a timescale that reaches past your own hands. It is the long faithfulness of a people who have stopped waiting to leave. And it is the truest test of whether the exile has believed the prophet at all.

Chapter 10: Plant Gardens, Eat Their Produce

You can throw up a house in a season. A garden makes you wait, and the waiting is the whole lesson. You put a seed in the ground and for weeks nothing happens. Nothing you can see. And if you plant the slow things, the fig and the vine and the olive, the orchard, you wait years, not weeks. Some of what you plant you won't taste for a decade. Some of it you won't taste at all. So when God tells a homesick people, straining west toward the road home, to plant gardens, he is telling them a truth their grief cannot carry yet. They are going to be here long enough for trees to come into their bearing. This is not a layover. This is a life. A garden is a bet on staying, made with seeds instead of stone. It is a harder bet than the house, because the house shelters you tonight and the garden asks you to believe in a future you can't see yet, and to believe it enough to kneel down in a conquered field and put something living into the dirt.

That is why the garden, not the house, tells you whether a man has actually accepted the exile or is only enduring it while he privately waits for it to end. A man who still expects to leave can build a house. He tells himself it's an investment, a thing he'll sell when the order comes to march, a roof he can walk away from. But nobody digs an orchard into ground he plans to abandon by spring. The exiles who believed Hananiah, who were sure the whole nightmare would be over in two years, would never plant a slow tree. There is no colder waste of a man's labor than to nurse a sapling for the man who conquers you next. Only the exile who has heard the word seventy years and let it land in his

body, who has quit waiting for the quick rescue and finally decided to live the life set in front of him, will bend down and press a slow seed into Babylonian soil. The garden is acceptance with dirt under its fingernails. It is the body finally agreeing with what the prophet said. We are here a long time, and the long time is not a sentence to serve. It is a life to plant and tend and, when the seasons have run, to harvest.

Notice what God does not say, because the silence is the whole point. He does not say endure Babylon. He does not say survive it, or wait it out, or hunker down until deliverance comes. He says plant a garden, which is the most forward-leaning, most hopeful, most rooted thing a person can do with a patch of dirt. A garden is an argument against despair spoken in the grammar of the seasons. Every seed the exile drops in the ground is a small sermon to his own frightened heart. The God who sent him here has not stopped being the God who makes things grow. Even in the country of his defeat the rain still falls and the sun still rises on the just and the unjust alike. The old covenant with the seasons, seedtime and harvest, cold and heat, summer and winter, has not been canceled just because the temple is a heap of ash a thousand miles behind him. To plant is to confess that God still rules the ground even here, in the land that does not know his name.

The long obedience against the culture of the instant

Eugene Peterson built a whole book on a borrowed phrase, and he called it "a long obedience in the same direction." He wrote it in 1980, against what he named an instant society, a culture of immediacy that had trained us to expect everything now and to quit anything that doesn't pay off fast. Following Jesus, Peterson argued, is built to be the opposite of that. It is a slow walk in one direction, held across a whole life, one foot in front of the other,

through weather and boredom and the long stretches where nothing seems to be happening at all. The garden is that long obedience made visible in the ground. It doesn't answer to your will, or your hurry, or your enthusiasm, or your metrics. It answers to seasons. It answers to patience. It answers to the slow faithfulness of a man who keeps tending ground that shows him nothing for a long time, who waters and weeds and prunes through the months of apparent nothing, because he knows this is simply how living things grow. Underground. Unseen. Root before shoot, and both of them long before there is any fruit to hold up as proof.

Peterson was naming a wound, and it has only opened wider since. We are a people of the launch and the campaign and the quarterly number that has to move now. We have shrunk the human sense of time down to the length of a notification, and we have hauled all of it into the life of faith. We want revival by next year. We want a recovered culture by the next election. We want our own holiness on a schedule we can watch, a straight line trending up, proof this month that we are further along than we were last month. A garden will give us none of that, and neither will God. The most important things grow on a clock we don't control and can't read. A people who have forgotten how to do anything slowly have forgotten how to do the one thing exile most requires. We plant nothing slow, because nothing slow shows up in the numbers by the time we need the numbers. We walk off the ground the minute it fails to produce. Then we stand around the frantic, shallow, perpetually disappointed thing we've built and ask out loud why the church feels so thin.

There is a deeper problem under the impatience, and Charles Taylor named it. The modern self, he argued, lives inside what he called the immanent frame, a world felt as closed and flat, a

universe of matter and mechanism with the transcendent shoved out to the edge or out of the picture altogether. And a self that lives in a flattened world will flatten its sense of time along with everything else. If this life is all there is, then every hour that doesn't visibly pay off is an hour lost forever, and waiting stops being a discipline and becomes a kind of theft. The instant society is not just a bad habit. It is the natural worship of a people who no longer believe the world is deep enough to reward patience. The garden refuses that whole frame. To plant a slow tree is to say, with your hands, that time is not a flat line running out but a deep field held by God. The years you won't live to see are as safe in his keeping as the ones you will. A life spent on a harvest you will never gather is not a wasted life. It is a life aimed right.

The deepest thing the garden teaches is how to plant what you will not harvest, and no posture is more foreign to a modern person, or more necessary to an exile. Stand, in your mind, in front of one of the great cathedrals of Europe. Chartres, or Salisbury, or Cologne. Think about the men who laid the foundations. The masons who quarried and dressed and set the first stones of Cologne in 1248 were laying the base of a building that would not be finished until 1880. More than six hundred years. Not one of them, not their sons, not their sons' sons for twenty generations, would ever worship in the finished thing their hands began. They carved gargoyles no living eye would see for centuries, tucked up in heights nobody would reach until long after every man who cut them was dust. They set stone knowing for certain they would die inside the scaffolding, that the spire was a rumor they would never live to confirm. And they built anyway. They gave their working lives to a glory they would not see, content to be one faithful link in a chain whose finish belonged to God and to the unborn. That is gardening on

the scale of centuries. It is the exact posture the seventy years demands: the willingness to plant orchards whose shade will fall on faces you will never meet, to work with everything you have for a harvest it is not yours to gather.

Scripture knew this cathedral logic long before there were cathedrals. Abraham was promised a land and a people as many as the stars, and Hebrews tells us the truth about how he held it. "These all died in faith, not having received the things promised, but having seen them and greeted them from afar, and having acknowledged that they were strangers and exiles on the earth." He greeted the promise from afar. He waved at it across a distance he knew he would not cross in his own lifetime, and he called himself a stranger, and he kept walking toward a country he would only ever see over the horizon. The whole story of the patriarchs is a story of men who planted what they would not harvest, who buried their wives in fields they bought but would not keep, who died holding a deed to a homeland their descendants would not enter for four hundred years. The exile did not invent this pattern. It only stripped away the illusion that had let a comfortable people forget it, the illusion that the harvest comes in the lifetime of the one who plants.

A garden is a bet that God, not you, will be here for the harvest. And the whole of faithfulness is learning to make that bet with your hands, not just your mouth.

I know this impatience from the inside, because it is mine, and I won't pretend to preach it down from some height I've already reached. I want to see the fruit. I want the work of my hands to show a result I can point to in a stretch of time I can stand to wait, and the garden rebukes that want every single season. It reminds me that the most important things grow on a timeline

that has nothing to do with my need to watch them grow. I have measured my own faithfulness by what I could see, the way the world measures everything, and the seventy years stands over all of it and says no. That is not how my kingdom keeps time. To plant a garden in Babylon is to make peace, in the body and not just the theology, with not being the one who harvests. It is to give my one life to a slow, faithful tending and to leave the increase, as every farmer since the first farmer has had to leave it, to God. The whole exile turns on this discipline, and it is the discipline our age has most completely lost. The church cannot recover its nerve until it recovers its patience.

The command that corrects the pious

The command is not only plant gardens. It is plant gardens and eat their produce, and the second half is aimed like an arrow at an error the pious are especially prone to. We assume that faithfulness in a hostile land must mean only labor and self-denial and grim endurance, and never, ever, enjoyment. God tells the exiles to eat. To sit down at a table in the middle of Babylon and taste the fruit of the trees they planted. To enjoy the good that even an exile's life produces, to take the ordinary pleasures of food and harvest and home as gifts and not as guilty little compromises smuggled out of a fallen world. The God who sent his people into exile did not send them into a joyless one. The exile who has learned to plant but never to eat, who treats every pleasure as a distraction pulling him off the real and serious work, has misread the command as badly as the man who never plants at all. Both of them have refused the life God actually gave.

There are two ways to fail at eating the produce, and the exile gets pulled toward both. The first is the failure of the suitcase Christian, the one who keeps his bags packed by the door, too

busy waiting to leave to ever really live where he is. He holds the goods of this life at arm's length, because they are not the goods of home, and he can't taste the bread of Babylon because his heart is always somewhere over the western horizon. He is so spiritual about his exile that he refuses its honest joys, and he calls the refusal holiness, when often it is nothing more than a failure to receive what God has actually handed him. He has decided that because this is not the country he wanted, he will not let himself be glad in it, and he mistakes his own sourness for devotion. The second failure is the exact opposite. It is the failure of the glutton, who consumes without end and tastes nothing, who is so busy grabbing for the next thing that he never once enjoys the thing already in his hand. His overconsumption is its own strange kind of inability to eat, because real eating takes presence, and gratitude, and a capacity for the word enough, and the glutton has none of the three. One man is too pious to enjoy the produce. The other is too greedy to taste it. And both have failed the simplest command in the letter, which is to sit down and eat.

The cure for both is the same, and it is gratitude. The settled, unhurried, grateful enjoyment of ordinary good as the gift of God. Paul wrote it to Timothy in a letter that could have been addressed straight to an anxious exile. "For everything created by God is good, and nothing is to be rejected if it is received with thanksgiving, for it is made holy by the word of God and prayer." Read the setting, because it sharpens the point. Paul is warning against teachers who forbid marriage and require people to stay off certain foods, a false spirituality that treats the created world as an enemy to be starved rather than a gift to be received. Against that grim asceticism Paul lays down a flat, unembarrassed line: everything God made is good, and the way you honor the Giver is not by refusing the gift but by receiving it

with thanks. Gratitude is the whole difference between the glutton and the saint at the very same table. The glutton grabs. The saint gives thanks, and in the giving of thanks the food stops being fuel and becomes something closer to a sacrament, a daily sign that the God who provides in Jerusalem provides just as surely in Babylon.

And then there is the Preacher in Ecclesiastes, the last witness you would expect on the side of joy, and for that exact reason the most convincing. Here is a man who has stared into every vanity under the sun, who has tasted every pleasure and built every great work and stacked up every possession and pronounced all of it a chasing after wind, who knows better than anyone in Scripture how fast the light fails and how completely death levels the wise man and the fool. And from inside that hard clarity, having seen through everything, he keeps circling back to the same stubborn counsel, again and again, like a refrain he can't leave alone. "There is nothing better for a person than that he should eat and drink and find enjoyment in his toil. This also, I saw, is from the hand of God, for apart from him who can eat or who can have enjoyment?" "Go, eat your bread with joy, and drink your wine with a merry heart, for God has already approved what you do." This is not some lesser, fleshly wisdom set against the higher spiritual life. This is the spiritual life, arrived at the hard way, on the far side of disillusionment. The man who has seen that nothing under the sun can carry the weight of ultimate meaning is set free, at last, to take the bread and the wine and the work of the day as exactly what they are. Small daily gifts from the hand of God, to be enjoyed with a glad heart and not squeezed for a significance they were never meant to carry.

Put those two witnesses together, Paul and the Preacher, the

apostle and the disillusioned king, and they say the same startling thing from opposite ends of the Bible. The way of holiness is not the refusal of the world's ordinary goods. It is the grateful reception of them from the right hand. The exile is not being told to numb himself to pleasure until the homecoming, gritting his teeth through a joyless captivity as if sourness were an achievement. He is being told to set a table, and eat the fruit of his own garden, and bless God over it, right there in the heart of the empire that burned his temple. That grateful table is not a betrayal of his grief. It is the answer to it.

The feast Babylon cannot manage

Sit with the strangeness of that a moment, because this is where the whole thing turns from a lesson about patience into a picture of two entirely different ways of being alive. Babylon is the great consumer. That is what an empire is, at bottom, an engine of consumption, a machine built to take, to extract, to acquire, to devour the goods and the labor and the bodies of everyone within reach and turn them into more of itself. Babylon eats without end. And yet, for all that endless eating, Babylon cannot manage a feast, because a feast is not the same thing as consumption, and the empire has never once understood the difference. Consumption grabs and swallows and reaches immediately for the next thing, and is never full, and never satisfied, and never present to what it holds. A feast receives. A feast pauses. A feast gives thanks before it takes a bite, and lingers over what it has been given, and knows the meaning of the word enough, and rises from the table not craving but content. The empire consumes the whole world and tastes none of it. The exile plants one small garden and tastes everything.

This is why the grateful table of a faithful household is, all by itself, a witness a watching pagan cannot account for. Robert

Bellah gave us the woman he called Sheila, whose entire religion was her own little voice, and that self-authored faith is the water the whole late-modern world now swims in, a world where the sovereign self is the final court and the only question worth asking of anything is whether it works for me. A self like that cannot feast, because the feast requires two things the sovereign self does not have. It requires a Giver to thank, and it requires a limit to honor, a place where you say enough and mean it. The self that answers to no one and is satisfied by nothing is sentenced to consume, to reach and grab and scroll and swipe and acquire, forever hungry in the middle of unimaginable plenty, because it has cut itself off from the one posture that can turn plenty into gladness, which is gratitude, and gratitude requires a Someone to be grateful to. The exile who bows his head over a plate of ordinary food and thanks the God of heaven for it is doing something the empire, in all its power, is structurally unable to do. He is enjoying his life. And an empire that consumes everything and enjoys nothing has no answer to a man who has almost nothing and enjoys it all.

There is more here than a contrast, though. There is a foretaste, because the produce of the exile's garden is never only a present pleasure. It is a down payment on a coming one. Every harvest the exile gathers in Babylon is a small pledge of the great harvest at the end of all things, a sign that the God who gives fruit now will give the fuller fruit at the last, that the table set in exile is a rehearsal for the feast in the kingdom. Isaiah, prophesying to this very people, painted the end of the story as a banquet. "On this mountain the Lord of hosts will make for all peoples a feast of rich food, a feast of well-aged wine, of rich food full of marrow, of aged wine well refined. And he will swallow up on this mountain the covering that is cast over all peoples... he will swallow up death forever; and the Lord God will wipe away

tears from all faces." The end of exile, in the mouth of the prophet, is not an escape into a bodiless heaven. It is a feast, on a mountain, with rich food and aged wine and every tear wiped away, and the thing that gets swallowed up at last is death itself. The great consumer, consumed. To eat the produce of your garden with joy, here and now, in the middle of Babylon, is to practice for that feast, to taste in the ordinary fruit of an ordinary tree a small sure sample of the goodness waiting at the far end of the seventy years. The exile does not have to survive until the return to learn that God is good. He can taste it now, at the table he has set in the heart of the empire, and the tasting is itself an act of faith, a body rehearsing a hope it cannot yet see.

The early church understood this, and made the meal the center of everything it was, which is why the empire found it so hard to explain and so impossible to stop. Where Babylon consumed, the church feasted, and it feasted in a way that flipped the whole social order of the ancient world at a single table. Rome sorted its meals with fierce care. The good couches for the important guests, the lesser food for the lesser people, everyone seated exactly by rank and blood and wealth, the banquet itself a diagram of who mattered and who did not. And the church sat the slave down beside the master and called them both brother, and passed the same bread and the same cup to both, and gave the seat of honor to the widow and the stranger and the poor. Paul had to rebuke the Corinthians for exactly this, for letting the empire's way of eating creep back into the Lord's table, the rich eating their fill while the poor went hungry, and he told them that to eat that way was not to eat the Lord's Supper at all. The gathered meal of the Christians was a whole other kind of society pressed into an hour around a table, a feast the empire could not produce because the empire could only ever sort and consume. The church, gathered around bread and wine and

thanksgiving, could do the one thing the empire never learned. It could receive. It could give thanks. It could be full.

Rodney Stark, running the arithmetic on how a powerless minority grew into half an empire across three hostile centuries, kept landing on answers the modern church does not want to hear, because none of them involve power or platform or cultural standing. One of them is exactly this. The Christians lived, together, in a way that was visibly more full of life than the world around them, and the exhausted people of a brutal age came to see if it was real. When the great plagues emptied the cities and the pagans fled their own dying by the roadside, the Christians stayed and nursed the sick, and the ones who lived did not forget who had sat by their beds. But it was not only the crisis that drew people. It was the ordinary, daily, unforced gladness of a community that ate together and thanked God together and welcomed the children no one else wanted and cared for the widows no one else would feed. The Letter to Diognetus, written by some anonymous Christian in the second century to a puzzled pagan, put the strangeness of it exactly. They live in the flesh, he wrote, but they do not live according to the flesh. They pass their days on earth, but they are citizens of heaven. That is the paradox of the feast in exile: a people entirely at home in the goodness of created things, and entirely unowned by the empire that produced them, tasting the world more deeply than the consumers who possessed it, precisely because they had received it as a gift instead of seizing it as spoil.

What this asks of us, on a Tuesday

I have to preach this one to myself from the harder side, and it is worth confessing which side that is. My temptation has never been the glutton's. It is the striver's, the inability to stop working long enough to enjoy what the work produced, the low, constant

suspicion that rest and pleasure are indulgences I have not yet earned and probably never will. I can plant. What I cannot easily do is sit down and eat. I am far better at building than at living, far more comfortable producing than dwelling, and I suspect I am not the only one, that a whole generation of us has gotten very good at constructing lives we do not actually live in and gardens we never sit down in. We plant the career and the ministry and the reputation, and we live perpetually at the edge of our own harvest, managing it, worrying over it, measuring it, never once resting in it and never once giving thanks for it with a glad heart. And the command to eat the produce is God's specific mercy to men built like me. It is an order to stop working long enough to be a creature again, to receive the one life I have been given instead of endlessly auditing it, and to trust that the God who grows the garden will keep growing it while I rest.

So make it concrete, because a chapter about tasting that never touches a Tuesday has failed its own argument. To eat the produce of your Babylonian garden is, first and most simply, to keep a table. It is to guard the family meal against the thousand forces that would dissolve it into separate screens and staggered schedules and food eaten standing up on the way to the next thing, and to make it instead a place where the household actually stops, and looks at one another, and gives thanks out loud before anyone lifts a fork. That thanksgiving is not a formality. It is the whole difference between the empire's way of eating and the exile's, a small daily act of defiance against the consumer's reflex to grab and swallow and rush on. It is to recover the Sabbath, not as a rule but as a feast, one day in seven when you make nothing and prove nothing and simply receive your life as the gift it is, a whole day organized around the scandalous idea that the world will keep turning while you sit still. It is to notice the ordinary goods the striver and the glutton

both race past. The taste of good bread. The light through a window in the late afternoon. The particular faces around your own table. The produce of a year's slow work. And to receive each of them as what it is, a gift from a hand that has not stopped giving even in the country of your exile. And it is, hardest of all for the striver, to let the enjoyment be a form of faithfulness rather than a break from it, to believe that a father laughing at his own table is preaching the gospel to his children as surely as a father teaching them the catechism, because he is showing them, in the only language a child fully trusts, that the God his family serves is a God worth being glad about.

This is not the escape from exile. It is the way through it. The suitcase Christian will not eat because his heart has already left. The glutton cannot eat because his heart is never present. The striver forgets to eat because his heart is always three fields ahead. All three have missed the strange gift buried in the second half of the command. God did not plant his people in Babylon merely to labor there. He planted them to live there, and living includes the table, the harvest, the feast, the grateful tasting of ordinary good that says, louder than any argument, that God is present and generous and good even here, even now, even in the land that does not know his name. Plant the garden, the letter says, and plant the slow things, the fig and the vine and the long obedience whose fruit you may never taste. And then, having planted, do the thing the same command requires in the same breath, the thing the pious keep forgetting and the empire has never once managed. Sit down. Give thanks. Eat.

And now the letter turns to the deepest planting of all, the one beside which the orchard is a passing thing, the slowest seed and the longest obedience and the boldest bet any exile ever makes on a future he will not live to see. A fruit tree is a bet on a

decade. A marriage is a bet on a lifetime. A child is a bet on a world you will be dead before you get to see. The exile is about to be commanded to plant not in the soil but in the flesh, to take wives and raise children in the middle of Babylon, and that is a harder and more defiant garden than any orchard. That is where the letter goes next.

Chapter 11: Take Wives, Raise Children

The next command in the letter is the most defiant thing God says to the exiles, and it doesn't look defiant at all. It wears the most ordinary clothes a human life can put on. Take wives and have sons and daughters, God tells them through Jeremiah. Take wives for your sons and give your daughters in marriage, that they may bear sons and daughters. Multiply there, and do not decrease. Marry. Have children. Raise those children to marry and have children of their own, so the line doesn't thin out and vanish in a foreign country. He says this to a beaten, demoralized people sitting in the wreckage of their nation, a people with every reason to think their story was over. And what he commands is the most stubbornly hopeful thing a human being can do. Start a household. He commands it as an act of defiance against despair.

You have to understand what defeat does to a people before you can hear how strange this is. The command runs against a real gravity, and the gravity is real. Conquered people stop having children. It's one of the most reliable patterns in the whole record of human sorrow. When a nation breaks, when the future has been slammed shut, when the story a people told about itself collapses, the birthrate falls. It falls not by anybody's decree but by a thousand quiet private calculations made in the dark. Why bring a child into a lost cause. Why marry into the exile that broke me. Why hand my daughter to the captivity I can barely stand myself. Why pour a life into a future I've stopped believing in. The natural posture of the defeated is contraction. A slow

folding-in. A refusal of tomorrow that starts with the refusal to make more people to live in it. And it's against exactly that contraction, that quiet giving-up dressed up as realism, that God speaks his sharpest word in the whole letter. Multiply there, and do not decrease. Don't let the line die in Babylon. The exile is not the end of the future. It's the soil the future gets grown in now, and the growing starts in households that refuse to concede the story is finished.

I won't pretend this isn't hard to follow. The letter has just spent its opening lines stripping away every reason for optimism. God told them seventy years. He told them most of them will die here. He told them the popular prophets promising a quick trip home are liars. And then, having taken away the fantasy of rescue, having handed them a shovel when they wanted a ticket, the very next thing he tells this grieving people is to fall in love, and marry, and make children, and give those children away in marriage so the whole fragile business can happen all over again. That is not what despair would say. Despair says close the womb and empty the cradle. Despair says the safest thing is to make nothing that can be taken from you. God says the opposite. He tells the exiles to bet on a future they will never live to see, and to make that bet with the most irreversible thing a person can wager, which is a child.

The home as the first outpost

The reason God can command this, and the reason it isn't cruel, is that the household is the first and most durable outpost of the people of God in any foreign land. It's the smallest and the strongest unit of the faith's survival. Before there was a temple to lose, before there was a nation to conquer, before there was a king or a court or a priesthood, there was a family at a table, and the faith got carried there. This isn't a sentimental point. It's the

actual architecture God built into his people from the start, and the exile doesn't invent it. The exile only strips away everything else until this is all that's left, and forces the people to see it was always the load-bearing thing.

Go back to the passage that stands behind this whole command, the one every faithful Jew in Babylon carried in his body, the words of the Shema in Deuteronomy chapter six. "Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is one. You shall love the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your might." And then, right away, before a word is said about temples or priests or sacrifices, comes the command about how this gets passed on. "And these words that I command you today shall be on your heart. You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise."

Notice where the handoff happens. Not in the sanctuary. In the house, on the road, at the table, at the edge of sleep, and in the first grey minutes of waking. Notice who does the handing off. Not the priest. The parent. The central command for passing the faith to the next generation wasn't given to religious professionals in a holy building. It was given to fathers and mothers in the ordinary texture of a regular day. And the medium isn't a lecture or a curriculum. It's conversation, repetition, the constant low pressure of a life lived in front of a child who is always watching. You shall teach them diligently. The Hebrew word carries the sense of sharpening, of honing, the way you work an edge onto a blade with patient repeated strokes. The faith is meant to be worked into a child the way an edge is worked into steel. Not in one dramatic session but in ten thousand ordinary ones, when you sit and when you walk and

when you lie down and when you rise.

This is the wisdom the exile recovers and Christendom let us forget. Under Christendom the home could afford to be lazy about formation, and most homes were, because the whole surrounding culture carried the faith alongside the parents and backed up at every turn what got taught, or not taught, at the table. The school opened in prayer. The town closed on Sunday. The stories in the air were the Bible's stories. Even the calendar bent around the Christian year, so a child soaked up the shape of the gospel from the shape of his own days without anyone teaching it to him on purpose. A parent could be almost completely passive and still watch the faith pass to his children, because the water carried it. The home didn't have to be strong because the culture did the heavy lifting.

In Babylon the culture carries something else, and this is the hinge the whole chapter turns on. Your children are being formed all day long, without a break, by forces that never rest and are far better funded than you are. The only question is whether anything happening at your own table is strong enough to compete. The school forms them. The screen forms them. The feed forms them, hour after hour, with a catechism so constant and so seductive that most parents don't even recognize it as catechism, because it doesn't announce itself as religion. It just forms desire. It teaches a child, underneath the level of argument, what a good life looks like, what's worth wanting, who he is, whose approval matters, what will make him happy. James K. A. Smith has spent a career insisting we are not first of all thinking things who believe our way into a way of life. We are loving things, formed by what we do over and over, by liturgies. And the secular age is thick with liturgies of its own, the scroll and the screen and the store, and they're working on your children

every single day whether you've noticed or not. A liturgy doesn't need your consent to form you. It only needs your repetition.

So the family that doesn't deliberately, actively, relentlessly form its children in the faith is not staying neutral. There is no neutral. The screen doesn't wait for permission and the feed doesn't observe a truce. The passive Christian home in Babylon is not keeping the child's options open for some clean choice later. It's conceding the field. It's handing the child to Babylon's catechism by default. And then, years on, when the grown child believes what Babylon believes and wants what Babylon wants and can't see why anyone would want otherwise, the parents wonder what happened. What happened is the most ordinary thing in the world. The child was catechized. Just not by them.

Your children will be catechized by the screen and the feed unless they are catechized at the table. There is no third option. And the table has to be louder.

Marriage as covenant, not contract

None of this holds if the marriage underneath it won't hold. So before the children there's the question of the thing that makes the home possible at all. Take wives, God says. And the taking of a wife or a husband in Babylon is asked to carry a weight the surrounding culture can no longer imagine carrying. A home that forms children across decades, and a marriage that witnesses to a watching city across decades, both need the one thing the age has quietly abolished, which is permanence. And permanence is only possible where marriage is understood as a covenant and not a contract. That distinction isn't a technicality. It's the whole difference between two ways of being human.

A contract is a deal. It's an exchange of goods and services

between two parties, entered for the benefit of each, and it lasts exactly as long as it serves the interests of both. When it stops delivering, when the cost outruns the benefit, when one party finds a better deal somewhere else, the contract gets dissolved. And that's not a betrayal of the contract. It's the contract doing what a contract does, because a contract was always conditional, always a means to the ends of the people who signed it. A culture built around the sovereign self, the self as the final authority that Robert Bellah watched being born in the woman he called Sheila, can only understand marriage as a contract, because it can only understand any relationship as a contract. One more arrangement that exists to serve the individual and can be exited when it stops. The self is the point. The marriage is the tool. And a tool that stops working gets thrown out.

A covenant is a different kind of thing altogether, and the difference is the difference between the world and the kingdom. A covenant is a binding of persons that creates an obligation deeper than the benefit either party gets from it. It doesn't last as long as it serves me. It lasts because I gave my word, and my word doesn't bend to whether the arrangement is paying off this month. This is the shape of every covenant God makes. And it's no accident that Scripture reaches again and again for marriage as the picture of God's covenant with his people, because the covenant is the thing marriage is supposed to be. When God binds himself to Israel he doesn't say I will be your God as long as you meet my needs. He says I will be your God, full stop. And then he keeps saying it across centuries of Israel's unfaithfulness, through the exile itself, which is the covenant tested to its absolute limit and holding anyway. Hosea was told to marry a woman who would betray him and to keep loving her through the betrayal, exactly so his marriage would preach in the flesh what God's covenant love actually costs and actually endures. A

contract could never survive Gomer. Only a covenant could. And only a covenant does.

This is why recovering marriage as covenant isn't a private matter of personal happiness. It's a central act of the exile's witness. The exiles were told to build their marriages into Babylon as a permanent presence, and permanence is exactly what the surrounding culture can no longer produce or even picture. In an age of the provisional, where vows are treated from the start as revisable and the exit is always kept in view, a marriage that actually keeps its vows in plain sight, across decades, through the long stretches when it costs far more than it returns, is one of the loudest sermons a Christian household can preach. The neighbor who watches two people stay, and stay well, and stay tenderly, through the seasons when staying is hard and the culture would have counseled leaving a long time ago, is watching something he can't account for out of the resources of his own world. He's hearing the gospel preached in a language older and deeper than words. The language of a love that does not quit, which is the only language that can carry the news of a God who did not quit on us.

I want to steelman the contract, because it isn't held only by the shallow or the selfish, and a pastor who can't feel its pull hasn't been honest. The move from covenant to contract came dressed as compassion, and often it sincerely was. It came as a rescue for people trapped in marriages that were crushing them. Women with no power and no recourse. Homes where the covenant language had been used as a cage and a weapon, where a demand for permanence had become a demand that the abused stay and suffer. Those were real evils. And the church too often defended the evils in the name of defending the vow, and the loosening was partly a righteous refusal to keep sacrificing

human beings on the altar of an institution. I won't pretend the old arrangement was innocent. But name what was lost when we let the whole thing slide from covenant to contract, because the cost fell hardest on exactly the people the loosening was supposed to protect. It fell on the children, who need the ground under them to hold. It fell on the poor, who can't buy their way out of the instability the well-off can absorb. A culture of the disposable vow does not free the weak. It exposes them. The strong were always going to be fine, and the covenant was the one thing standing between the vulnerable and the full weight of the storm. To recover the covenant is not to recover the cage. It's to recover the shelter, and to insist, this time, that it never again be turned into a cage.

Catechized at the table

So the marriage holds, and out of a marriage that holds comes the home, and the home is where a child is either formed in a truer story than Babylon's or handed over to Babylon by default. And the forming happens less through instruction than through liturgy, less through what's said than through what's done over and over, because a child is a body before he is a mind, and the body learns what it practices.

Think concretely about what this means, because the letter isn't asking for a mood. It's asking for practices, and the practices are so ordinary they seem too small to matter, which is exactly why they matter. The family meal, guarded and unhurried, a table where the phones are gone and the faces are present and the same people show up night after night to eat and talk and be known, is a liturgy. It teaches a child, underneath anything he could put into words, that he belongs to a body that gathers. That he's not a free-floating individual optimizing his own experience but a member of a household that eats together and therefore

lives together. The world is teaching him the opposite all day, teaching him he's a consumer alone with a screen, and the guarded table is a small daily contradiction of that lie, repeated until it's in his bones.

The prayers said together at the hinges of the day, in the morning and at the meal and at the edge of sleep, are the Shema's when you lie down and when you rise turned into an actual practice. They teach a child that time itself is held by God, that the day opens and closes in his presence, that we don't seize our hours but receive them. The reading of Scripture in the home, the family gathered around the actual words, not a devotional about the words but the words themselves, is the most direct obedience to Deuteronomy six a parent has. And it's the thing most Christian homes have quietly stopped doing, having handed it off to a program at the church for one hour a week. Under Christendom that might have been enough. In Babylon it's not remotely enough, because one hour cannot compete with the thousand hours of the feed.

Family worship is the old name for this, and the name is worth recovering along with the thing, because the thing has nearly died among us. For most of the church's history, and with particular seriousness among the people who took the covenant most to heart, it was simply assumed a Christian household would gather, daily or close to it, to sing and to read the Scriptures and to pray. That the father especially carried the responsibility to shepherd the souls under his roof. That the home was a little congregation and the table a little altar. Nobody thought this was extraordinary piety. It was thought to be the ordinary shape of a Christian family. The baseline. The least a home could do. We've let it collapse into nothing, or into a hurried grace over a meal eaten in front of a television, and we

let it collapse in exactly the era when the surrounding culture stopped doing the work for us, which is a catastrophe of timing. The exile can't afford it. In Babylon the family altar isn't optional decoration on a faith the culture is carrying. It's the front line of the faith's transmission, the place where the story gets handed down or lost, and a household that won't gather to worship has already begun, quietly and with the best intentions, to hand its children to the empire.

I say all of this as a father, and I won't pretend to stand outside the undertow I'm describing, because I feel the same current every Christian parent in this country feels. The pull to hand the formation of my children off to people and devices better funded and more relentless than I am. The exhaustion at the end of a day that makes the screen so easy and the gathered table so hard. The private hope that somehow the faith will pass to them the way it passed under an arrangement that no longer exists. I've handed my sons to Babylon's catechism in a hundred small tired moments and called it giving them a break. Called it giving myself a break. And the confession isn't a side note to the argument. It is the argument. We did this. I did this. The formation of a child doesn't fail in one dramatic act of apostasy. It fails in the pile-up of ordinary surrenders, in the slow ceding of the table to the screen, one tired evening at a time. And getting it back won't come through one dramatic act of devotion either. It'll come the same way it was lost. One ordinary evening at a time, reclaimed.

The home as contrast society in miniature

What this builds, when it's built, is a home that is itself a small contrast society, and this is where the chapter connects to everything else the book has argued. Gerhard Lohfink gave the church a phrase for what it's meant to be in the world, a contrast

society, a people whose common life is so unlike the surrounding culture that the life itself becomes the argument. The household is that contrast society in its smallest and most basic form. A Christian home in Babylon should run on a visibly different physics than the world outside its door, so a child grows up having tasted, in the most formative place there is, the shape of another kingdom before he ever has words for it.

A home where people aren't consumed by their devices in a culture drowning in them. A home where the vows hold in an age that treats vows as provisional. A home where children are received as gifts and not as burdens or accessories or projects, in a civilization that's less and less sure they're worth the trouble. A home where forgiveness is practiced, actually practiced, parents asking children for forgiveness and children learning that reconciliation is possible, in a world that knows only grudges and cancellation. A home where the poor and the stranger are welcomed at the table, where hospitality isn't entertaining but the actual opening of the household to people who can't repay it, in a society organized around the closed door. A home like that doesn't need to lecture its children about the kingdom. It has let them live in the kingdom, in the one place a small child can be reached. And the child carries out into Babylon not just a set of beliefs he was told to hold but a memory in the body of a way of life that was real, that he ate at, that held him. So when he meets the kingdom again as an adult, he recognizes it, because he was raised in a rehearsal of it. The home is not the delivery mechanism for a message about the faith. The home is where the faith is first lived, or first betrayed, and the child knows the difference long before he can name it.

Multiply and do not decrease

Which brings us back to the sharp end of the command, the

phrase that unsettles modern ears, multiply there and do not decrease. It has to be rescued from a counterfeit before it can be received as the gift it is. There's a politics loose in the church right now that hears multiply and do not decrease as a demographic strategy. A call to outbreed the opposition, to win the future by sheer numbers, to turn children into ammunition in a culture war and the family into a front line. That reading turns the womb into a weapon and the household into a factory for producing partisans. It isn't what the letter means and it isn't what I mean, and it has to be named and refused, because it poisons the very thing it claims to defend.

What God commands the exiles is not a demographic weapon. It's an act of hope. It's the refusal of a beaten people to give up on the future, the quiet defiance of households that keep believing the story is worth handing on even when the surrounding world has written that story off. The point isn't to win Babylon by outnumbering it. The point is to refuse the despair that stops a conquered people from believing there should even be a next generation. To insist that a child is not a strategic asset and not a burden but a bearer of the image of God, and a sign that we have not surrendered to the story that says tomorrow isn't worth making. The natalism the letter commands is not the natalism of the culture warrior counting his troops. It's the natalism of hope against contraction, the fruitfulness of a people who believe, against all the evidence their exile could muster, that the future belongs to God and is therefore worth filling with people who will love him.

And the earliest church understood fruitfulness in exactly this hopeful, not strategic, way. It's worth remembering how the church actually grew, because we've absorbed a false picture of it. The early church didn't grow mainly by argument, and it

certainly didn't grow by conquest, because for three centuries it had no power to conquer anyone with anything. Rodney Stark ran the arithmetic and found that the astonishing growth of the church across its first three centuries, from a few thousand to something near half the empire, required no miracles of mass conversion at all. Only a steady rate of increase held across generations, the kind of patient compounding growth that comes not from crusades but from ordinary faithfulness reproducing itself year over year. The church grew, in large part, the way the exiles were told to grow. Through families. Through the steady patient handoff of the faith from parents to children, one household at a time, unglamorous and decisive.

But it grew by something more than birth, and this is the detail that ought to stop us, because it shows what the command looks like when it's fully obeyed. The Roman world the church was born into practiced the exposure of unwanted infants as a matter of course. A child not wanted, most often a girl, most often for being a girl, would be carried out and left on a hillside or a rubbish heap or beside a road to die of cold or hunger, or to be taken by whoever might use her. This was not a scandal in that world. It was ordinary. It was legal. It was the assumed right of the father to decide which of his children would live, and the philosophers who wrote about the good life saw nothing wrong with it. Into that world came the Christians, and they went out to the hillsides and the rubbish heaps and gathered up the infants the empire had thrown away, and they carried them home and raised them as their own. They multiplied their households not only by birth but by mercy, refusing to let a child be discarded, treating every exposed infant as a bearer of the image of God the empire had failed to recognize. The Letter to Diognetus, written by some anonymous Christian in the second century to explain his strange people to a puzzled pagan, put the whole ethic in a

line. Christians marry, he wrote, as all others do, and they beget children, but they do not expose their offspring. They do not throw away their young. In a world that discarded children, the church gathered them, and its fruitfulness could not be pulled apart from its reverence for exactly the lives the empire counted as garbage.

I want the church to feel the full weight of what that did, because it's the pattern for us. The Christians did not save the abandoned infants as a political program to shift the demographics of the empire. They saved them because they served a Lord who had said let the little children come to me, because they could not look at a discarded child and see anything but a person God had made. And their inability to look away, multiplied across a hundred thousand households over three hundred years, quietly rebuilt the moral imagination of an entire civilization. The empire had taught the world that a child's life was the father's to spend or discard. The church taught the world, not by argument but by the sheer accumulated weight of gathered children raised in love, that every child belonged to God and could not be thrown away. That is what multiply and do not decrease looked like when the church actually did it. Not a strategy to win. A refusal to let a single life be counted as worthless, repeated until the world could no longer count lives the old way.

What decrease actually is

And there's a hard lesson buried in do not decrease that the exile church can't afford to miss. The church most often shrinks not through persecution from outside but through failed transmission within. We picture our decline as something done to us. The pressure of a hostile age, the mockery of the cultured, the withdrawal of the culture's old support. All of that is real. But the church does not mainly die of persecution. Persecution,

historically, tends to concentrate and purify the church rather than kill it, because the blood of the martyrs, as Tertullian threw at the empire around the year two hundred, is seed. What actually decreases the church, quietly and with no drama, is a generation that holds the faith and fails to hand it on.

We have watched this happen in our own lifetime, and we've mostly refused to see it for what it is. We built congregations that kept their children endlessly busy with programs and entertainment, that mistook amusement for formation and attendance for discipleship, that assumed the faith would pass to the next generation automatically the way it had under Christendom. No deliberate effort, no family altar, no catechism, no thick practice. Only a nice youth room and a good band and a positive experience. And we watched those children grow up and walk away. Not in rebellion mostly, not with any drama, but simply because they had been catechized far more deeply by the culture than by the church that had only entertained them, and when the two stories came into conflict the deeper formation won, as it always will. The child raised on a thousand hours of the feed and one hour of a games night in the church basement was formed by the feed. This wasn't mysterious. It was arithmetic.

The exile can't afford that complacency, and the letter forbids it. In a hostile age the faith passes to the next generation only where it's deliberately, lovingly, relentlessly handed over, worked into a child by patient repeated strokes the way an edge is worked into steel, in the home first and most of all. A church that doesn't take the formation of its own children with deadly seriousness will not need to be persecuted out of existence. It will simply fail to reproduce. It will decrease, not with a bang and not with a purge, but one unformed child at a time, a slow quiet bleeding-out of a

generation that was amused instead of catechized. And it will blame the culture for a wound it inflicted on itself by neglect. Do not decrease is not mainly a command about birthrates. It's a command about transmission, about whether the story survives the handoff, and the handoff happens at the table or it doesn't happen at all.

So the home is the seedbed of everything else the letter commands. It's not a retreat into the family and it's not the bunker, because the family formed rightly is not formed to hide but to send. To raise children who will carry a different story out into Babylon as the next generation of faithful exiles, the ones who will build the houses and plant the gardens and keep the vows in the decades after we're gone. Babylon is downstream of ten thousand kitchen tables, and so is the church that will outlast it. The letter knows this, and it grounds the whole calling of exile in the humblest possible place. In a marriage that holds and a table that gathers and a child who is taught diligently when he sits and when he walks and when he lies down and when he rises.

But a home is not a fortress, and it was never meant to be, and the child who is formed rightly at the table is formed there precisely in order to be sent out from it. The family that turns inward, that pulls the walls close and forms its children only to protect them, has misread the letter as badly as the family that hands its children to the screen. The exiles were never told to build their households as bunkers against Babylon. They were told to build them, and then to open the door. The same letter that says take wives and raise children says, in the very next breath, seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile. The home is the first outpost, but it is an outpost, which means it faces outward, toward a city that does not yet know the God who formed the people at that table. And so the next

question the letter asks turns the whole household inside out. The children are being raised. The vows are being kept. The story is being handed down. For whose sake. Not only for the family's own. For the city's. And to that city, and its welfare, and the strange command to seek the good of the very empire that burned the temple, we turn now.

Chapter 12: Seek the Welfare of the City

Everything in the letter has been leaning toward this line. Now we stand under it. Build houses. Plant gardens. Take wives, raise children. Those were the warm-up. This is the hinge the whole letter turns on, the command that gathers up all the others and points them somewhere, and it ought to still knock the wind out of us the way it knocked the wind out of the first exiles who heard it read aloud in a foreign room. But seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile, and pray to the Lord on its behalf, for in its welfare you will find your welfare. Not your welfare. The city's. The flourishing of Babylon. The empire that broke the walls of Jerusalem, burned down the house of God, and marched you a thousand miles from everything you loved. Seek its good. Work for it to thrive. Actually want it to prosper. Nobody has ever said that to a conquered people. It is the exact opposite of what every conquered people in history has wanted to hear. And it sits at the dead center of the exile's life like a sun the other commands orbit.

We have to feel how outrageous it is before we have any hope of obeying it. An exile, facing the city that took everything from him, naturally leans one of two ways, and we've met both of them already. He wants Babylon to fall. He nurses the coming judgment like a coal in his chest, refuses to lift a finger for the good of the place that humiliated him, and waits for the day the empire finally gets what it has coming. Or he wants in. He envies the place, and he's quietly ready to trade his strange, costly identity for a comfortable seat at its table. Resentment or

assimilation. The clenched fist or the open hand of surrender. God forbids both and commands a third thing neither the bitter man nor the assimilated man can even picture. Pour yourself out for the good of the city. Make it more just, more whole, more alive, and do it exactly as a people who belong entirely to someone else. The exile is to be the best citizen Babylon has. Not in spite of belonging to another kingdom. Because of it. He can seek the earthly city's good with a freedom only a man whose deepest hope lies somewhere the city can't reach could ever manage.

The word for welfare here is shalom. And the whole command lives or dies on whether we hear that word at full strength or in the shrunken thing we've handed each other. We've made shalom mean quiet. We've made it mean the absence of trouble, a private inner calm, the feeling of a candle and a soft chair after a long week. That is not the word. Shalom is wholeness. It is the way things are meant to be when they're finally set right, a thick, textured flourishing that reaches into every corner of a shared life and leaves nothing untouched. A city has shalom when the hungry are fed and the worker is paid what he's owed and the stranger can walk the streets without fear and the sick are cared for and the old are not abandoned and the child is safe and the weak are not ground down under the heel of the strong. It's the field where justice and mercy and truth and peace have all sat down together and refused to get up. To seek the shalom of a city is to seek all of that. The full flourishing of a real place, for the good of the real people who live there. Not to carve out a quiet corner where you can run your private religion undisturbed while the city rots around you. It's a public word. A demanding word. It sends the exile out of his house and into the life of the city as an agent of its wholeness, and there's no way to keep it and stay behind the wall.

Walter Brueggemann spent a career reminding the church that the prophets never let shalom stay a feeling. He read it as a social vision, a picture of the whole community set right, and he insisted the Bible measures shalom not by the contentment of the comfortable but by the security of the vulnerable. He's right about that. Which means the command to seek shalom can't be satisfied by anything private. It reaches past the individual soul into the shape of a common life. So the exile who hears seek the welfare of the city and boils it down to keep your head down and your own family safe has not obeyed a smaller version of the command. He's refused it. And dressed the refusal up as prudence.

James Davison Hunter gave this whole posture a name a generation ago, in a book that landed in 2010, and the name stuck because it's exactly right. He called it faithful presence. He set it against three failed postures the church keeps reaching for in a culture it no longer runs, and all three are worth naming, because most of us are quietly living inside one of them without ever having chosen it. There's the defensive posture, the church that defines itself by what it's against, always braced, always at war, reading the city as a threat to repel. There's the relevant posture, the church so desperate to be liked by the age that it files itself down until there's nothing left the age could object to and nothing left worth accepting. And there's the purity posture, the church that only wants to withdraw, to get clean and stay clean, to pull back from the contamination of the city and wait behind the wall. Defensiveness, relevance, withdrawal. The fist, the mirror, the bunker. Against all three Hunter set faithful presence. The slow, patient, committed work for the real good of a real place, done by people whose hope is anchored somewhere the place can't touch, and who are therefore free to love it without needing it to save them.

That last part is the whole thing, and it's easy to read right past. Faithful presence is only possible for people whose final hope is not riding on the city. The second your deepest security is tied up in Babylon getting better on your schedule, you can't love Babylon. You can only use it, or fear it, or try to seize it. You'll love it the way a man loves an investment, which is to say not at all. But the exile whose real city is elsewhere, whose foundations sit somewhere no army can sack, doesn't need anything back from Babylon. And that freedom is what makes seeking its good even possible. You have to stop needing the city to save you before you can spend yourself saving it. This is the strange thing running under the whole letter. The people who need Babylon least turn out to be the ones most able to bless it.

Faithful presence is the freedom of a people who no longer need the city to be their salvation, and are finally free to be its neighbor.

And then, having handed the exiles the hardest command in the letter, God ties a promise to it so strange it turns the whole thing from charity into something surer and deeper. In its welfare you will find your welfare. He binds the flourishing of the exiles to the flourishing of the city so tightly the two can't be pried apart. When they seek Babylon's good, they are, in the deepest way open to them, seeking their own. This is not a bribe. It's not selfishness with a halo painted on. It's a statement about how God actually built the world. The people who spend themselves for the good of the place they live will find their own lives caught up in its flourishing. And the man who schemes to secure his own welfare while ignoring the city's is not just being disobedient. He's being a fool. His welfare was never separable from the welfare of the place God planted him. Seek the city's good and you'll find your own waiting for you inside it. Hoard

yours behind a wall and you'll lose both, because they were one welfare all along, and you tried to split what God had joined.

I've watched the church make this exact split. I've made it myself. And it's worth confessing before I go on, because the diagnosis in this chapter falls hardest on us. The American church, taken as a whole, has not been seeking the welfare of the city. It's been seeking its own. Its own market share. Its own political muscle. Its own comfort and protection and the survival of its institutions. It has too often looked at the real city, with its real poor and its real strangers and its real lonely people, and seen either a threat to guard against or a mission field to harvest. Rarely a neighbor whose flourishing we were simply told to want. We built our buildings and guarded our budgets and fought our fights, and the one thing we were plainly told to do, seek the good of the city and pray for its peace, we quietly left undone. Then we stood around wondering why our witness rang hollow and why the city never believed for one minute that we loved it. The answer is not complicated and it's not comfortable. Mostly, we didn't love it. We used it, or we feared it, or we tried to rule it. And a city can always tell the difference between being loved and being managed.

Because the second half of the command exposes what the church actually does when all it's doing is surviving. A church seeking its own welfare gathers. It draws people in, grows the crowd, fills the room, counts. A church seeking the welfare of the city scatters. It sends people out, into the schools and the shops and the hospitals and the neighborhoods, to spend themselves for people who will never join, never give, never show up on any tally the church keeps. The whole logic runs backward from everything our metrics reward. Which is why the command is so hard for an institution to obey. Institutions are

built to preserve themselves. This one asks the church to spend itself on a city that offers nothing back except, in the mysterious economy of shalom, everything.

The command has a shape, and this is where the false comfort has to stop, because the welfare of a city is never an abstraction and Scripture never once lets it stay one. When God tells the exiles to seek the shalom of Babylon, he's commanding something with a direction, something that leans, and it leans the same way the whole law and the prophets lean. Down. The whole witness of Scripture insists that the health of a community is not measured at the top but at the bottom. Not by the comfort of the powerful but by what's happening to the people who can't defend themselves. Read the law God gave his people and you find him circling back, again and again, with a kind of holy stubbornness, to the same four figures. The poor. The stranger. The widow. The orphan. He makes them the test of whether a society is whole, the ones by whose treatment the whole thing is weighed. "You shall not wrong a sojourner or oppress him, for you were sojourners in the land of Egypt" (Exodus 22:21). "You shall not mistreat any widow or fatherless child" (Exodus 22:22). "When you reap the harvest of your land, you shall not reap your field right up to its edge... you shall leave them for the poor and for the sojourner" (Leviticus 23:22). The corners of the field belong to the people who have no field. That is what shalom looks like when it touches dirt. So to seek the welfare of the city is to seek, first and most of all, the good of exactly the people the city is most tempted to overlook.

The God who wrote this letter is the same God who heard the cry of slaves in Egypt, and he has never once stopped bending toward the bottom of the world. That's not a sentimental add-on to his character. It's close to the center of how he's shown

himself. He is the God who hears the cry. A people who claim that God while staying deaf to the very cry he's famous for hearing have not understood the welfare they were told to seek. Seeking the shalom of Babylon means feeding its hungry, defending its weak, tending its sick, welcoming its strangers. Not as an optional program the really committed church might get to after the important work is done, but as the shape the command takes the moment it stops being a sermon and touches the ground. There is no version of seek the welfare of the city that skips the people the city has forgotten. The bias is not a suggestion. It's built into the word.

The early church understood this with a clarity that shamed an empire, and the way it sought the good of the very city that hunted it is the pattern the exile is handed. Rodney Stark, the sociologist who spent his career running the arithmetic on how a powerless minority conquered Rome from underneath, kept coming back to the plagues, because the plagues are where the pattern shows plainest. When the great sicknesses swept the Roman world, the Antonine plague in the 160s and the plague that carries Cyprian's name in the 250s, and the cities filled with the dying, the pagan response was the rational one. The ancient one. The one any of us might have picked. You fled. You left the sick by the road, even your own, and you got out, because to stay was very likely to die. And the Christians stayed. They nursed the sick, their own and their pagan neighbors alike, at appalling cost. Many of them caught the sickness and died doing it, because they served a Lord who had touched lepers and because they did not believe death got the last word. A nursed body sometimes lives. And a pagan nursed back from the edge of death by a Christian who had no earthly reason on the ledger to sit by his bed does not forget who sat there. The city's welfare was served by exiles who had every reason to let it die and chose

instead to spend themselves for its life. And the seeking was the loudest sermon the ancient world ever heard, louder than any argument. You cannot argue with a person who is dying for you and does not hate you.

There's a particular poverty the exile is set up to answer in our own moment, and it's not the kind that comes to mind first when we hear the word poor, though that kind is real and pressing and never leaves. It's the poverty of isolation. The slow fraying of the bonds that once held neighbors to each other, the emptying out of the ordinary fabric of a common life. Robert Putnam wrote the book that named it, *Bowling Alone*, published in 2000, and the picture in the title has outlived the statistics because it caught something true. Americans still bowled, he found, more of them than ever. They'd just stopped bowling in leagues. They bowled alone. And the leagues were only the visible edge of a huge withdrawal, the emptying of the clubs and the unions and the lodges and the congregations and the plain neighborly habits that once knit the country together, all of it draining away until we live and grow old and increasingly die among strangers. The years since Putnam counted have only cut the seam deeper. We are lonelier than our grandparents could have imagined being, surrounded by more people and connected to fewer, and the loneliness is not a private sadness but a public sickness, one that hollows out a whole society from the inside. Doctors now measure its cost in the body, in years taken off a life, in a death rate that rivals the older, more obvious killers. A city can be well fed and well housed and still be dying. Ours is dying of exactly this.

Into that fraying the command to seek the city's welfare lands with a fresh, almost embarrassing concreteness, because the cure for isolation is not a policy the exile has to wait on the

government to pass. It's a table. Be the neighbor Babylon forgot how to be. Learn the names on your own street, the ones you've lived beside for years and never asked. Open your table to people who have nowhere to be on a Tuesday night. Tend the lonely and the elderly and the overlooked, the widow three doors down, the old man whose kids moved away, the young family drowning and too ashamed to say so. Not as a program with a name and a budget but as the ordinary, unglamorous fabric of a life lived for the good of the real place. The church, of all the institutions still standing in a country that has come apart at this seam, is nearly the last one built to do this. A body organized around a shared table and a shared meal and the strange claim that strangers can become family. A city dying of isolation is a city whose shalom is exactly the thing the exile was sent to seek. And the exile who can't be bothered to learn his neighbor's name has walked past a mission field lying open on his own doorstep, looking for something that felt more important.

Gerhard Lohfink argued that the church was meant to be a contrast society, a community whose common life is so unlike the world around it that the life itself becomes the argument. And nowhere is that contrast more available right now than here, at the seam of loneliness, because the world has forgotten how to make what the church was built to make. The world can assemble a crowd. It can produce an affinity group in its sleep, a room full of people the market already sorted together because they were already alike. What the world can no longer make is a room where people who have nothing in common but Christ sit down at one table and call each other family and mean it across decades. The old and the young. The rich and the poor. The ones the algorithm would never have put in the same room. That room, when it actually exists, is a miracle in a lonely age. It's the most persuasive thing an exhausted world could stumble into.

And it costs nothing but the willingness to stay long enough to become a real neighbor to a real person.

This seeking belongs to neither political tribe, and it will be captured by neither, which is exactly why the church has to take it back as its own before both sides finish tearing it in half. One tribe has taken the care of the poor and the stranger and made it a partisan program, a plank in a platform, until Christians who lean the other way learned to hear the whole biblical command as the language of the enemy and quietly set it down. The other tribe took the same care and made it a partisan suspicion, a softness to be guarded against, a thing decent hard-nosed people are right to distrust, until Christians who lean that way learned to feel righteous about their coldness. Between the two of them they've handed the whole church a permission slip to ignore half of what God plainly commands while feeling justified about the half it kept, each side pointing at the other's blind spot and never once at its own. The exile refuses the whole arrangement. He takes the entire command, the poor and the stranger and the neighbor and the widow and the lonely and the weak, not because a party told him to and not to spite the party he distrusts, but because the God who sent him into the city told him to seek its shalom, and shalom has always had this shape and this bias. Toward the bottom. Toward the edges. Toward the people the powerful look past. Seek the welfare of the city, honestly, with the whole Bible open, and you'll find yourself drawn first, every single time, toward the very people the city has forgotten. And you'll find that neither tribe was ever going to lead you there, because both of them had a reason not to.

I feel the pull of the tribes in my own chest, and I won't pretend I stand above it, because the man who thinks his politics have never once edited his Bible has simply not looked closely at the

edits. I've caught myself reading past commands because they sounded like the other side, and reaching for commands because they flattered mine, and calling the whole rigged operation faithfulness. We did this. I did this. And the letter cuts under all of it, because Jeremiah was not writing to a party. He was writing to a people, and he told that people to seek the good of a pagan empire, which means the command was never going to line up neatly with any faction inside that empire, or any faction inside ours. It sits above the whole fight and judges both halves of it. The exile who has actually heard it will find himself politically homeless in exactly the way the gospel has always made its people homeless. Too generous for one tribe and too demanding for the other. Belonging, finally, to a city that shows up on no ballot.

So the command has weight, and it has direction, and it has a bias built into its bones, and it asks the exile to do the one thing the resentful can't and the assimilated won't. Spend himself for the flourishing of a city he doesn't control and will never own, bending first and always toward the people that city forgot. But there's a danger in a command this active, and the letter knows it, which is why it doesn't stop with our hands. A man can seek a city's good for a while out of grim duty with the old bitterness still simmering underneath, doing the right thing with a poisoned heart, and that poison will eventually curdle everything it touches. The work alone can't save the one who does it. Something has to go to work not only on the city but on the exile himself. On the resentment he carries. On the heart still tempted to serve Babylon while secretly hoping it burns. And the letter names that something in the very next breath. Seek the welfare of the city, and pray to the Lord on its behalf. The command doesn't end with our hands. It ends on our knees, in the hardest prayer in the whole Old Testament, the prayer that takes the

exile's bitterness apart from the inside, the prayer for the peace of Babylon. That's the work that comes next. And it's the work that makes all the rest of it possible. Because you cannot seek the welfare of a city for a lifetime that you have not first learned, on your knees and against every instinct you own, to love.

Chapter 13: Pray for the City

There's a second half to that sentence we almost never reach. The first half is so big it takes all the air in the room. Seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile. We spent a whole chapter there, on the shalom of Babylon, on the strangeness of a God who tells the deported to want good for the empire that deported them. And then the sentence just keeps going. Same breath, no pause. It adds a second command, and we've always treated it like a pious little footnote to the real work. And pray to the Lord on its behalf. Seek the welfare of the city, and pray to the Lord on its behalf, for in its welfare you will find your welfare. That's two commands, not one. Seek, and pray. And the second one isn't decoration on the first. It's the engine of it.

Let me say plainly what I think we've done with that second command, because I've done it myself for most of my ministry. We read it as the softer half. Seeking sounds like work. Prayer sounds like the thing you do once the work is done, the benediction after the sleeves come back down. So we quietly demoted it to an afterthought, the spiritual seasoning on the practical meal. And we got the whole letter backward. The prayer isn't the seasoning. It's the fire under the pot. It's the inside practice, and without it the outside seeking curdles every single time into something the letter never signed off on. Either the fighter's contempt or the assimilator's flattery. A seeking of the city's welfare that's really a seeking of my own. God knew that. He knew what would happen to a people told to want the good of their enemy if that were the only thing he told them. So he told them a second thing. Pray for the city. And the praying is

what makes the seeking possible in the first place.

Let me start with something I've found to be true and never seen said as bluntly as it deserves. You cannot go on hating a city you pray for by name every day. It's not possible. The hatred doesn't survive the praying. Put them side by side in the same soul and one of them dies, and if the praying is real and daily and specific, it's the hatred that dies, slowly, the way a fire dies when you quit feeding it. That's not a sentiment. It's a mechanism. It's one of the oldest, best-attested facts of the spiritual life, and it works whether you want it to or not, which is exactly why it's dangerous, and exactly why God commanded it to a people who had every earthly reason to want Babylon to burn.

Think about what it costs to actually pray for someone. Not to pray about them. That's easy, and it's mostly complaint in a church robe, the practice of informing God about people we already convicted. To pray for them. To stand in front of God and ask him, honestly, for their good. You can't do that and keep the person at the distance hatred needs, because prayer for another person is an act of the imagination before it's an act of the will. To ask God for someone's welfare you have to picture their welfare, and to picture their welfare you have to picture them. Not a category. Not the enemy. Not the empire. A person. A street. A family. Some particular good you're asking a particular God to hand a particular someone. And the second you picture them that way, the abstraction cracks. The enemy stops being the enemy and becomes the neighbor two doors down whose son is sick, the coworker whose marriage is going under, the official whose fear you can suddenly see sitting under his cruelty. Hatred needs the category to live. Prayer breaks the category into faces. And you can't hate a face you're holding up to God and asking him to bless.

Praying for Babylon isn't first a way of changing Babylon. It's how God changes the one who prays, until he can't tell his enemy from his neighbor anymore, because in front of God they were never two different things.

That's what the first command alone could never do, and it's why God gave both. James K. A. Smith, working from Charles Taylor and the long tradition behind him, has spent a career reminding us that we're not mainly thinking things that occasionally act. We're loving things. We're formed by what we do over and over, shaped from the outside in by practices that work on us below our arguments. He borrows the old word for those practices. Liturgies. A liturgy is a repeated action that trains a love, that bends the heart in a direction over time, that turns you into a certain kind of person not by convincing you but by rehearsing you. And here's Smith's whole point, the one the church after Christendom can't miss. The secular age is full of its own liturgies. The scroll, the screen, the store, catechizing us all day into a certain picture of the good life. And the only thing strong enough to beat a rival liturgy is a truer one. Prayer for the city is a counter-liturgy. It's the daily rehearsal that turns an exile into someone who can actually want the good of an enemy, because it works on him underneath his politics, underneath his grievance, underneath the contempt the culture war trained into him, and slowly makes him into a person whose reflex toward the city is the open hand, not the clenched fist. You don't argue yourself into loving Babylon. You pray yourself into it, one day at a time, until the love is just there, and you find you can't remember exactly when the hatred left.

I've watched this happen in my own chest, and I won't pretend it was theory to me before it was experience. There's a version of

the pastor I was ten years ago who prayed about the country the way a man reads the news, scanning for confirmation of what he already believed, arriving at God with a list of the enemy's crimes and a request that God deal with them. That isn't intercession. That's grievance with the head bowed. And what I've found, slowly, over years of trying to actually do what the letter says, to actually pray for the specific city I got planted in, is that the practice won't let you stay there. It keeps forcing the abstraction back into a face. You can't pray daily for the schools without starting to see the worn-out teachers instead of the ideology. You can't pray daily for the officials without starting to feel the weight they carry instead of only the harm they do. The prayer doesn't make you naive about the harm. It makes you unable to shrink the person down to the harm, which is a completely different thing, and it's exactly what the fighter has lost and exactly what the letter is trying to protect.

Now I have to hold up the other half, because if I stop here I've written a chapter the letter never licensed, a chapter about prayer as a technique for making us nicer to Babylon. That's not what the exiles were told to do and it's not what the prophets modeled. The same Scriptures that command prayer for the city are full of prayer against the city. Prayer that names the city's evils and asks God to end them. Prayer that doesn't soften the horror but holds it up to God at full volume. The exiles who were told to seek Babylon's shalom are the same exiles who sat down by the rivers of Babylon and wept, and wrote one of the most terrible prayers in all of Scripture, a psalm that opens in unbearable homesickness and ends in a curse so violent we skip the last verses when we sing it. By the waters of Babylon, there we sat down and wept, when we remembered Zion. And a few lines on, to the daughter of Babylon, doomed to be destroyed, blessed shall he be who repays you with what you have done to us. The

prayer for the city and the prayer against the city sit in the same book, sometimes in the same mouth. Any account of exile prayer that keeps one and loses the other has flattened the thing God actually asked for.

So let me say what I think intercession for Babylon really is, and why it takes both, and why losing either one wrecks it. The only intercession the letter authorizes holds blessing and resistance together, and it's much harder than either half alone, because each half is easy on its own. The whole difficulty is in the holding. Blessing without resistance is flattery. It's the prayer of the assimilator, the exile who's decided that seeking the city's good means never naming the city's sin, who blesses Babylon so thoroughly he can't see anything left in it to grieve, and whose prayers for the city end up sounding exactly like Babylon's prayers for itself. That's not intercession. That's surrender with the eyes closed. But resistance without blessing is contempt. It's the prayer of the fighter, the exile who names the city's sin so relentlessly he forgets the city is also full of the beloved and the lost and the bearers of God's image, whose prayers against Babylon have no warmth in them anywhere, only the cold satisfaction of the prophet watching the fire fall. And that's not intercession either. That's hatred with a religious vocabulary. The letter forbids both by requiring both at once. You bless the city and you pray against its evils, and you do the two in the same breath, and doing them together is the whole discipline. Because a heart that can hold real blessing and real resistance toward the same city at the same time is a heart that's been made, by long practice, to love the way God loves. Who so loved the world that he grieved it, and so grieved it that he came to die for it, and never once pretended it was other than it was.

Look at how the prophets actually did this, because they're the

masters of it, and they won't let us turn prayer for the city into sentimentality or spite. Jeremiah himself, the man who wrote the letter telling the exiles to seek Babylon's welfare, is the same man who wept over Jerusalem until his eyes gave out. The weeping prophet. The one who cried, oh that my head were waters and my eyes a fountain of tears, that I might weep day and night for the slain of the daughter of my people. He didn't weep because he approved of the city. He wept because he loved a city he'd spent his whole life indicting. The tears and the indictments came from the same place. That's the pattern. The prophet isn't the man who chose between loving the city and telling the truth about it. He's the man who refused to choose, who loves it enough to tell the truth and grieves the truth enough to keep loving, whose prayers carry both the blessing and the resistance without either one canceling the other. Walter Brueggemann spent much of his life teaching the church to get this back, the prophetic imagination that holds grief and hope together, that can criticize the ruling order and energize a different one in the same act. And he was right that we've mostly lost it, that we split the prophet in two and kept the half we liked. The comfortable church kept the blessing and lost the resistance. The angry church kept the resistance and lost the blessing. And the letter to the exiles won't let us keep either half alone.

I want to slow down on the mechanics, because it's one thing to say the exile has to hold blessing and resistance together and another to actually do it on a Tuesday morning with a cup of coffee and a country that grieves you. What does it look like, up close, to pray for a city that's also under judgment. It looks like naming the good you want for it and the evil you want ended, in the same prayer, without collapsing either one. It looks like asking God for the flourishing of the schools and the healing of the marriages and the peace of the streets, and in the same breath

asking him to break what's breaking the poor, to drag into the light what's being done to the vulnerable in the dark, to bring down the arrogance that grinds the weak. It looks like praying for the conversion of the very people whose policies you're praying against, holding their eternal welfare and your resistance to their present harm in the same hand, refusing to let your opposition to what they do curdle into a wish that they'd be destroyed. The Sermon on the Mount made this the actual test of whether you belong to the Father at all. Love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you, so that you may be sons of your Father who is in heaven. Notice Jesus didn't say stop calling the persecution persecution. He called it persecution in the same sentence. He named it as evil and commanded prayer for the ones committing it, and he made the two commands one, and he said doing both together is what marks a person as a child of God, because it's what God himself does, who makes his sun rise on the evil and on the good, and sends rain on the just and on the unjust. God's blessing falls on the city that crucified his Son. That's the pattern the exile is being formed into. Blessing and resistance, held together, because that's how the Father loves a world that hates him.

Now I have to steelman the objection, because it's serious and I've felt the full weight of it, and it isn't the objection of the lazy or the cynical. It goes like this. Isn't this a recipe for passivity dressed up as piety? If I'm praying for the city instead of fighting for it, am I not just baptizing my own retreat, comforting myself with the feeling of doing something while the actual evils go unopposed? The activist looks at the praying Christian and sees a man who traded the picket line for the prayer closet and called the trade holiness. And the objection has teeth, because it's true that prayer can be a hiding place. We can and do use the language of intercession to duck the cost of action. There's a

false prayer that's really just a way of handing God our responsibilities and going back to sleep. I won't pretend that danger isn't real. It's real, and I've used prayer that way, and so have you.

But the objection misses the one thing that changes everything. The letter doesn't offer prayer instead of seeking. It commands both, in the same sentence, and it puts them in an order the objection reverses. Seek the welfare of the city, and pray to the Lord on its behalf. The prayer isn't a substitute for the seeking. It's the inside life that feeds the public one, the root system under the visible tree, the hidden thing that decides whether the visible thing is alive or dead. Eugene Peterson spent his whole pastoral life fighting the reduction of the minister to a manager, the trading of the interior work of prayer for the exterior work of running a religious organization, and he understood these two aren't competitors. They're one organism. The public work of the church is only ever as deep as the private prayer underneath it, and a public ministry with no interior life is a cut flower. Bright for a few days and already dying. The person who prays for the city isn't the person who stopped working for it. He's the only person whose work for it won't eventually poison him, because his public seeking keeps getting purified by his private praying, drained of its self-interest and its contempt and its need to win, and handed back to him each morning as something closer to love. Take the prayer away and the seeking doesn't get more effective. It gets more dangerous, because now it's unwatered, and public zeal with no private prayer underneath it is exactly the thing that produced every Christian atrocity in history. The crusade and the pogrom and the auto-da-fé. Faithful men doing terrible things to the city in the name of God, with no interior life left to tell them they'd become the very evil they set out to fight.

That's the deepest reason for the second command, and it's worth saying as clearly as I can. The interior life is the guardrail on the public life. A church that seeks the welfare of the city without praying for it will, sooner or later, seek the city's welfare on its own terms, by its own vision, by its own methods, and it will end up imposing on the city a good the city never asked for. That's how the seeking of shalom becomes the machinery of coercion. That's how the love of neighbor becomes the tyranny of the improvers. The prayer is what keeps the seeking humble. It's the daily admission that I don't finally know what's best for this city, that its welfare is in the hands of a God who isn't me, that I'm an instrument of a shalom I didn't design and can't control. The one who prays for the city every morning gets reminded every morning that he's not the city's savior. And that reminder is the only thing that's ever kept the church's love for the world from turning into the church's domination of it.

So the captive becomes something the empire never expected and could not produce, and it's the deepest thing this chapter has to give you. The captive becomes a priest for the city. Think about what a priest is, in the oldest sense, the sense the whole Old Testament is soaked in. A priest stands in the gap. He represents the people to God and God to the people. He carries the community before the Lord in intercession and carries the Lord's word back to them. He bears the names of the people on his heart into the holy place. The high priest of Israel wore the names of the twelve tribes on his breastplate, twelve stones engraved with twelve names, so he carried the whole people over his heart every time he walked into the presence of God. And the astonishing thing the exile finds out, the thing that turns the whole catastrophe inside out, is that the deported people of God become, in Babylon, the priests of Babylon. Not the priests Babylon appointed to worship Babylon's gods. The priests

Babylon never knew it had, carrying the pagan city on their hearts before the God the city didn't worship, standing in a gap the city didn't know was there, interceding for a people who'd have laughed at the idea that these particular captives were praying for them by name.

This is the calling Peter names when he writes to the exiles of his own day, the Christians scattered across Asia Minor, and calls them a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for God's own possession. He isn't handing out an honorary title. He's describing a job. The whole people of God, the entire scattered dispersion of resident aliens, has become a priesthood. Which means every one of them stands in the gap for the world around them, carries the neighbors and the city and the empire before God, does for the watching pagans the one thing the watching pagans can't do for themselves. Be prayed for by someone who knows the living God. The captive isn't a victim of Babylon. The captive is Babylon's priest, its intercessor, the hidden reason the wrath is held back and the mercy runs, standing between the city and the judgment it earned, asking God for a welfare the city has done nothing to deserve. Abraham stood before the Lord and bargained him down over Sodom. Will you sweep away the righteous with the wicked? Suppose there are fifty righteous within the city. And God let a doomed city's fate hang on the intercession of one man who loved it enough to argue with God for it. That's the priestly calling of the exile. To be, in Babylon, the Abraham who stands before the Lord and pleads for a city that has no idea his name is being spoken over it in the dark.

And this priesthood isn't glamorous and it doesn't photograph and it will win no election and draw no crowd, which is exactly why it's the work the church after Christendom is being handed back. When the water held us up, we didn't need to be priests for

the city, because the city was more or less us, and the intercession went unnoticed because it seemed unnecessary. Now the city isn't us, and the gap has opened wide, and into that gap the exile is called to stand. Not with a lever. Not with a vote. Not with a program. With a name on his heart and a prayer in his mouth, doing for the city the deepest thing that can be done for it, which is to hold it before the God who made it and loves it and grieves it and hasn't yet given it up. Rodney Stark spent years working out why the early church grew through three centuries of powerlessness, and the answers he found were the visible ones. The nursing of the plague-stricken. The rescue of the exposed infants. The honor given to women and the poor. But under every visible mercy there was an invisible one. The church at prayer for the very empire that was killing it. Intercession no historian could measure, because it left no record except the changed lives of the ones who prayed, and, over three hundred years, the changed empire that couldn't finally hold out against a people who kept asking God to bless it.

I have to be honest about where this leaves me, and where I suspect it leaves you, because the demand of it is enormous and I don't stand over it. To pray for the city daily, by name, with blessing and resistance held together, as a priest standing in the gap for people who despise the God I'm pleading to, is not a thing I do naturally or do well. My prayers still curdle into grievance more often than I want to admit. I still catch myself informing God of the enemy's crimes when I meant to intercede for the enemy's soul. The interior life is the hardest work there is, precisely because nobody sees it and nobody claps and there's no metric that will ever tell you it's working, and a man formed by an age of platforms and numbers is starved for exactly the confirmation the prayer closet will never give him. But I've come to believe this hidden, unglamorous, unmeasurable work is the

actual foundation of everything else the letter commands. The building and the planting and the marrying and the seeking are all cut flowers without it. Bright for a season and already dying. And the church that's still here in a hundred years will be the church that recovered the interior life, that learned again to be a priesthood for a city that doesn't know it's being prayed for, that stood in the gap and refused to leave.

So pray for the city. Not about it. For it. Pray for the actual streets you drive and the actual schools your neighbors send their kids to and the actual officials whose names you know and whose policies you resist, and pray for their welfare and against their evils in the same breath, and let the praying do to you what only praying can do. Make you, slowly and against your will, into someone who can no longer hate what he's been asking God for years to bless. The interior life will feed the public life or the public life will die. The priest will stand in the gap or the gap will stand empty. And the exile who learns to pray for Babylon finds out, somewhere in the years of doing it, that he's been changed more than the city has, that the command to intercede was God's mercy to him before it was ever God's mercy to Babylon, that he set out to bless a city and got blessed in the blessing, exactly as the letter said, for in its welfare you will find your welfare.

But there's a hard edge waiting here that this chapter has kept its distance from, and I have to name it before I hand you off. The prayer for the city has a limit, and that limit is the whole subject of what comes next. You can seek Babylon's welfare and pray for Babylon's good with your whole heart, and there will still come a day when Babylon asks you for the one thing you cannot give it. When the city you've blessed and prayed for and served commands you to bow. And on that day the priest who loved the

city has to become the confessor who defies it, and the two aren't in tension. They're the same faithfulness meeting a different demand. The man who prayed toward Jerusalem with his windows open, three times a day, inside the very administration of the empire he served so well, was the same man who wouldn't stop when the law told him to stop, and he took the lions' den as the price of the open window. Daniel is the exile who shows us where the prayer for the city ends and the refusal to bow begins, and how one life can hold both, and how the interior life we've been describing is the only thing that makes the coming defiance possible. Because a man who hasn't been praying in secret won't have the strength to refuse in public. We've learned to pray for Babylon. Now we have to learn the one thing we will never do for it.

Chapter 14: Do Not Bow

Everything in this book so far has been an argument for staying. Build the houses. Plant the gardens. Take wives, raise children, seek the welfare of the city, pray for the empire that burned your temple. Every one of those pushes the exile deeper into Babylon. Further into a place that is not his home. Closer to neighbors who worship other gods. And if you've followed the argument this far, if you've felt the whole letter pulling you toward the city, toward love and rootedness, you should be feeling a little dizzy right about now. Because push seek the welfare of the city far enough, give the place enough of your heart, and eventually you can't quite tell the difference between seeking its welfare and belonging to it. There's a line out there somewhere. Past it, faithful presence quietly turns into assimilation. Past it, loving Babylon turns into bowing to it. And the letter hasn't told us where the line is. This is the guardrail. The one command that keeps all the others from carrying us off the cliff.

The letter doesn't spell it out. The rest of the exile story does, and it does it in one man, in two scenes, one at the top of an empire and one at the bottom of a furnace. His name was Daniel. He's the exile who did both of the things this book keeps saying can be done at once. He served Babylon brilliantly, and he would not bow. Not one without the other. Not the man who keeps his soul by keeping his distance. Not the man who joins the city by losing his soul. The third thing, the harder thing. He poured his whole competence into running a pagan empire and, at the very same time, drew a line he would die before he crossed. Daniel is the answer to the dizziness. He's what it looks like when seek the

welfare of the city and do not bow live in one life, for a lifetime, and neither one cancels the other.

Watch the serving first. We tend to rush past it to get to the dramatic part, and the serving is half the point. Daniel was a teenager when the Babylonians tore him out of Jerusalem and dropped him in the capital. They gave him a Babylonian name, Belteshazzar, named for one of their gods. They gave him a Babylonian education, the whole curriculum of the empire that had just wrecked his nation, the literature and language of the Chaldeans. They were grooming him to help run the regime that had ended his world. And he took it. He learned the curriculum. He entered the service. Over a long life he became one of the most effective public servants in the empire, so good at the actual work of governing that king after king promoted him. Nebuchadnezzar raised him up. Belshazzar reached for him in a crisis. When the Persians conquered Babylon and everything should have changed, Darius the Mede kept him and set him over the whole kingdom. The text is careful to say the reason wasn't his religion. It was his competence. An excellent spirit was in him, and he was faithful, and there was no error or fault found in him. Daniel was so good at serving the empire that the empire couldn't do without him through three regime changes and most of seventy years.

That's not a footnote to Daniel's faithfulness. That is his faithfulness, the seek-the-welfare-of-the-city half of it, lived out at the top of the pagan state. He didn't serve grudgingly, one foot out the door, doing the minimum to survive. He served with excellence, the way Jeremiah's letter demands, because for a person who belongs to God there's no such thing as secular work. Running Babylon was as much the place of Daniel's obedience as the temple in Jerusalem would have been. He

sought the shalom of an empire that wasn't his, and he sought it with everything he had, and the empire was genuinely better for having him in it. That's the man you have to read the second scene against. When the refusal finally comes, it doesn't come from a bitter outsider looking for a fight. It comes from the most loyal and capable servant the kingdom had.

Then comes the line. Daniel's an old man now, at the top of the Persian administration, and his rivals can't find one thing to pin on him. Nothing. No corruption, no negligence, no fault in his public work at all. So they do the only thing left. They go to the king and get a law passed, a beautiful trap. For thirty days no one in the empire may petition any god or man except the king himself, or it's the lions' den. They found the one place the loyal servant won't comply, the seam between serving the empire and worshiping it, and they wrote a law that forces him to stand on one side of it in public. And watch exactly what Daniel does, because the precision of it is the whole lesson. When Daniel knew that the document had been signed, he went to his house where he had windows in his upper chamber open toward Jerusalem. He got down on his knees three times a day and prayed and gave thanks before his God, as he had done previously.

Read that slowly. Every phrase is carrying weight. The windows were open. He didn't slip into a back room and pray in secret, hedging, keeping the letter of his faith while dodging the cost of it. He also didn't march into the public square and pray in the king's face to make a point, staging a confrontation, turning his defiance into a show. He just went home and did what he'd always done. On his knees, at the window, toward Jerusalem, in plain sight, three times a day, exactly as before. As he had done previously. That phrase is the hinge of the whole scene. Daniel

doesn't escalate and he doesn't retreat. He keeps the practice he already had. The empire drew a line through the middle of his ordinary prayers and told him to stop. He didn't stop. And he didn't put on a show of not stopping either. He just kept praying, windows open, and let the law do to him whatever it was going to do.

That's the shape of the refusal, and it's worth naming carefully, because the American church gets its shape so badly wrong. Daniel's no sits inside an enormous yes. He says yes to Babylon ten thousand ways, yes to its work and its service and its welfare, faithfully, ably, for decades. And then, at one point, on one thing, he says no, and the no is total, and it costs him the lions' den, and he doesn't flinch. The huge yes is what gives the small no its weight. A man who says no to everything about Babylon is just a crank, and the empire can wave him off. A man who says yes to everything is just assimilated, and he's got nothing left to refuse with. Daniel is neither. He's the servant who's earned the right to be believed when he finally won't comply, because everyone who's watched him for forty years knows he isn't looking for a fight, and knows that if this man won't bow, the thing he won't bow to must be a real God.

Serve the city with everything you have, and worship it with nothing. The line between those two is the whole of faithfulness in exile. Daniel walked it for seventy years and never once lost his footing on either side.

The other scene is his three friends, and it hands us the sentence that is, I think, the deepest thing exile ever taught the people of God about faithfulness. Nebuchadnezzar has set up a golden image on the plain of Dura and ordered that when the music plays, everyone in the empire fall down and worship it.

Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, Daniel's companions, three more brilliant young administrators of Babylon, will not fall down. The king, enraged, hauls them in, gives them one more chance, and adds his taunt: and who is the god who will deliver you out of my hands. Their answer is one I want to give exactly, because it's one of the few places in Scripture where you can watch faith and uncertainty stand in the same breath and neither one cancels the other. If this be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of your hand, O king. But if not, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods or worship the golden image that you have set up.

But if not. Three words, and they hold the entire structure of costly faithfulness. Our God is able to deliver us, they say, and we believe he will. And then, without a pause, without softening the first claim, but if not. If he doesn't. If the furnace takes us, we still will not bow. The refusal isn't riding on the rescue. They don't say we won't bow because we're sure God will save us, which would make their courage a bet on the outcome. They say we won't bow whether God saves us or not, because the bowing is wrong no matter what it costs, and their obedience isn't a wager on being spared. That's the difference between faith and its counterfeit. The counterfeit obeys God because it expects a payoff and would reconsider if the payoff didn't come. The real thing obeys because God is God, and it holds the obedience steady into the fire, even if the fire is the last thing it ever feels. But if not is the sentence that makes a martyr. It's the sentence the comfortable church has almost entirely forgotten how to say.

Now I have to turn the whole thing around and let it fall on us, because we've read Daniel for generations and we've gotten him exactly backwards. We've made him a hero of personal purity, a

man who kept himself clean, and we've used him to justify the very withdrawal the letter forbids. But Daniel didn't withdraw. Daniel was up to his elbows in the governance of a pagan empire, seeking its welfare with everything he had, and refusing only to worship it. The American church has managed, with real ingenuity, to reverse both halves of him at once. We bow to the very things Daniel would not bow to, and we refuse the very city Daniel gave his life to serve. We got him backwards. And getting Daniel backwards is a fair summary of what's gone wrong with us.

Look at what we bow to. We bow to the nation, first and most obviously, in the parts of the church that have welded the cross to the flag so completely they can't tell anymore which one they're actually worshiping. They end their prayers asking God to bless the country, and by the country they mean something very close to the kingdom itself. That's the golden image on the plain of Dura, and a great many of us fall down when the music plays and never notice we've knelt, because the image is draped in enough of our own history and our own affection that bowing to it feels like piety. We bow to the market, next, in the parts of the church that have quietly swallowed the whole logic of consumer capitalism as the water we swim in, that measure a ministry by its growth the way a business measures a quarter, that have let the categories of the brand and the platform and the market share move into the imagination of the people of God until we can barely think a thought about the church a marketing department wouldn't recognize. And we bow, most of all and most invisibly, to the self. To the sovereign little voice Robert Bellah heard in the woman he called Sheila back in 1985, the self that has become the final court of appeal, so that even our faith has quietly reorganized itself around whether it works for me instead of whether it's true. Nation, market, self. Three golden images.

And the church that won't stop talking about how the culture bows to false gods has, in a lot of rooms, fallen down before all three.

The reversal finishes itself in the part that indicts us most. While we're busy bowing to the things Daniel refused, we've refused the thing Daniel did. We've declined to seek the welfare of the city. Whole slices of the church have decided the neighbors are the enemy, that the city is Babylon in the worst sense, something to be feared and fought and walled off, and they've pulled their investment and their love and their labor back from the common good, seeking the welfare of the church and letting the city fend for itself. We've flipped Daniel completely. He served the empire and would not worship it. We worship the empire, in the forms of nation and market and self, and will not serve it. He gave Babylon his competence and withheld his knee. We give Babylon our knee and withhold our competence. If you set out to design the exact photographic negative of a faithful exile, you could hardly do better than a large part of the American church right now. And I say that as a member of it. I'm inside the diagnosis. I've caught in my own chest the reflex to bow to at least two of those three images while telling myself I was standing up straight.

So the practical question presses in, and it's the question this chapter exists to answer. If the line between serving the city and worshipping it is the whole of faithfulness in exile, and if the line isn't always obvious, how does the exile actually see it? How does Daniel know that running the empire is faithful service and bowing to the image is idolatry, when both of them, from a distance, look like cooperating with Babylon? What's the faculty that tells them apart, and can it be learned? Because the honest truth is the line doesn't announce itself. The golden image on the

plain of Dura was obvious, one dramatic moment with music and a furnace. But most of the bowing the modern exile is asked to do is nothing like that. It's gradual. It's in the air. It's dressed as ordinary participation, a thousand small accommodations, not one of which feels like idolatry. Which is exactly how assimilation actually happens. Not in one big apostasy. In ten thousand unnoticed concessions that add up, over a generation, to a church you can't tell apart from the world it was sent to serve.

The faculty that sees the line has a name. The name is discernment. And discernment isn't a mood or an instinct, it's a skill, and it's a skill the church can't survive after Christendom without. In Christendom you didn't need much of it, because the culture did your discerning for you. The water ran in a roughly Christian direction, so a person could drift with the current and end up more or less where a Christian should be. The sharp work of telling the kingdom from the world could be left mostly undone, because the gap between them was narrow and the culture kept nudging you back toward the right bank. That's over. The current runs the other way now, and a church that drifts will drift straight out to sea. The only thing that keeps an exile oriented is the deliberately trained capacity to tell, in a specific situation, the difference between serving the city and bowing to it. That capacity doesn't come naturally and it doesn't come cheap. It has to be built. Building it is one of the central tasks of the long after.

What has to be discerned, most urgently, is the set of lenses we didn't choose and can't see, the ones the culture ground and slipped over our eyes so early we mistake them for our own vision. Charles Taylor spent eight hundred pages describing one of them, the immanent frame, the way the modern person experiences the world as closed and flat and disenchanted, a

universe of matter and mechanism with God pushed out to the edges. His hardest point is that this isn't a belief we hold. It's a lens we see through. And it shapes the believer as much as the unbeliever. James K. A. Smith, reading Taylor for the rest of us, keeps pressing the same uncomfortable point. We're all breathing this air. Even our faith has gone thin and buffered and immanent. We believe in God the way we believe a fact instead of dwelling in him the way the saints did. The lens is invisible precisely because it's a lens and not an object. You don't see your glasses. You see through them. And an exile who has never once taken his glasses off to examine them has no way of knowing which of his convictions are the gospel and which are just the shape the immanent frame pressed his faith into. Discernment starts there. In the strange, hard act of catching your own inherited lenses in the act of distorting. Of asking, about some assumption you've always taken for granted, whether it came from Scripture or whether it came from the water.

This is why theological depth isn't a luxury for the exile but a survival skill, and I mean survival in the plainest sense. A shallow faith can't discern. It has nothing to discern with. It knows a few slogans and a worship set and a handful of convictions it absorbed from its subculture, and it can't tell which of those convictions are the faith once delivered to the saints and which are the residue of the last election, because it has never gone deep enough into the tradition to have a standard to measure by. The exile who wants to see the line between serving and bowing has to know the Scriptures, the whole arc of them, well enough to be corrected by them where his culture has bent him. He needs the creeds, the long memory, the company of the dead that Chesterton called the democracy of the dead, the two thousand years of the faithful who were not buffered and can therefore see what we can't. He needs enough theology in his

bones that when the golden image goes up, in whatever draped and plausible form it takes in his moment, something in him recognizes it as an image and refuses to kneel, even when everyone around him is kneeling and calling it common sense. Depth isn't decoration on the faith. In exile, depth is the thing that keeps you from bowing. And a church that neglects the forming of deep disciples isn't staying neutral. It's training its people to kneel before every image the age puts up, one undiscerned assumption at a time.

And this is finally why the two halves of Daniel have to stay together, because either one without the other collapses into a failure the exile can't afford. Serving the city without the refusal to bow is just assimilation, the church dissolving into the world it was sent to bless, so busy seeking Babylon's welfare it forgets it belongs to Someone else and ends up worshiping what Babylon worships. But the refusal to bow without the serving is its own disaster, and it may be the more tempting one for a frightened church right now. It's the posture of the exile who keeps his purity by keeping his distance, who draws his lines and defends his boundaries and refuses every accommodation, and in the process refuses the city itself, pulling his love and his labor and his prayers back from the common good in the name of not getting contaminated. That exile has kept his knee unbent and his hands empty, and he has disobeyed the letter as surely as the assimilationist, because the letter didn't send him into Babylon to stay clean. It sent him to seek the welfare of the place, and you can't do that from behind a wall. Daniel is the rebuke to both. He would not bow, and he would not withdraw. He held the no and the yes in the same life, the total service and the total refusal. That holding of both at once, the impossible-looking union of deep involvement and unbending distinctness, is the actual vocation of the church in exile. And the reason it's so rare is that

it's so hard.

I want to leave you standing where Daniel stood, at the open window, because that image carries the whole of what I've been trying to say. The windows are open toward Jerusalem, which means his heart is fixed on a city that isn't this one, a home he belongs to that Babylon can't touch. But the man at the window isn't staring out at a place he refuses to serve. He's the second most powerful man in the empire, on his knees, in the middle of his ordinary life of governing a city he's poured himself into, praying toward his true home three times a day exactly as he always has, and about to pay for it in the den of the lions and not caring what it costs. That's the exile this whole book has been building toward. Present, fully, in the life of the place. Faithful, completely, to the God of the home he actually belongs to. Serving Babylon with everything, and bowing to it with nothing, and holding both until the day he dies old and honored in a foreign land with his soul entirely intact.

Which raises the last question, the one that carries us into the final part of this book. Daniel could do it because Daniel was formed to do it, because there was something in him deep enough and rooted enough to recognize the golden image and refuse it while everyone else knelt. Where does a people like that come from? Not a person. A people. Because the three in the furnace didn't stand alone. They stood together, three of them refusing at once, and Daniel himself came out of a community that had been forming exiles for generations before he was born. A single heroic individual is not a strategy. The question is how you grow a whole people who can serve the city and will not bow to it, a community formed deeply enough that its members recognize the images the age erects and decline to kneel, not by their own private strength but because they belong to a body that

has trained them to see. That people has existed before. It existed for three centuries in the heart of an empire far more hostile than ours, with no power and no standing and nothing but the strange, irresistible quality of its common life. And it did not merely survive there. It converted the empire that was killing it. Before we can be that people again, we have to go back and look at how they did it the first time, the church before the empire, the powerless minority that out-lived and out-loved the Rome that fed it to lions. Because everything the exile needs to know about how to live in the long after was already worked out, at cost, by the people who lived it before us.

Chapter 15: The Church Before the Empire

There's a fact about the church that should reorganize how a frightened American Christian thinks about the future. Almost nobody says it out loud, because it embarrasses the whole model of power we've run on for sixteen centuries. The most explosive growth in the history of Christianity happened when the church had no political power at all. Not a little. None. It couldn't pass a law. It couldn't seat a magistrate. It couldn't close a shop on the sabbath or open a school with a prayer or count on one institution in the known world to defer to it, or even to leave it alone. It was illegal for most of three hundred years, slandered the whole time, hunted in stretches. Its people met in borrowed houses and in the tunnels under the city. They were burned in gardens and thrown to animals in front of crowds who'd paid to watch. And across three centuries of exactly that, it went from a few thousand terrified followers of an executed Galilean laborer to something near half the population of the Roman Empire. It conquered Rome from underneath, before Constantine ever lifted a finger, and it did it with nothing we'd recognize as strength.

We don't want this fact, and I understand why. It indicts us. If the church grew fastest with the least power, then the power we've spent a generation grieving was never the engine we told ourselves it was. The loss we're mourning is not the loss of the thing that made us fruitful. It's the loss of the thing that let us be lazy. We did this. I did this. And I want to say it plainly before I say anything else. We looked at the water going out and decided the church couldn't live without it. The first three centuries stand

up in the record and tell us, quietly and without heat, that we're wrong. We've got the story of our own family exactly backward.

Let me start where the honest historians start, which is the arithmetic, because the numbers turn out to be less miraculous and more sobering than either the triumphalist or the skeptic wants. The sociologist Rodney Stark sat down late in the last century and did something the pious rarely bother to do. He ran the math. The question is simple. How do you get from a handful of Jewish believers in the year 40, a movement so small it could've fit in a large room, to the tens of millions of Christians the empire plainly held by the early 300s, on the eve of Constantine? And the answer, Stark showed, doesn't require a single mass conversion. Not one stadium filled. Not one emperor's decree. Not one of the sudden spectacular ingatherings we picture when we imagine the ancient church exploding across the world. It requires a growth rate of around forty percent a decade. That's the same rate sociologists have measured, in our own time, in vigorous new religious movements that spread person to person, house to house, with no advertising and no state behind them. Forty percent a decade, which is something close to three or four percent a year, held without a break for almost three hundred years. That's it. That's the whole engine.

Sit in how ordinary that number is, because the ordinariness is the point. Forty percent a decade is not a revival. It's not a wave. It's what happens when a community grows the way a family grows. When a group of people so loves one another and so welcomes the stranger that the group is a little larger every year than it was, and it keeps being a little larger, patiently, for ten generations. The early church didn't detonate. It compounded. And compounding, unlike detonation, can't be faked and can't be hurried and can't be produced by a platform or a program. It can

only be produced by a kind of life, sustained over a very long time, that keeps drawing people in faster than death and hostility can carry them out. So the real question isn't the arithmetic. The arithmetic is settled. The real question is the one Stark spent his career on, the only one that matters. Why? Why did this odd, powerless, hunted minority keep compounding through the worst an empire could do to it, when by every worldly measure it should've been stamped flat a dozen times over?

The answer isn't the one we'd choose for ourselves, and that's exactly why it's worth hearing. It wasn't strategy. They had no strategy in any sense we'd recognize. It wasn't messaging. They controlled no channel, and every channel that existed was against them. It wasn't cultural power. They had less than any group in the empire. It was that they lived in a way the empire couldn't explain, and they died in a way the empire couldn't explain, and the inability to explain them was the most persuasive thing the ancient world had ever run into. When you can't account for how a people lives, you begin, against your will, to want the thing that accounts for it. The church didn't win the argument of the ancient world. It became the argument. And the two great proving grounds where it became the argument were the plagues and the discarded children. Let me take you into both, because that's where the abstraction turns into blood.

Twice in those centuries a pestilence came through the empire and broke it, and the historians who study the ancient world now think these plagues did more to remake Rome than most of its wars. The first arrived in the 160s, carried home, the sources suggest, by soldiers returning from the eastern campaigns. It's called the Antonine plague, after the emperor whose reign it wrecked. It burned through the cities for fifteen years and killed, by the careful estimates, somewhere between a quarter and a

third of the population wherever it fully landed. The physician Galen, the most famous doctor in the world, fled the city of Rome when it came, which tells you everything you need to know about what the finest medical mind of the age thought could be done. Then, in the 250s, it came again, worse. A second great dying that the sources describe in a way that turns your stomach. Bodies in the streets. Whole households emptied. The living too few and too frightened to bury the dead. It's called the plague of Cyprian, after the bishop of Carthage who lived through it and wrote about it, and Cyprian described a disease that came on with fever and bleeding and rotting extremities and a stench that emptied the houses of everyone who could still walk.

Now understand what the ordinary, rational, decent response to such a thing was, because the Christians didn't do it, and the not-doing is the whole story. When the plague came to a city, you left. If you had means, you fled to the country and waited for it to pass. And if you couldn't leave, you did the other rational thing, which was put distance between yourself and the sick. Even the sick in your own house. The pagan sources and the Christian sources agree on this with a rare and terrible unanimity. People threw the half-dead into the roads while they were still breathing and left them there. They abandoned parents. They abandoned children. Not because they were monsters. Because everyone knew that to nurse a plague victim was very often to catch the plague and die, and self-preservation is the oldest law there is, and the old gods gave no reason to break it and no hope on the far side of breaking it. To stay was to die. So, sensibly, terribly, the ancient city in a plague evacuated its own compassion along with its own bodies.

And the Christians stayed. That's the fact everything else in this

chapter turns around, and it isn't legend, because we have it from the mouths of the men who watched it happen, some of them hostile witnesses. When the sickness filled the cities, the Christians didn't flee. They stayed, and they nursed the dying. Their own first, and then, unforgettably, their pagan neighbors, the very people who on a normal day despised them and on a bad day might inform on them. They carried water to the fevered. They cleaned the filth of the dying. They held the hands of strangers whose own families had run. They buried the dead that no one else would touch. Bishop Dionysius of Alexandria, writing in the middle of the third century in the teeth of the second plague, described his own people going to the sick without a thought for the danger, taking the illness into their own bodies from the ones they were tending, dying in the place of those they nursed, and he called it, without a flicker of irony, the equal of martyrdom, this drawing of another's death onto yourself. A century and more later the emperor Julian, who hated the church and spent his short reign trying to revive a dying paganism against it, wrote a bitter letter to a pagan priest. The Galileans, as he called them, had grown so strong precisely because they cared for everyone's sick and everyone's poor and everyone's dead, while his own side cared for no one's. He ordered the pagan temples to start copying the Christians. It didn't work, because you can't decree the thing that only love produces.

Consider what that steady, stubborn nursing actually did. Not spiritually, arithmetically, because it did something arithmetical that folds right back into Stark's numbers. Basic care, even without medicine, even without any understanding of what caused the disease, saves lives in a plague. A person with a raging fever who's given water and kept clean and simply not abandoned survives at a far higher rate than a person left alone in

a doorway. So the Christians, by staying, didn't only witness. They lowered their own death rate below their neighbors', because they cared for their sick instead of running from them, and they raised the survival rate of every pagan they nursed. And every one of those nursed pagans got up from a bed they should have died in and walked back into a city that had thrown them away, carrying in their body a debt they couldn't stop thinking about. A pagan nursed back from the edge by a Christian who had no earthly reason to sit at his bed, who by every law of self-interest should've been miles away in the clean country air, does not forget who stayed. He wants to know what kind of God makes a person do that. The plagues, which should have thinned the church faster than anything, instead filled it, because in the exact hour when the old gods proved they were nothing, the followers of the crucified one proved their God was real by dying for people who weren't even their own.

They had no power, so they had only their lives. And in a plague, when everyone else was saving theirs, the church spent its lives. The spending was the sermon the empire couldn't answer.

Then there were the children, and this one's harder to look at, but it belongs in the record, because it's the second great place where the church's ordinary life indicted the empire's. The Roman world practiced what it called exposure, and we shouldn't soften the word. When a child was born the father didn't want, most often a girl, or a child that was sickly, or simply one more mouth in a poor house, the child was carried out and left. Left on a hillside, at a crossroads, on a rubbish heap outside the city walls, to die of cold or hunger or animals. Or, worse, to be gathered up by someone who collected exposed infants to raise for the slave markets and the brothels. This wasn't a crime and it wasn't a

scandal. It was legal. It was common. It was assumed. We have a letter, preserved in the dry sand of Egypt, from an ordinary husband away on business, writing home to his pregnant wife with casual affection about the household accounts, and in the same breath, in the same untroubled tone, he tells her that if the child she's carrying turns out to be a girl, she should expose it. That's the water the ancient world swam in. The discarding of unwanted children was so normal a man could mention it between a greeting and a grocery list.

And the Christians went out and gathered them up. In a world that threw its infants away, the church walked out to the hillsides and the refuse heaps and the crossroads and took the abandoned children home and raised them as its own sons and daughters. It refused, absolutely and from the beginning, to expose its own children, so Christian households didn't thin out the way pagan households did, and it took in the children the pagans had discarded, so Christian households grew by mercy on top of growing by birth. The earliest Christian writings outside the New Testament say this flatly, as a mark of the faith. The document we call the Didache, a little manual of the faith from very near the apostolic age, lists among the plain commands of the two ways, you shall not murder a child by abortion, nor kill it when it is born. The Letter of Barnabas says the same. This wasn't a fringe position or a later development. It was there at the root, a bright and immovable line, and it had a demographic consequence that fed straight back into the forty percent. A community that welcomes every child and discards none, in a world that discards its children as a matter of course, will simply grow faster than the world around it, generation over generation, even if it never converts a single adult. The church out-loved the empire at the very edges of life, where the empire was cruelest, and the love was fruitful in the most literal way there is.

It ran further than the plagues and the infants, into the whole ordinary shape of a life together that the empire had no category for. In a world that treated women as property to be handed between fathers and husbands and used and set aside, the church gave women honor, and gave widows a real place and a real support instead of destitution, and gave marriage a dignity and a permanence and a mutuality it hadn't had, so that even hostile observers noticed how the Christians treated their women, and women came into the church in numbers that alarmed its enemies. In a world sorted with brutal precision by class and blood and legal status, the church did the thing no one else in antiquity did. It sat the slave and the master down at one table, gave them the same bread and the same cup, called them both brother, and meant it. A slave could rise to lead a congregation that held his own master in the pews. There's nothing else like this in the ancient world. The empire had its clubs and its guilds and its associations, but every one of them gathered people who were already alike, sorted by trade or class or city of origin. Only the church gathered people who had nothing in common but the crucified Lord. The freedman beside the senator's wife beside the dockworker beside the runaway slave, made into a single family. That room, which the empire couldn't produce and couldn't explain, was a kind of miracle sitting in plain sight in a hundred cities.

Someone put all of this into words near the middle of the second century. An anonymous Christian writing to a puzzled pagan official named Diognetus, who wanted to understand what these people actually were, and the little letter he wrote is one of the loveliest things to survive from the early church, and it names the exile condition with a precision that could've been written this morning. Christians, he wrote, are not distinguished from the rest of humanity by country or language or custom. They do not

live in cities of their own or speak a strange dialect or follow an eccentric way of life. They live in their own countries, but only as sojourners. They share in all things as citizens, and they endure all things as foreigners. Every foreign land is to them a homeland, and every homeland a foreign land. They are in the flesh, but they do not live according to the flesh. They pass their days on earth, but their citizenship is in heaven. They obey the established laws, and in their own lives they surpass the laws. They love everyone, and by everyone they are persecuted. And then the line that ought to be carved somewhere every anxious Christian will see it. What the soul is to the body, the writer says, Christians are to the world. The soul is spread through all the members of the body, and Christians through all the cities of the world. The soul dwells in the body but is not of the body, and Christians dwell in the world but are not of the world.

Resident aliens. Sojourners. That's not a metaphor the church invented in a season of decline to comfort itself. It's the settled self-understanding of the church at the very height of its powerlessness and the very height of its growth, and it's drawn straight from the apostles, who assumed it as simply the truth of what the church now was. Peter opens his first letter by addressing the Christians scattered across the provinces of Asia Minor with a phrase that yokes two words we'd never dare to yoke. He calls them elect exiles of the dispersion. Chosen, and homeless, in a single breath. Not chosen and therefore comfortable. Not chosen and therefore in charge. Chosen precisely as exiles, elect precisely as strangers. And a few lines on he tells them how the elect exile is to live in a hostile city, and it's the whole strategy of the church before the empire compressed into a sentence. "Beloved, I urge you as sojourners and exiles to abstain from the passions of the flesh, which wage war against your soul. Keep your conduct among the Gentiles

honorable, so that when they speak against you as evildoers, they may see your good deeds and glorify God on the day of visitation" (1 Peter 2:11–12). There it is. Exactly what the plagues and the infants and the one table actually accomplished, prophesied by an apostle before it happened. They'll slander you. Let them watch you live. Let the life be so plainly good that the slander can't survive the watching, until the very people speaking against you are driven to glorify the God who makes people live like this.

That's the whole method, and it has a name in the New Testament, and the name tells you everything about what kind of method it is. The Greek word is *martyria*, witness, and you can hear our word martyr sitting inside it, because in those centuries the two words became one thing. Witness is what you do when you can't coerce. You can't make a watching world believe. You can't legislate the kingdom into a human heart. You can't conquer your way to a single genuine conversion, because a forced faith is not faith at all. So you do the only thing left to a people with no lever, which is live the truth out loud, in public, at whatever cost it exacts, and trust God with a result you can no longer manufacture. Witness is the weapon of the powerless. It was the only weapon Jesus ever actually authorized, and it turned out to be, by an enormous margin, the most effective force in the history of the world, because it converted an empire from the floor of its own prisons.

And so we come to Tertullian, the fierce North African lawyer who became one of the church's first great Latin voices, writing around the year 197 while the persecutions were still very much on, addressing the Roman authorities directly in a defense of the faith, and throwing at them a single sentence that has never once lost its edge. The blood of the martyrs, he wrote, is seed. He

meant it as a taunt and as a fact, and it was both. Every time you kill us, he was telling the empire, you plant us. We multiply the more you cut us down, because the watching world can't look away from the way we die, and it can't stop asking the question our dying forces on it. What could a man possibly possess that would let him go to the animals like that, singing, without hatred for the crowd and without fear of the beasts? In the ordinary economy of the world, killing a movement kills it. The empire understood killing. It was superb at killing. And it discovered, to its bafflement, that this particular movement grew from its own executions. The arena where it meant to end the church became the church's most persuasive pulpit, because a Roman who came to jeer at the deaths of the Christians sometimes went home unable to stop thinking about them, and some of those went looking, quietly, for the thing that could make a human being die that way, and found it, and were baptized, and in time died that way themselves. The blood was seed. Tertullian wasn't being poetic. He was reading a demographic fact off the floor of the Colosseum.

I have to stop here and steelman the objection, because there's a serious one, and the church that quotes these stories at itself for comfort usually refuses to hear it, and it deserves better than that. It goes like this. You're romanticizing weakness. You're telling a frightened church a bedtime story about the powerless early days to make it feel noble about its losses, and you're quietly leaving out the part where power, when it finally came, brought real and enormous goods. When Constantine and then Theodosius made the faith legal and then established, the killing stopped. The exposed infants eventually became illegal to expose, because Christians with power outlawed the thing that Christians without power could only rescue people from one child at a time. The gladiatorial games were ended. The hospitals were built and

endowed at scale. The universities were founded. Slavery was, over long and shameful centuries, finally named as the evil it was and abolished, and none of that was done by a powerless minority nursing the sick in a plague. It was done by a church that had gotten its hands on the levers and pulled. So don't stand there, the objection concludes, and tell me powerlessness is the church's true condition, when the greatest and most lasting mercies in the history of the West were purchased precisely by the power you're teaching me to despise.

I hear that, and I won't wave it away, because most of it is simply true, and a church that pretends power did no good is telling itself a different lie in the opposite direction. Power did real good. The end of exposure was a mercy no amount of private rescue could equal. The hospital, an institution the ancient world did not possess, is a Christian invention made possible by Christian resources and Christian influence, and it has saved more lives than every plague nurse of the third century combined. I'm not going to insult the memory of those goods. But look hard at the sequence, because the sequence is the whole answer to the objection. The church did not earn its moral authority by holding power. It earned its moral authority by three centuries of powerless love, and then it spent that authority, once power came, to write mercy into the laws. The witness came first. The lever came second, and the lever only did good to the exact degree that the witness had already formed a people who knew what mercy was for. When the sequence reverses, when a church reaches for the lever before it has done the long, costly, unglamorous work of witness, before it has become the kind of people the plague and the hillside would have proven them to be, the lever does not produce mercy. It produces a Christianity you can't tell apart from a voting bloc with a worship band. A tribe that has learned to command obedience and forgotten how to

compel by love. The objection is right that power did good. It's wrong about which came first, and getting the order right is the difference between the church that converted Rome and the church that, some centuries later, would need converting itself. Witness earns the authority. Authority, if it comes at all, is meant to be spent, not hoarded, and it's only ever safe in the hands of a people who did not need it to be faithful.

And that's precisely the church being handed back to us, whether we wanted the gift or not. We're being returned, after a very long detour, to the condition in which the church has always been most fully itself. The condition it was born in. The condition of the elect exile with no lever and no deference and no water underneath, holding nothing but the truth and a life visibly bent by it and a willingness to bleed if the bleeding comes. We've been so afraid of losing our power that we forgot the plain fact of our own origin, which is that the power was never the thing that made us fruitful. The first time around we didn't have it, and its absence was not the wound the church overcame. It was the soil the church grew in. A church that can't coerce has to convert. A church that can't buy loyalty has to earn it. A church that can't call down the magistrate on its enemies has to call down nothing on them but the sheer unanswerable weight of its own astonishing life, and then trust God with what that life does in the watching heart. This is not the emergency setting of the church. Look at the arithmetic. Look at the plague. Look at the hillside. This is the church running at full strength.

I don't say any of this from a safe distance, and I won't end the chapter pretending I stand outside the fear I'm describing. I came up in the era of platform and reach and metrics, and I wanted every bit of it, and I told myself the wanting was zeal for the kingdom when a good deal of it was only the cultural Christian

in me grieving the water he was raised to assume. I've caught myself, more times than I want to confess, measuring the health of the church by exactly the instruments the empire uses to measure everything. The size of the room. The reach of the message. The standing in the culture. The access to the levers. And calling that stewardship. And the early church stands over the whole of it and asks me the question I don't enjoy. When the plague came to your city, would they have found you at the bedside or on the road out of town? When the child was on the hillside, would you have gone out into the cold to gather it up, or would you have decided, sensibly, that it wasn't your problem and wasn't your risk? Those are the only questions that ever built anything, and no amount of power answers them, and no amount of powerlessness excuses me from them. We spent so long assuming the water that we let the muscles of witness go slack, and now the water is gone and we're discovering how weak we let ourselves become. The discovery is a mercy, because a church cannot begin to recover a strength it still believes it does not need.

So the fact stands where I began, and it won't be argued away. The most explosive growth in the history of the faith happened with no political power at all, among a hunted minority that nursed its enemies in the plagues and gathered its enemies' children off the hillsides and sat slave and senator at one table and went to the animals without hatred, and grew forty percent a decade for three hundred years on nothing but the unanswerable argument of a life the empire couldn't explain. That church didn't need Christendom. Christendom didn't exist yet. That church needed only to be itself, exposed and powerless in the heart of a pagan world, and to be itself was enough. More than enough. Enough to bury the empire that fed it to lions. We're being handed that church back. We should take it like the gift it is.

But the story doesn't end with the church rising through the empire, and I'd be lying to you if I let this chapter close on the triumph, because the triumph is where the danger begins. The church that had no power got power, at last, in the fourth century, and then it did the thing the exiles were always warned against. It began to confuse the two cities. It began to believe a Christian empire was the point of the whole story, that God had crowned history with a baptized Rome, that the kingdom and the empire had fused into one glorious and permanent thing that could never fall. And then, in the year 410, the unthinkable happened, and the eternal city was sacked in three days of fire, and a whole civilization went into shock, and the church's faith buckled, because if a Christian Rome could fall, then what exactly had God promised, and what exactly had we been standing on? Into that grief an aging bishop in North Africa sat down to write the book that pried the two cities apart with both hands, while the ash was still falling and the barbarians were already moving toward the walls of his own town. We turn now to him.

Chapter 16: Augustine Watches Rome Fall

In the third week of August, in the year 410, the impossible happened. Alaric and the Goths came over the walls, and for three days Rome burned. The civilized world went into the kind of shock you go into when a parent dies. Even an old parent. Even a failing one you've watched go downhill for years. Some part of you had just quietly assumed they'd always be there. Rome was the eternal city. She was more than eleven hundred years old, counting from the founding the Romans dated to 753 before Christ, and in all that time no foreign enemy had gotten through her walls. Eight hundred years back a band of Gauls had breached them once, and the memory of it had haunted the Roman imagination ever since as the one great humiliation. Now it had happened again. And this time was worse, because this time Rome was supposed to be under the protection of a higher God. For thirty years the empire had been officially Christian, ever since Theodosius made the faith the religion of the state in 380. The cross flew over the legions. The old temples were shuttered or converted. And then the barbarians were in the forum. The churches were the only buildings Alaric ordered spared. The grief was total. Out of it came two accusations, and the church is still answering both.

The first came from the pagans, and it was the obvious one. This is your fault. Rome was strong, they said, when Rome honored the old gods, when the sacrifices were offered and the temples kept and the ancient rites that had guarded the city for a thousand years were performed on schedule. Then you Christians came

and talked her out of all of it. You closed the temples and silenced the augurs and told the whole world that the gods who made Rome great were nothing but demons and stone. Now the gods have pulled their protection, exactly as anyone could have predicted, and the barbarians are in the streets, and the blood is on your hands. It's a coherent argument. It has the shape of every argument that ever blamed a catastrophe on abandoning the old ways, and it landed because it fit what everyone already half-believed. That the health of a city and the favor of its gods were the same thing. That to change the second was to gamble with the first.

The second accusation is the one we forget, and it's the one that should worry us more, because it came from inside the church. Plenty of Christians in 410 were privately devastated for the opposite reason, and their faith was buckling under it. They'd come to believe a Christian empire was the whole point of the story. They'd watched the faith go from the catacombs to the throne in a single century, from Nero's torches to Constantine's basilicas, and they'd drawn the natural conclusion. God had been building toward this all along. The whole arc of history had bent toward a baptized Rome. The kingdom of God and the Roman empire had fused into one glorious permanent thing that would carry the gospel to the ends of the earth and the end of time. The Christian poets said as much. Eusebius, the great historian of the church, had all but crowned Constantine as the earthly image of the divine, writing of the Christian empire as if it were the promises arriving in the flesh. And now the permanent thing was on fire. If a Christian Rome could fall to a pack of Arian barbarians, then what had God actually promised? What were they standing on? Had they believed a lie?

Into that double grief, an aging bishop in a provincial North

African port sat down and wrote the book that ought to be the constitution of every Christian who has ever lived after Christendom.

Augustine of Hippo was fifty-five when Rome fell. He'd been a bishop for thirteen years already, and by any measure the world uses, he was a small figure in a small place. Hippo Regius was a working harbor town, not a capital. Augustine was not in Rome. He'd spent only a few years of his life there, decades earlier, and he learned of the sack the way everyone in the provinces did. From refugees. From rumor. From the ships that came into the harbor carrying people who'd lost everything and wanted someone to tell them what it meant. He had come to faith late and hard, out of a young manhood he'd spend the rest of his life confessing, out of the fashionable philosophies and the ambitions and the appetites of a clever man who wanted every good thing except the one that mattered. He knew from the inside what it was to build a life on things that couldn't hold the weight. And when the whole world came to his door asking why the eternal city had turned out not to be eternal after all, he didn't offer them comfort. He offered them a book. It took him thirteen years to write, from 413 to 426, twenty-two volumes of it, and it's called *The City of God*. The argument at the heart of it is one idea, and it cuts the panic off at the knees.

There are, Augustine said, two cities. They've been tangled together from the very beginning, since Cain and Abel, since before there was a Rome or an Israel or any nation at all, and they'll stay tangled, running through the same families and the same streets and sometimes the same heart, until the end of the age when God finally sorts them out. What makes them two cities is not their borders, because they have none. Not their citizens' passports, because those citizens carry the same

passports as everyone else. What makes them two cities is two loves. The line is one of the most quoted sentences the man ever wrote, and it deserves to be quoted in full. Two loves have made the two cities. The earthly city was made by love of self reaching even to contempt of God. The heavenly city was made by love of God reaching even to contempt of self. That's the whole thing. Not Christian nation against pagan nation. Not West against barbarian. Two loves, running through the middle of everything, building two cities that won't be untangled until the end.

And here's what that did to the grief down in the harbor. Rome, Augustine said, was the earthly city. Rome had always been the earthly city. She'd been built, gloriously and impressively and with real virtues Augustine was careful to honor, by love of self and lust for glory and the will to dominate that he called the *libido dominandi*, the drive to rule, which had made her great and would in the end unmake her the way it had unmade every empire before her. And this was true, Augustine insisted, even after 380. Even with the cross over the legions. Even when the emperor knelt at the altar. Baptizing an empire doesn't change the love that built it. Rome was never the City of God. Not for one day. Not even at the height of the Christian empire, not even when Theodosius did public penance before Ambrose and the whole world marveled that a bishop could bring an emperor to his knees. The earthly city can be improved, restrained, made less cruel, and Augustine thought it should be. But it can't be converted into the City of God by an edict, because the City of God is not a territory you can conquer or a government you can reform. It's the whole company of everyone who loves God, across every nation and every century, most of whom Rome had never heard of and never would.

Do you see what he's doing? Do you see that it's exactly our

problem? The Christians of 410 had made the same mistake we've made. They'd fused the faith with its political and cultural establishment so completely, so unconsciously, that when the establishment fell they couldn't tell it apart from the falling of God. And Augustine pried the two apart with both hands, while the ash was still coming down, while the refugees were still weeping in his church, and he told them the hardest and most freeing thing anyone could have said. The thing that has fallen is not the thing you were promised. The empire was the scaffolding. The City of God is the building. The scaffolding was never load-bearing for the faith. It only looked that way. And now that it's come down, you can finally see the building underneath, the one no Alaric can breach, because it isn't made of walls.

Rome was never the City of God. So the fall of Rome is not the fall of God. Learn that now, while it's only your country shaking, and you won't lose your faith when it finally gives way.

I want to be honest about how strange and how brave this was. We read Augustine through sixteen hundred years of him having won the argument, and we forget what it cost to make it in 413. It would have been so much easier to give the people what they wanted. He could have told the pagans they were wrong on their own terms, that Rome fell because she hadn't been Christian enough, that a purer Christian empire would have held. He could have told the grieving Christians this was a temporary setback, that God would restore the empire greater than before, that the barbarians were a chastisement to endure before the glory came back. Both were available. Both were, in a sense, more pious, more patriotic, more comforting. Augustine refused both, because both made the same error. The error of tying God's

promise to Rome's survival. He'd come to see it wasn't a small mistake at the edge of the faith but a poison at its center, a thing that would make the faith unlivable the moment the empire failed. So he took the harder road. He told a grieving people that the city they were mourning had never been their true city, and that their true city was safe, and that the difference between those two things was the difference between a faith that could survive history and a faith that history could kill.

I have to name the objection at its strongest, because it's old and it has teeth. Wasn't Augustine just teaching people to abandon the world? Wasn't this the beginning of a long Christian indifference to the actual welfare of actual cities, a spiritualized retreat that let believers watch the empire burn with their arms folded because their real city was somewhere else? Serious people have read him that way, and the charge can't be waved off, because the withdrawal we warned about a few chapters back can quote Augustine as easily as the suitcase can quote Paul. But read him closely and the charge falls apart. The same Augustine who said Rome was not the City of God also insisted that the two cities, for now, share a common life and use a common peace. He said the citizens of the heavenly city are to make use of the earthly peace and even to work for it, to want Babylon's welfare precisely because their own pilgrimage runs straight through it. He wasn't telling the church to stop loving the city. He was telling it to stop worshipping it. He was cutting the idolatry, not the love. Those are opposite operations, though the frightened heart mixes them up, because it's only when you stop needing the city to be your salvation that you're free to love it without terror, to seek its good without staking your soul on whether it survives. Augustine did not teach the church to watch Rome burn with folded arms. He taught it to watch Rome burn without losing its faith, which is a completely different thing,

and the only posture anybody has ever been able to help a burning city from, instead of just dying with it.

This is the deep continuity between the man in the harbor and the letter we've been reading for sixteen chapters, and it's worth saying out loud, because Augustine is Jeremiah's student even though nine hundred years lie between them. Jeremiah told the exiles that Babylon was not their home and never would be, and in the same breath told them to seek its welfare and pray for its peace. Augustine told the Romans that the empire was not the City of God, and in the same breath told them to use its peace and work for its good. Both men are doing the exact same thing. Both are refusing the two easy answers at once. Both are cutting the false hope, the fantasy that the earthly city is the ultimate thing, and by cutting it, freeing their people to love the earthly city rightly, as a place and not as a god, for as long as God keeps them in it. The exile who has learned Jeremiah's lesson and the Roman who has learned Augustine's are the same person. The freedom they share is the freedom this whole book has been trying to describe. The freedom of a people whose deepest hope is fixed somewhere no barbarian can reach.

The Scriptures were saying this long before Augustine gathered it into a system, and he knew it, and he leaned on them at every turn. The writer of Hebrews said it with a kind of ache, of the patriarchs who died still waiting. "These all died in faith, not having received the things promised, but having seen them and greeted them from afar, and having acknowledged that they were strangers and exiles on the earth" (Hebrews 11:13). And then the sentence Augustine might as well have taken for his title. "For here we have no lasting city, but we seek the city that is to come" (Hebrews 13:14). There it is. The two cities, sitting in the New Testament three centuries before the bishop was born, the

settled conviction of the whole people of God that we are travelers here, that our papers are provisional, that no city built by human hands has foundations that will hold. Paul said the same to the Philippians, writing from a prison in the empire whose citizenship he legally held and did not finally trust. "But our citizenship is in heaven, and from it we await a Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ" (Philippians 3:20). Not our citizenship will be in heaven someday. Is. Already. Now. While Rome still stood and Paul still carried its papers, his true city was elsewhere, and he knew it, and it made him free in a Roman jail in a way his jailers couldn't understand.

Behind all of it stands the oldest word, the one the exiles heard from Jeremiah and the Romans heard from Augustine and we're hearing now. The word to a defeated people that their defeat is not the end of their God. When Jerusalem fell in 587 before Christ and the temple burned, the natural theological conclusion, the one the surrounding nations drew about their own beaten gods, was that the God of Israel had lost. Had proven weaker than the gods of Babylon. Had been dragged off in chains with his people. The prophets said no. They said the fall of the temple was not the fall of God, that God had not been defeated but had used Babylon as the rod of his own purpose, that he was as present in the ashes of Jerusalem as he'd ever been in its glory, and more. The whole theological achievement of the exile was learning to say that sentence and mean it. Our city has fallen and our God has not. Augustine said it again in Latin in 413. We're saying it in English now. The building is not the scaffolding. The kingdom is not the country. The fall of the one is not the fall of the other, and the people who can't tell them apart will lose their faith on the day the scaffolding comes down. The people who can tell them apart won't.

There's a detail at the end of Augustine's life I can't get out of my head, and I've saved it for the end because it carries the whole weight of everything I've been trying to say. Augustine did not die a peaceful old age in a stable world. He died in the year 430, twenty years after the sack of Rome, and by then the barbarians were no longer a distant rumor from the capital. They were at his own gates. The Vandals, another Arian Germanic people, had crossed from Spain into North Africa and swept across the province burning as they came, and in the last months of Augustine's life they laid siege to Hippo itself. The old bishop lay dying inside a walled city with an enemy army camped outside it, watching, in his final weeks, the visible undoing of the whole Roman order he'd lived his entire life inside. Refugees crowded the town. The countryside was in flames. Everything he'd ever known was coming apart within sight of his deathbed. And this time it was not a story carried by ships from far away. It was outside the wall.

And he died in peace.

His biographer Possidius, who was there, who knew him, tells us Augustine spent his final days having the penitential psalms of David written out and hung on the wall where he could see them from his bed, and that he wept over them, and prayed, and asked to be left alone with God at the end, and that he died on the twenty-eighth of August in 430 with the Vandals still at the gates and the fever taking him and his mind entirely his own. He was not calm because he was too old to understand what was happening. He understood it better than anyone alive. He was calm because he'd spent thirteen years teaching himself and everyone who would listen that his city, his real city, was not the one under siege. The Vandals could take Hippo. They could burn his church and scatter his people and reduce the whole province

to ash, and they nearly did, and within a year of his death the city fell. But they could not touch the city he actually belonged to, because that city has no walls for an army to breach and no gates for a siege to close, and its walls, in the words of the prophet, are salvation, and its gates are praise. The man who'd told the whole world Rome was not the City of God got to prove, on his own deathbed, with the barbarians in sight of his window, that he'd believed it all along.

That's the freedom on offer to us. I want to be careful how I say this, because it's not the freedom the frightened church keeps asking for. It's not the freedom of a church that wins, that turns it all around, that gets the water back and the deference back and the old central seat at the table. Augustine got none of that. He died and his city fell and the empire he was born into passed out of the world within a lifetime. The freedom on offer is a stranger and a better thing than winning. It's the freedom of a church that has stopped confusing the burning empire with the indestructible kingdom, and can therefore watch the smoke without despair, and can keep loving a city that's dying without dying inside when it dies, and can get back to the only work that was ever actually ours, the work of loving the God whose city has no walls to breach. A church with that freedom cannot be defeated, because the one thing that could defeat it, the loss of the earthly city it had mistaken for the kingdom, has already happened, and it turned out not to be fatal.

We should learn this now, on purpose, before we're forced to. That's the whole reason to look at Augustine in a book about the American church. He learned the lesson in the hardest possible school, with the actual barbarians at the actual gate, and he had the seventeen years between the sack of Rome and his own death to work it all the way down into his bones, so that when the siege

came he was ready. We are not, most of us, being besieged. We're watching a slower thing, a draining rather than a burning, the quiet withdrawal of a cultural establishment rather than the sudden arrival of an army. And that slowness is a mercy, because it gives us time Augustine barely had. Time to do the pulling-apart now, calmly, while it's still only our country shaking and not the last hour of our lives, so we cut the idolatry before the crisis instead of during it. Learn to tell the empire from the kingdom now, while the telling is a matter of study and not survival, and you won't have to learn it in a panic later, when the scaffolding is coming down around you and there's no time left to figure out that it was only ever scaffolding.

Because the temptation, once the scaffolding is gone and the fear has passed, is to rush right out and rebuild something. To gather the survivors and count them and ask how we make our numbers strong again, how we build a tribe sturdy enough to hold its ground against a world that no longer holds us up. That instinct is not wrong to want strength. It's only wrong about where strength comes from, and about what kind of strength the church was ever meant to have. Augustine, having watched two cities fall, did not spend his last decades trying to turn the church into a stronger version of the empire that was dying. He spent them making disciples. Writing to individual souls. Forming a people whose depth did not depend on the walls that were failing all around them. That's the pattern, and it's the pattern the next chapter has to make plain, because the question that faces a church after its Rome has fallen is not finally how to build a stronger tribe. It's how to build a deeper people. And those are not the same project. They pull, as we're about to see, in opposite directions, and everything depends on which one we choose.

Chapter 17: Deeper Disciples, Not Stronger Tribes

Everything in this book has been walking toward one sentence. Let me just say it, and then spend a chapter earning it. The future of the church in America does not belong to stronger tribes. It belongs to deeper disciples. Those are not two roads to the same place. They run in opposite directions. And the years ahead are going to make everyone in the church pick one, whether they mean to or not. Most of us will pick without ever seeing there was a choice, because the tribe is louder, and the tribe is faster, and the tribe will let you feel like you are winning right up until the moment your roots give out underneath you.

I have to start with a confession. I have no right to say any of this from a distance. I came up in the age of the platform and the metrics and the reach, and I wanted all of it, and I told myself the wanting was zeal for the kingdom. I have measured a ministry by the size of the room. I know that little ugly lift when the numbers move, and the sag when they don't, and I have called that lift the presence of God when it was only the presence of a crowd. So when I say the future belongs to depth and not to dominance, I am not scolding a movement I stand outside of. I am naming a sin I know from the inside. It's the sin of a man who wanted the church to be strong in the exact way the world is strong, and who is learning, late, against his own instincts, that those are not the same strength. The church has almost always been most alive at the very moment it had the least of what the world calls strong.

Start with why depth was optional under Christendom and isn't

anymore, because the whole argument turns on it. When the culture is carrying you, you can be a mile wide and an inch deep and get by fine. The water holds you up no matter how shallow your roots go. A nominal faith, a Sunday faith, a faith of vague agreement and inherited habit, works perfectly well in a world that already assumes it. It costs nothing, because the culture is paying the bill. It never gets tested, because nothing in the surrounding air is pushing against it. So it can go a whole lifetime looking healthy without once being asked to stand on its own. That kind of faith doesn't fail in fair weather. It only fails when the weather turns.

The sun comes up on the American church

Jesus told a parable about exactly this, and we've been mishearing it for generations. We've softened it into a nice little lesson about being open-hearted, when it's really a warning about the drought that's coming for every shallow thing. A sower went out to sow, and some seed fell on rocky ground, where it did not have much soil, and it sprang up quickly, because it had no depth of earth. And when the sun rose it was scorched, and because it had no root it withered away. Read it slow, and notice what it doesn't say. It doesn't say the rocky-ground plant was sickly. It says the opposite. That plant came up first. It came up fastest. In the early weeks it may have looked like the healthiest thing in the whole field, greener and taller than the seed that landed on good soil and was still spending its strength underground, on roots nobody could see. Everything you could see favored the shallow plant. Right up until the morning it died.

Notice, too, what the parable refuses to blame. It doesn't blame the sun. The sun is not the villain, and neither is the drought that Luke names in his telling, the season of testing when the moisture is gone. The sun is just the weather. The sun does what

the sun has always done. The problem was never the heat. The problem was the rock an inch under the surface, the shallowness that let the plant look magnificent in the cool of the morning and killed it by noon. The sun didn't cause the death. It only showed you a death that was already certain the day the seed landed on ground with no depth to it.

The sun has come up on the American church. That's our whole situation in one image, and it's why I keep coming back to it. For a long time the water held us, and the sky was mild, and the shallow and the deep looked about the same, all of it green together in the assumed Christian morning of this country. Now the sun is up. The drought is here. The cultural moisture that kept the nominal faith looking alive has burned off, and all across the country the rocky-ground plants are dying in the heat. We're watching congregations that looked strong a generation ago brown and curl and blow away, and we're calling it a crisis. It isn't first a crisis. It's a revelation. The drought didn't create the shallowness. It exposed it. And the only thing that has ever lived through a drought is a root that went down long before the sky turned to brass.

The drought does not create shallow faith. It shows you the shallowness that was already there. And the only thing that has ever survived a drought is a root that went down long before the sun came up.

This is the mercy hidden inside the hard providence of this moment, and the church won't find it until it stops grieving the drought as a disaster and starts taking it as a clarification. A faith that only ever grew in subsidized soil never knew if it was real. It couldn't know. Nothing tested it. The end of Christendom is the sun coming up on a field that's been growing untested for

centuries, and the sun is a brutal, honest thing. It's going to tell us the truth about what we planted. And the truth is going to be that a lot of it had no root. That is unbearable to watch, and it is the most useful thing that could possibly happen to us. You cannot go down to the root until you admit you don't have one. The drought is what finally makes the admission impossible to dodge.

Waiting for a very different Benedict

There was a philosopher named Alasdair MacIntyre who ended a famous book in 1981 with an image the church has been chewing on ever since. It belongs to us more than it belonged to him, because he wasn't writing as a believer when he wrote it. He had spent the whole book, called *After Virtue*, arguing that the moral fabric of the West had come apart past the point of ordinary repair. We were living among the fragments of a moral language whose meaning we'd lost, he said, still arguing about good and evil with words we no longer had the framework to use. At the very end he turned to the question of what a person who saw this clearly ought to do, and he reached back, the way this whole book keeps reaching back, to the last time the West fell apart.

In the collapse of the Roman order, MacIntyre wrote, men and women of good will turned aside from the task of shoring up the imperium and instead set themselves to the construction of new forms of community within which the moral life could be sustained. What saved the moral and spiritual life of Europe was not the people who wore themselves out trying to prop up a dying empire. It was the ones who quietly built small communities where a whole way of life could be kept alive through the long night. And then came the sentence everyone remembers. We are waiting, he wrote, not for a Godot, but for

another, doubtless very different, Saint Benedict.

Sit with what he is and isn't saying, because it's easy to hear this as a call to retreat, and it isn't that. Benedict of Nursia, around the year 529, walked away from a Rome that was visibly finished and founded a monastery at Monte Cassino. He wrote a rule for common life so wise and so durable that communities are still living by it fifteen centuries later. Those communities became, without anyone planning it, the arteries the faith and the learning of the West flowed through across the dark centuries. MacIntyre is not telling the church to run. He's telling it to build. The strategy of the long night is not to hold the empire up. It's to build communities deep enough and thick enough to carry the true thing through the winter, the way the monasteries carried it through the last one. And he adds that crucial phrase, doubtless very different, because the new Benedict won't wear a habit or copy manuscripts by candlelight. The form will be strange to us. But the pattern is the same. Depth built to outlast collapse.

This is why formation has to replace reach as the church's central strategy, and it's the hinge of the whole chapter, so let me say it as plainly as I can. Under Christendom the goal could be reach, because belief was assumed, and the work was mostly getting people into a building the culture had already half filled for you. You didn't have to form them deeply, because the world was doing the forming, catechizing your people in a broadly Christian direction all week so the church only had to top up on Sunday what the culture had already poured in. After Christendom, reach without depth is worse than useless. It's a trap. You gather people into a shallow faith the secular age will evaporate by Thursday, and you count the gathering as success while the drought does its quiet work, and in the end you've produced a great crowd of rocky-ground plants, green in the

morning and gone by noon. The church that survives the drought will not be the one with the biggest room. It'll be the one that formed people deeply enough to stand when the room emptied out.

We are what we love, and liturgies form us

The reason formation is harder than reach, and the reason we underrated it so long, is that we misjudged what a human being is. We assumed, without quite saying it, that people are brains on legs. That they believe their way into the kingdom. That if you get the right information into their heads, the right life will follow. James K. A. Smith has spent a career telling us this is false, and that the church's whole approach to formation was built on the mistake. We are not first of all thinking things. We are first of all loving things. We are creatures of desire and habit, and our loves are shaped far more by what we do over and over, with our bodies, than by what we are told. The things we do over and over are liturgies, whether we call them that or not. A liturgy, in Smith's sense, is any ritual that aims your love at a picture of the good life and installs that picture below your conscious thought, so you come to want it without ever deciding to.

And the secular age, Smith insists, has liturgies of its own. They are catechizing us all day long whether we notice or not, and they are extraordinarily good at the work. The scroll is a liturgy. You pick up the glass rectangle a hundred times a day, and each time you run the same little ritual of thumb and glance and hunger, and the ritual is forming you. It's teaching your body that satisfaction is always one more swipe away, and that you are the center of a feed built entirely around you. The store is a liturgy, and Smith has famously read the shopping mall as a kind of cathedral, with its pictures of the good life in every window and

its promise that you are one purchase from becoming the person you were meant to be. The stadium is a liturgy, and so is the endless scroll of outrage that trains you to find yourself in what you're against. None of these announce themselves as formation. That's exactly their power. They feel like leisure, like convenience, like harmless habit, and the whole time they are reaching down past your thinking and bending your loves toward a good life with no God anywhere in it.

Once you see this, you can't unsee it, and it changes what the church is for. If we are formed by liturgies, and the secular age is running its liturgies on us every hour of every day, then a church that offers only information, a weekly download of correct beliefs into people who spend the other hundred and sixty-seven hours being formed by the store and the scroll, is bringing a pamphlet to an artillery duel. The only thing that forms a person deeply enough to stand against a rival liturgy is a stronger, truer, more beautiful liturgy of its own. A set of practices that reach past the thinking and bend the loves back toward God, repeated across years until they live in the body and not just the head. This is why recovering practice is not a matter of taste or nostalgia. It's a matter of survival. The church that will make deep disciples in a secular age is the one that recovers its own liturgies, its fixed-hour prayer and its Christian calendar and its fasting and its confession and its real Sabbath, and lets them do to its people what the mall and the feed are doing to everyone else. Only truer. And toward a better country.

A contrast society

Say the church does this. Say it stops chasing reach and gives itself to depth, forms disciples by practice and not just information, and slowly becomes a people with roots. What is such a people for? Here the New Testament gives an answer that

is not the one the American church usually gives, and the gap between the two explains a great deal about how weak we are right now. We tend to think the church exists to hand out religious goods and services to individuals, that it's a place you go to get your spiritual needs met, a vendor of meaning with a worship band, and that the community is just the delivery truck for the message. The New Testament thinks the community is the message. It is not the wrapper around the gospel. It is the gospel made visible.

A scholar named Gerhard Lohfink spent a book, called *Jesus and Community*, arguing this was the point all along. God has always worked by calling out a people whose common life would be a sign to the nations, and he gave that people a name worth keeping. A contrast society. Not a collection of individuals who each privately believe some religious things and happen to gather on Sundays, but a community whose shared life is so unlike the world around it that the life itself becomes the argument. Israel was called to be this and mostly failed at it. The church was born to be this. A people whose way of living together would be visibly, stubbornly different, so different that an outsider couldn't account for it by any of the usual explanations, and would have to ask where such a thing could possibly come from.

Jesus said the same thing more simply, on the last night of his life, when he told his friends what the world would use to know them. By this all people will know that you are my disciples, if you have love for one another. Not if you win the argument. Not if you take the culture. Not if you out-shout the rival tribe or capture the institutions or elect the right people. If you have love for one another, in a way the world can actually see and cannot copy, the world will know. He staked the whole credibility of the movement not on a position paper but on a visible quality of life

together. A love so concrete and so durable that a watching outsider could look at it the way that pagan in the plague years looked at the Christians nursing his fever, and ask the only question that finally matters. Where does that come from? I want to know the God who makes people live like that.

Now hear the indictment, because it's ours, and it's the sharpest thing I have to say in this chapter. The reason the contrast is so faint right now is that the church has mostly let the culture sort it into tribes exactly like all the other tribes. We have churches sorted by politics, where everyone votes the same way and the gospel has quietly become the chaplain of a party. We have churches sorted by class and by race and by age and by taste, each one a comfortable affinity group of people who were already alike. And an affinity group is the precise opposite of a contrast society, because there's no contrast in a room full of people the market would have gathered anyway. The world can assemble people who are already alike. It does it in its sleep, with an algorithm, for free. Only the gospel can assemble people who have nothing in common but Christ, the progressive and the conservative, the rich and the poor, the citizen and the stranger, and sit them at one table and make them family and have it be true. That room is a miracle. The affinity group is just demographics with a steeple. And a watching world already exhausted by its own tribes has no reason to look twice at ours.

The world can assemble people who are already alike. Only the gospel can assemble people who have nothing in common but Christ. That room, when it actually exists, is the most persuasive thing on earth.

Witness, not conquest

This is where the church has to break its oldest, deepest habit,

and I don't think we understand how deep it runs. Christendom trained us, over sixteen centuries, to change the world by holding the lever. It taught us to assume, so far down it feels like instinct instead of assumption, that the way you accomplish a Christian end is to get Christian hands on the law and the throne and the institutions and pull. We reach for the lever the way you reach for a railing in the dark, without thinking, sure it's there and sure it's the way to stay standing. And it's exactly the instinct the early church did not have. Could not have had. The lever was nowhere near its hands. The church that turned the ancient world upside down never once held the controls. It had one tool, and the New Testament has a word for it. The word is witness.

The Greek word is *martyria*, and you can hear our word martyr sitting inside it, which tells you right away what kind of tool it is. Witness is what you do when you cannot coerce. You cannot make the watching world believe. You cannot legislate the kingdom into a human heart or conquer your way to a conversion. So you do the only thing left to a people with no lever, which is to live the truth out loud and in public and let it cost you whatever it costs, and to trust God with the result. Witness is the weapon of the powerless. It is the only weapon Jesus ever actually authorized. And it is, by an enormous margin, the most effective one in the history of the world, because it converted an empire from the floor of a prison, with no army and no law and no throne, armed with nothing but a way of dying the empire could not explain.

And here is the irony the church has never fully faced, the trade at the center of our long confusion. The day we got the lever, we started to lose the witness. When Constantine handed the church the empire in the fourth century it looked like the greatest victory imaginable, and it brought some real goods, and I won't pretend

otherwise. But it also began a long, slow exchange that thinkers from Yoder to Stanley Hauerwas have called the Constantinian shift, and the heart of the exchange was this. A church that could now command obedience slowly forgot how to compel by love. Why out-die an empire that's now yours to run? Why win the slow way, by witness, when you can win the fast way, by decree? So the muscle of witness, the one that had carried the church for three unbroken centuries, started to waste away the very moment the lever came within reach. It has been weak ever since, because a church with its hand on the controls never has to build it. We traded the strength that had converted Rome for the strength Rome already knew, and we called the trade a triumph. We've been slowly finding out the real price for seventeen hundred years.

Lesslie Newbigin, who had watched the church lose its grip on the West and had thought harder about it than almost anyone, asked the essential question and gave the answer that ought to be framed in every church that's frightened of the future. How is it possible, he asked, that the gospel should be credible, that people should come to believe that the power which has the last word in human affairs is represented by a man hanging on a cross? How does a claim that absurd on its face ever become believable to a watching world? And his answer was disarmingly simple and enormously demanding. I am suggesting, he wrote, that the only answer, the only hermeneutic of the gospel, is a congregation of men and women who believe it and live by it. A hermeneutic is the thing that makes a text readable, the lens a message can finally be understood through. Newbigin is saying the only lens the world will ever read the gospel through is the life of a community that embodies it. Not the billboard. Not the law. Not the election, and not the platform. The congregation, living the thing, in front of the neighbors, is the argument. There is no

other translation of the gospel the world is able to read.

The imagination we lost

There's a kind of poverty that comes from traveling light too long, and the church has it bad, and it's the last thing I want to name before I hand you to the end of this book. For centuries the culture carried the Christian memory for us, the calendar and the stories and the assumed furniture of a Christian imagination. Like anyone who lets somebody else hold the heavy things, we forgot how heavy they were and eventually forgot we owned them at all. Now the culture has set the bags down, and we've reached for our inheritance, and found ourselves poor. We're holding a faith stripped down to a few slogans and a worship set, with two thousand years of accumulated depth sitting in a storehouse we've forgotten how to walk into. Charles Taylor has a name for what the modern condition has done to us. We have become buffered selves, he says. Sealed off, insulated, where our ancestors were porous selves, open at every point to a world they felt was charged with God and meaning and presence. We live now inside what he calls the immanent frame, a world felt as closed and flat and disenchanted, a universe of matter and mechanism with the transcendent pushed out to the edges or out of the picture entirely. And Smith reminds us this is the air all of us breathe now, believer as much as unbeliever, so even our faith has gone thin. We believe in God the way you believe a fact, instead of dwelling in him the way the saints did, in a world lit from the inside by his presence.

You cannot argue your way back into a full world. You have to be re-formed into it, and the practices are how the re-formation happens, and they are exactly what Christendom let us set down. The church spent two thousand years developing a technology of the soul, a whole architecture of practice built to take an ordinary

person and slowly form them into someone who can see and live in the real world, the one with God in it. So the way back runs backward, into what the church has long called the Great Tradition, into the company of the dead. C. S. Lewis warned about chronological snobbery, the unexamined assumption that whatever is newer must be wiser, that the past has nothing to teach the present but its mistakes. G. K. Chesterton called the cure the democracy of the dead, tradition understood as the refusal to let the small, arrogant aristocracy of those who merely happen to be walking around right now outvote the vast company of the faithful who came before. After Christendom, the church cannot afford chronological snobbery one more day. We are too thin, too new, too thoroughly formed by the very age we're trying to resist, to survive on our own shallow resources. We have to go back and drink from the deep wells, Augustine and the desert mothers and fathers and the medieval mystics and the Reformers and the long unbroken line of the faithful. Not out of nostalgia. Out of thirst. Because they were not buffered and we are, and they have something we have lost and desperately need.

None of this is escape, and none of it is antiquarianism. It's the opposite. A person formed by these old practices is not less able to face the post-Christian world but far more, because they are no longer a thin modern self trying to hold a few facts against the whole crushing weight of a disenchanted age. They are a deep and rooted creature who actually lives in the real world, the enchanted one, the world the secular age has trained everyone else to disbelieve. And a rooted creature is the one thing a drought cannot kill. That is the imagination we lost. And it is, whether the world has words for the hunger or not, the very thing the world is quietly starving for. The buffered self is exhausted and doesn't know why. The church holds the answer in its own storehouse, has held it the entire time, and the long slow work of

the years ahead is in large part the work of going back inside and bringing it out.

So the whole strategy of the long after comes down to the sentence I started with, and I can say it now with the weight of the argument behind it. Not stronger tribes. Deeper disciples. Not the biggest room but the deepest roots. Not the lever but the witness. Not an affinity group the market could have gathered but a contrast society only the resurrection can explain. This is slower than politics and quieter than a campaign, and it does not photograph well, and it is the only thing that has ever actually worked, because it is the thing the church was doing on the morning the empire that had presided over its funeral discovered it was still alive. And that leaves one last question, the one this book has been walking toward from its first page. What holds a people to a work this slow, a work whose harvest they will not live to see, whose finish belongs to God and to generations not yet born? Only a promise could hold anyone to that. And there is a promise, made not to an empire but to a powerless few standing in the shadow of a pagan rock, that has outlived every empire since. It is to that promise, and to the people who will carry it into the long after, that we turn last.

Chapter 18: A People for the Long After

I want to end this book by telling you the truth about the clock. Almost everything that goes wrong in the church right now goes wrong because we are in a hurry, and the people of God were never a people in a hurry. So let me say the hard thing first, the way Jeremiah said it first. You and I are not going to see the end of this. The recovery of a deep, faithful, post-Christendom church is not a project we finish. It's not a problem we solve in a program cycle, or a campaign, or an election, or a lifetime. We are early in something long. We are the first wave of exiles, the ones who got off the road in 597 BC with the ash of Jerusalem still in our clothes, standing in a foreign city with our whole world behind us and a letter in our hands that just told us the number. Seventy years. We are near the front of it. We will die near the front of it. And the sooner we make our peace with that, the sooner we can stop reaching for the fast and ruinous answers. Because the fast answers, every one of them, are the answers of people who cannot bear to wait.

Go back to the letter one last time, to the number the false prophet could never stand to say. "When seventy years are completed for Babylon," God tells them, "I will visit you, and I will fulfill to you my promise and bring you back to this place." Seventy years. Not the two short years Hananiah was selling in the temple, with the bright confidence of a man who has never once been wrong on purpose. Not a disruption to be endured with the bags by the door. A lifetime. In the ancient world, that was the far edge of a human span, a number so long that nearly

everyone who first heard the letter read aloud would die in Babylon. Their children would grow old in Babylon. Only their grandchildren would walk the road home. This is the arithmetic the take-it-back crowd cannot do. It's the arithmetic the give-it-up crowd never bothers to. And it's the arithmetic every faithful exile in history has had to learn by heart. The work is longer than you are. You will pour out your one life on something you will not see finished. That is not the failure of the work. That is its actual shape, among a people whose God has always thought in generations and never in news cycles.

So here is what the seventy years asks of us first, before build or plant or seek or pray. It asks whether we can plant a garden whose fruit we will not gather. That's the whole test. And it's harder than any of the courage the martyr stories ask of us, because courage can be summoned in a moment and this cannot. This has to be lived across decades of apparent nothing. Think of the monks in the centuries after Rome fell, copying the Scriptures by hand in the cold, line after line, page after page, in rooms lit by tallow while the roads outside grew over and the aqueducts cracked and the old order came apart. None of them lived to see the civilization their patience would one day seed. They did not copy because they could see the harvest. They couldn't see the harvest. They copied because the word was true and the work was theirs and the seeing was God's business, not theirs. Think of the masons who laid the foundation stones of a cathedral that would take a hundred and fifty years to raise. They quarried and set and carved knowing they'd be dead a century before the spire went up, that they would never once kneel in the finished thing their own hands had begun. They built anyway. That is gardening on the scale of centuries. That is what the seventy years requires. And it is exactly what our age has trained out of us, because we are a people of the launch and the metric

and the quarter, and we have dragged all of it into the life of faith. We want revival by next year. A recovered culture by the next election. Our own sanctification on a schedule we can watch. We plant nothing slow, because nothing slow shows up in the numbers. And then we wonder why the church feels so frantic and so shallow and so perpetually let down by a God who keeps refusing to hurry.

I feel the rebuke of this in my own chest, and I won't pretend I stand outside it. I'm a man of my age. I'm formed by its impatience, hooked on its measurements, wanting to see the fruit of my work in my own lifetime and ideally this year. I have measured faithfulness by what I could see, the way the world measures everything, and the seventy years stands over all of it and says, gently and without moving, no. That is not how my kingdom keeps time. I did that. I have wanted to be the generation that wins, the one that gets to stand in the victory. And that want, however righteous it dressed itself up, was the take-it-back error wearing the clothes of zeal. Because underneath the anger and the activism, the whole demand to restore Christendom by force is a refusal to accept the number. It's the insistence on seeing the harvest in my own lifetime. That demand has never once, in the entire history of the people of God, produced anything but false prophets and broken people. You cannot do multigenerational faithfulness while requiring a one-generation payoff. The seventy years is God's gentle and devastating refusal of our hurry. It tells us the work is longer than we are. And a people who can accept that become the only kind of people who have ever built anything that lasted.

I need to separate this carefully from despair, because the prophet of the seventy years is not the prophet of decline, and from a distance they are easy to confuse. He is not telling the

exiles it's over. He is telling them it's long, which is a completely different word, facing a completely different direction. Decline faces down, toward the grave, and gives up. Nostalgia faces backward, toward the lost country, the old arrangement, the Jerusalem that was, and it spends the whole exile aching for a return to the past that isn't coming. Biblical hope faces forward, toward the thing God is doing next, the city he is building, the return that is also an advance. The exile eaten by nostalgia will waste the seventy years grieving a country that is gone. The exile with biblical hope will spend them building, because he knows the God who sent him here has gone on ahead of him, and that the future, not the past, is where the promise actually lives. The whole difference between a bitter exile and a faithful one is which way he is facing while he waits.

We are not the generation that brings in the harvest. We are the generation that plants the trees. We call that faithfulness, and we leave the fruit to God and to faces we will never see.

Now I want to set the seventy years beside the other promise, the one from the New Testament that the frightened church loves to quote and almost never reads for who it was spoken to. Jesus stood with his disciples at Caesarea Philippi, and it matters enormously where he was standing, because we have sanded that off too. Caesarea Philippi sat at the foot of a great rock face at the northern edge of the land. That rock was carved full of niches for the shrines of other gods, a whole cliff of pagan worship, and at its base was a deep cave the ancients called the gate of the underworld, the mouth of hell itself, where they believed the dead went down. Jesus took his little band to that exact spot, under that exact cliff, in the shadow of that exact cave. And it was there, with the shrines of the nations at his back and the

mouth of the underworld at his feet, that he made the promise. "On this rock I will build my church, and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it." Notice who heard it. Not an empire. Not a majority. Not a movement with a budget and a building and the deference of the culture. A dozen confused men, most of them fishermen, standing in a pagan district under a rock face bristling with other people's gods. A tiny powerless band with nothing to its name. To that little group, in that place, he said the gates of hell would not hold against them. The promise was never attached to our dominance. It was never attached to Christendom. It was attached to him, and to the strange deathless thing he was starting from underneath. And that thing has now outlived every single empire that ever presided over its funeral. Rome buried it. Rome is gone. It will outlive this one too.

We forget the scale of what that little band went on to do with no power at all. We forget it precisely because we've been taught to measure the church by the power it lost. So let me set the account straight, because this is the whole ground of the hope I'm offering you. The most explosive growth in the entire history of Christianity happened when the church had no political standing whatsoever. Not a little. None. It was illegal. It was slandered with the ugliest rumors an empire could invent. It was hunted in waves, its members burned and fed to animals for the amusement of crowds. And across three centuries of that, it went from a few thousand followers of an executed Galilean to something close to half the Roman world. The sociologist Rodney Stark sat down and ran the arithmetic, and it does not require any miracle of mass conversion to explain. It requires a steady growth rate of around forty percent a decade, the ordinary rate of a vigorous new movement, held for nearly three hundred years. The only question worth asking is why. Why did this odd, powerless, hated minority keep growing through the worst the

empire could throw at it, when by every worldly measure it should have been stamped out a dozen times over? The answer is not the one we want. It's not strategy and not platform and not cultural power, because they had none of it. The answer is that they lived in a way the empire could not explain.

When the great plagues came, the one under the Antonines in the 160s and the one that still carries Cyprian's name in the 250s, the cities filled with the dying and the smell of the dead. The pagan response was the rational, ancient one. You fled. You left the sick by the road, even your own, and you got out, because to stay was to die. The Christians stayed. They nursed the sick, their own and their pagan neighbors alike, at appalling cost to themselves, because they served a Lord who had touched lepers and because they did not finally believe death was the end of the story. A nursed body sometimes lives. And a pagan nursed back from the edge by a Christian who had no earthly reason on earth to sit at his bed does not forget who sat there. It went further than the plagues. In a world that carried unwanted infants out to the hillside to die of exposure, most of them the girls, the Christians went out and gathered them up and raised them as their own. In a world that treated women as property, the church gave them honor, gave the widow a place, gave marriage a dignity it had never had. In a world sorted ruthlessly by blood and rank, the church sat the slave and the master at one table and called them brothers and meant it. Some unknown Christian wrote a letter to a puzzled pagan named Diognetus in the second century, and he put it exactly. Christians live in their own countries, but only as sojourners. Every foreign land is their homeland, and every homeland a foreign land. They are in the flesh, but they do not live according to the flesh. They are the soul of the world. And Tertullian, writing around the year 200 while the persecutions were still on and the blood was still wet, threw a line at the

empire that has never lost its edge. The blood of the martyrs, he said, is seed. He meant it as a taunt and a fact at once. Every time you kill us, more of us appear, because the watching world cannot stop asking what a man could possibly have that would let him die like that, without hatred and without fear.

That is the church we are being handed back. That is the address we are going home to. We have spent so long grieving the power we lost that we forgot the power was the very thing the church did not have and did not need the first time around. A church that could not coerce had to convert. A church that could not buy loyalty had to earn it. A church that could not summon the magistrate had to summon nothing but the witness of its own astonishing life, and that witness turned out to be the most persuasive argument the ancient world had ever met. This is why I keep insisting, against every panicked instinct in us, that the exile is not the church's emergency. It's the church's native condition. Christendom was the exception. Sixteen hundred years of a holiday from our actual address. The holiday is over, and we are simply going home to the strange country we always lived in. The apostles assumed it as plainly as they assumed the sunrise. Peter opened his first letter to the scattered Christians of Asia Minor by calling them "elect exiles of the Dispersion." Chosen, and strangers, in the same breath. And the writer of Hebrews said it with a kind of ache that ought to reframe every anxiety we carry about the country. "These all died in faith," he wrote of the patriarchs, "not having received the things promised, but having seen them and greeted them from afar, and having acknowledged that they were strangers and exiles on the earth." And then, plainer still. "Here we have no lasting city, but we seek the city that is to come." That is our passport, and it always was. We only forgot it for as long as the culture let us feel at home. And feeling at home is the one thing the New

Testament never once promised us.

There's a man I keep coming back to when the ground feels like it's giving way, because he watched a whole world end and did not lose his faith in the ending. His composure is the composure I want for the church in the long after. In the year 410 the impossible happened. Alaric and the Goths came over the walls and sacked the city of Rome, and the civilized world went into shock, the way you go into shock when a parent dies, even an old and failing parent, because some part of you had quietly believed they'd always be there. Rome was the eternal city. Rome was eleven hundred years old. Rome had been, for thirty years now, a Christian empire, ever since Theodosius made the faith official in 380. And it fell, to barbarians, in three days of fire. Out of the grief came the accusation. This is your fault. Rome was strong when Rome honored the old gods, and you Christians talked her out of them, and now the barbarians are in the forum and it is on your heads. The harder grief, the one we forget, was inside the church. Among Christians who had come to believe that a baptized Rome was the point, that God had crowned history with a Christian empire, and who now watched the permanent thing burn and felt their faith buckle. Because if Christian Rome could fall, then what exactly had God promised, and what exactly were they standing on? Into that double grief an aging bishop in North Africa sat down and spent thirteen years writing the book that should be the constitution of every Christian living after Christendom. There are two cities, Augustine said, and they have been tangled together since the beginning, and they are built by two loves. The earthly city is built by the love of self, reaching all the way to contempt of God. The heavenly city is built by the love of God, reaching all the way to contempt of self. Rome was the earthly city. Rome was always the earthly city. Rome was never for one single day the City of God, not even when it flew

the cross over the legions. So the fall of Rome is not the fall of the kingdom, because the two were never the same thing to begin with. He pried apart with both hands the exact fusion we have made, and he made them look at the difference while the ash was still falling.

There's a detail at the very end of his life I can't get out of my head, and I'll hand it to you here at the end of the book because it carries the whole weight of what I'm trying to say. As Augustine lay dying in the year 430, the Vandals were at the gates of his own city, Hippo, besieging it. The world he had spent his life defending was visibly coming apart around his deathbed. The barbarians were not a theory or a forecast. They were outside the wall, within sight of his window. And this man died in peace, with the enemy in view, because he had spent thirteen years teaching himself and everyone who would listen that his city, his real city, was not the one under siege. That is the freedom on offer to us in the long after. Not the freedom of a church that wins. The freedom of a church that has stopped confusing the burning empire with the indestructible kingdom, and can therefore watch the smoke without despair, and get back to the work of loving the God whose city has no walls that any Alaric can breach. Learn that difference now, while it is only your country shaking. Learn it now, and you will not lose your faith when it finally gives way.

So this is the charge, and it's enormous, and it's the whole book gathered into a handful of imperatives. Be the church. Be the contrast society in a culture of lonely tribes, the room where people who have nothing in common but Christ sit at one table and call each other family, which is a miracle the market can never reproduce and the affinity group can only counterfeit. Be the deep disciples in the age of the inch-deep, the people with

roots that were put down long before the sky turned to brass, because the drought does not create shallow faith. It only exposes it. The only thing that has ever lived through a drought is depth. Be the witnesses who have set down the lever and picked up the cross, who have finally understood that a church which cannot coerce must persuade, and a church which cannot legislate must love, and a church which cannot conquer must witness, and bleed if it comes to that, and trust God with an outcome it can no longer manufacture. Be the elect exiles who seek the welfare of the city without ever bowing to its gods. Be Daniel and not his inversion, serving Babylon to the hilt and worshiping it with nothing, keeping the windows open toward the true city and taking the lions as the price. None of that requires the water to come back. All of it is available to a church with no power at all, which is the only kind of church that has ever actually changed anything. We did not need Christendom to be the church before it existed. We do not need it back to be the church now that it is gone.

In Its Welfare, Your Welfare

We began this whole book with a verse on a coffee mug, and it's time to give it back its full weight, because the entire letter has been quietly building toward it and we have spent twenty-five centuries reading it with the load-bearing wall knocked out. "For I know the plans I have for you, declares the Lord, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope." We have read that as a private promise of personal good fortune, a guarantee that my particular dreams are about to come true. And in reading it that way, we missed the single most important word in the sentence. The word translated welfare is shalom. And it's the same word, shalom, that stands three verses earlier, in the command we have circled through this entire book. "Seek the

welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile... for in its welfare you will find your welfare." Shalom in the seventh verse. Shalom in the eleventh. The very same Hebrew word, laid down twice, four verses apart, by a writer who chose it on purpose. This is not a coincidence, and it was never a coffee mug. The shalom God plans to give you in the eleventh verse is bound, by the deliberate repeat of one word, to the shalom he commands you to seek for the city in the seventh. Your welfare and the city's welfare are the same welfare. He said it twice, with the same word, so we could not finally pull them apart. And we pulled them apart anyway. We framed the second half over the fireplace and let the first half fall on the floor.

Hear the word at its full strength, because the whole promise turns on it and we have shrunk it to almost nothing. Shalom is not the thin thing we've reduced it to. Not mere quiet. Not the absence of trouble. Not a private inner calm you buy with a devotional and a candle. It is wholeness. It is flourishing. It is the way things are supposed to be when they are finally right. A city has shalom when the hungry are fed and the worker is paid fairly and the stranger is safe and the sick are tended and the weak are not crushed under the strong and the neighbors know one another's names. That is the thing God commands the exiles to seek, not for Jerusalem, which is gone, but for Babylon, the very empire that burned the temple and dragged them there in chains. And that is the thing God promises them in return, so tightly bound to the first that you cannot receive the one without spending yourself on the other. This is the whole letter, and the whole of this book, gathered into a single sentence. The plans God has for your good are not a promise that he will lift you out of Babylon into a private prosperity of your own. They are the promise that as you seek the good of the city he planted you in, you will find your own good waiting there, hidden inside the

welfare of the place you were sent to bless. You will not find your shalom by hoarding it behind a wall, or by keeping your bags by the door for a rescue that is seventy years away, or by dissolving into Babylon until there's no self left to flourish. You will find it exactly where the letter said you would. In its welfare, your welfare. Nowhere else. It was never anywhere else.

So this is finally what it means to live well, and it is why the whole of this book has insisted, against every other definition on offer, that the good life is not the one the culture is selling. To live well is not to escape the exile. It is not to end it early by force. And it is not to make a comfortable peace with it by surrender. To live well is to seek the welfare of the city where God has sent you, because in its welfare you will find your own. That is not an abstraction. It's a set of ordinary verbs, six of them, that this book has walked through one at a time, and now I want to gather them into the single life they were always meant to be. Build the house, and live in it, and stop holding your real life in reserve for a better place that is always just ahead. Plant the garden you may not harvest, and then sit down and eat its fruit with thanks, because the God of exile sets a table even here. Take a wife, and raise children who know a truer story than the one Babylon is telling them, and do not let the line thin out in despair, because a conquered people that stops believing in a next generation has already died. Seek the flourishing of the poor and the stranger on your own street, the neighbor Babylon forgot how to be, because the shalom of a city is always measured first at its margins. Pray for the city, by name, day after day, until the praying has quietly taken your bitterness apart from the inside and you find, to your own surprise, that you have come to love it. And keep your windows open toward the true city, and when Babylon asks for the one thing that belongs to God alone, do not bow. Build. Plant. Marry. Seek. Pray. And do not bow. Six verbs,

held together across one lifetime. That is not a strategy for surviving until the good life resumes somewhere else. That is the good life. It always was.

I am not going to end this book by promising you the exile is nearly over, because Jeremiah did not, and every prophet who has ever promised a short exile has turned out, without exception, to be lying. The number is still seventy years. It is still a lifetime. You and I will very likely die in Babylon, with the gardens we planted still years from their fruit, and the recovery of a deep and faithful church still unfinished in our hands, and our grandchildren, not us, walking whatever road home God is preparing. I want you to feel the weight of that and not have it lifted, because a false comfort at the end of a true book would betray everything the book was for. But hear the thing the number does not cancel, the thing that stands underneath it and holds it up. The God who wrote the letter did not send his people into exile and then withdraw to wait for them at the border. He went with them. He went into Babylon, into the fiery furnace where the three would not bow and a fourth figure walked with them in the flames, into the lions' den where Daniel kept the windows open, into the long captivity and the strange centuries, present in exile as surely as he had ever been present in the temple, and more so, because now there was no building to mistake for him. He is with his exiles still. In the houses and the gardens and the marriages and the ordinary prayers. In the daily, unglamorous, unphotographed labor for the welfare of a city that does not yet know his name.

This is the last thing, and it's the thing I most want you to carry out of this book, because it overturns the whole way we've been taught to think about the days we are living in. We have treated the exile as the interruption. The parenthesis. The hard stretch to

be endured until the good life resumes on the far side of the return. It is not. For the people of God, the exile has nearly always been the place where the good life is finally learned. It was in Babylon, not Jerusalem, that Israel gathered the Scriptures and built the synagogue and hammered out a portable, durable, unkillable faith that could survive anywhere on earth, because it was no longer propped up by a temple and a land and the assumption of the culture. The exile did not suspend Israel's faith. It forged it. It stripped the faith of its scaffolding and drove it down, past the borrowed power and the easy respectability and the comfortable water, all the way to the rock, until there was nothing left to stand on but God, and the people found out that God had been the only thing holding them up the entire time. That is the gift buried inside the loss we've been grieving. That is why the drained room where cultural Christianity used to stand is not a tomb but a beginning. The water was never the point. He was. He is. He will be, long after the last of the scaffolding has come down and the building, his building, is still standing in the morning light.

So build your house. Plant your garden. Take a wife, raise your children, seek the welfare of the city, pray for its peace, and keep the windows open. Do not wait for Babylon to become Jerusalem, and do not pretend that it already has. Live, fully and faithfully and without fear, in the city you did not choose, for the sake of a God the city does not yet know, and trust him with the seventy years and with the homecoming at the end of them that you may not live to see. Seek the welfare of the city. And in its welfare, exactly where the letter promised it would be, hidden all along inside the good of the place you were sent to bless, you will find your own.